



THE NATIONAL GUIDE

Moving to Australia

*A new role, a different pace of life and
somewhere new to call home.*

Ethicare Resourcing

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ethicareresourcing.com

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This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.



AUSTRALIA

An ancient land with an easy, open welcome

Getting to know Australia

Before it's a job or a visa, Australia is a place, with its own land, a very long history and an easy way of living.



Kettle on. A longer read – about 9 min

~26.6m

People

on a single continent

6 + 2

States & territories

each with its own feel

200+

Languages spoken

one of the most multicultural nations

65,000+

Years of culture

the world's oldest, still living

A FIRST IMPRESSION

A vast country with an easy warmth

Australia is the world's largest island and its smallest continent, roughly the size of mainland Europe, home to around twenty-six million people. Nearly all of them live around the coastal edge.

What strikes most newcomers first is the ease of it. The light is bright, the days are outdoors, and people are relaxed, direct and quick to include you. Underneath that easygoing surface sit two things worth understanding early: a First Nations culture tens of thousands of years old, and a modern nation built by people from every corner of the world. You'll feel both, often in the same day.

You don't need to know any of this before you arrive, but a little understanding goes a long way. **The people who settle most happily are those who come curious**, ready to learn the land's stories and customs rather than expecting it to be just like home.

THE LAND

One continent, many worlds

Australia is big enough to hold the tropics, the desert and cool green coastlines all at once. Where you settle shapes your whole experience of it, and there is far more choice than most people expect.

Where life happens

The coastal crescent

Most Australians live on the eastern and southern coasts: Sydney, Melbourne, Brisbane, Adelaide and Perth. Big, easy cities where the beach, the café and the office are rarely far apart.

The interior

The Outback & Red Centre

Beyond the cities lies the vast interior: red earth, endless sky and sacred places like Uluru. Remote, spectacular, and central to how Australia sees itself.

The climate

Sunshine & reversed seasons

From the tropical north to the temperate south, it's a sunlit country, and its seasons are flipped from the northern hemisphere. Summer runs December to February; Christmas is a beach day.

A SHORT HISTORY

How Australia came to be

Australia holds two very different timescales at once, a human story that is one of the oldest on earth, and a nation that is remarkably young.

65,000+ yrs ago

The First Australians

Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples have lived on this land for more than sixty-five thousand years, the world's oldest continuous living cultures, with hundreds of distinct nations, languages and deep connection to Country.

1770 & 1788

British arrival

James Cook charted the east coast in 1770; in 1788 the First Fleet established a British colony at Sydney Cove. What followed was profound and often painful upheaval for First Nations peoples, a history the country continues to reckon with honestly.

1901

Federation

Six self-governing British colonies united to form the Commonwealth of Australia, one nation, one Parliament, and the states and territories you'll recognise today.

1967

The referendum

More than ninety per cent of Australians voted to count Aboriginal people in the census and allow national laws for them, a landmark moment in a long journey toward recognition and equality.

1992

Mabo & native title

The High Court recognised that Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples held rights to their land before colonisation, overturning the idea that Australia had belonged to no one, a turning point in law and national understanding.

1970s–today

A modern, multicultural nation

The end of restrictive immigration policy opened Australia to the world, and waves of migration made it one of the most diverse societies on earth. In 2008 the nation formally apologised to the Stolen Generations, and the work of reconciliation continues today.

THE OLDEST LIVING CULTURE ON EARTH

First Nations Australia

Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples have cared for this continent for more than sixty-five thousand years. Australia has no national treaty; the relationship is expressed through recognition, custom and an ongoing process of reconciliation.

You'll hear it often

Acknowledgement of Country

Meetings, events and school assemblies frequently open by acknowledging the Traditional Owners of the land. A Welcome to Country is a similar ceremony offered by Traditional Owners themselves.

A different worldview

Connection to Country

For First Nations peoples, land, kinship, language and identity are woven together as "Country", a living relationship of care, not ownership, across some 250 language groups.

The work continues

Reconciliation & Closing the Gap

A national effort to heal historic wrongs and close the gap in health, education and life outcomes, including, very directly, in the health system you'll work in.

This is a live and sometimes complex national conversation, in 2023 a referendum on an Indigenous Voice to Parliament did not pass, and questions of treaty and recognition remain open. For healthcare workers it matters in practice: the system places real emphasis on culturally safe care and on better outcomes for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people, and you'll see that reflected in policy, training and everyday practice. You don't need to be an expert, an open, respectful willingness to understand is exactly what's hoped for.

AUSSIE ENGLISH

A few words you'll hear every day

English is the everyday language, though Australians shorten almost everything. None of it takes long to pick up, and a few of them are one of the quicker ways people find their feet.

ArvoAfternoon: "see you this arvo".

BrekkieBreakfast, often eaten out, at a café.

ServoA petrol (service) station.

Bottle-oThe bottle shop, where you buy alcohol.

ChemistThe pharmacy, where you fill a script.

DoonaA duvet or quilt for the bed.

ThongsFlip-flops: footwear, not underwear!

HeapsLots, or very: "heaps good", "thanks heaps".

No worriesYou're welcome, it's fine, the national motto.

EskyA cool box for keeping drinks and food cold.

UteA utility vehicle, a pick-up truck.

SnagA sausage, the star of any "barbie" (barbecue).

Many Australian place names come from Aboriginal languages, Canberra, Wollongong, Parramatta, Bendigo, so it's worth learning to say where you live correctly. Getting it right is warmly appreciated, and locals are happy to help.

PEOPLE & CULTURE

What Australians are like

Generalisations only go so far, but a few cultural threads come up again and again, and they tend to make settling in easier than newcomers expect.

Mateship

Welcoming

Loyalty and looking out for one another run deep. Neighbours, colleagues and other families who've made the move tend to fold you in quickly: many newcomers are surprised how at home they feel within months.

The great outdoors

A life lived outside

Weekends are for the beach, the bush, the backyard barbecue or the footy. Sunshine and the coast are woven into ordinary life, and an easy, shared way to make friends and feel you belong.

A fair go

Egalitarian & informal

Hierarchy is downplayed and first names are the norm, even at work. People value fairness, humility and not taking yourself too seriously. Everyone, in the Australian ideal, deserves "a fair go".

Many cultures, one home

Diverse & multicultural

Nearly half of all Australians were born overseas or have a parent who was. Large communities from every continent mean you'll rarely be the only one who has come from somewhere else.

A note on the everyday

Life here is comfortable and modern, but more relaxed and more spread out than many are used to: cities are low-rise and car-friendly, coffee is taken seriously, and sport is a shared language. For most people that easy, outdoor rhythm is precisely the appeal, and it's one our clinicians rarely regret.

Sophie's insight

When we began working in Australia, the thing that struck me most was how easily people made room for us. Say yes to the barbecue and the early swim. Learn to acknowledge the Country you're standing on, and to say your town's name the way the locals do. None of it is hard, and all of it tells Australia you've come to belong, not just to work. That openness, more than the sunshine, is what turns a posting into a home.

SophieCEO & Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

COMMON QUESTIONS

The things people ask us first

Will I understand the accent and all the slang?–

Very quickly, yes. English is the everyday working language, so you'll never be stuck, the accent and the habit of shortening words just take a week or two to tune into. Picking up a few local expressions is a lovely, easy way to show you've settled in, and colleagues will happily translate anything that catches you out at first.

How should I engage with First Nations culture respectfully?+

Is Australia very different culturally from home?+

Will my family fit in?+

— KEEP EXPLORING

Related guides

— YOUR AUSTRALIA JOURNEY

Is Australia right for me and my family?

Before the visas and job offers, the bigger question: could you build a good life here? An honest look at the joys and the trade-offs.

— PAGE AT A GLANCE

1. [A life decision first](#)
2. [What you're weighing up](#)
3. [A whole-family decision](#)
4. [The honest trade-offs](#)
5. [Is this your move?](#)
6. [Common questions](#)

Kettle on. A longer read — about 9 min

— MAKE IT YOURS

Turn this guide into your own checklist

This guide covers everything about moving to Australia. Answer two questions, where you're considering, and who's actually moving, and we'll build the checklist that applies to your household, with your ticks and notes saved in your browser.



— START WITH THE HONEST QUESTION

This is a life decision first, and a career decision second

Almost everyone we work with starts here, long before registration or jobs: wondering whether life could be bigger somewhere with more sun, more space and more time. Clinicians come to us from the UK, South Africa, Ireland, the UAE and beyond, and the first question is always the same human one.

So let's take the pressure off. You don't need to decide anything today. The goal of this first step is to help you picture the life honestly: what a normal week might feel like, what your children's days could look like, what you'd gain, and what you'd be leaving behind. The clearer that picture, the easier every decision after it becomes.

At Ethicare, we always say the same thing: **the people who settle best are the ones who moved with their eyes open**. They knew why they were coming, and they knew what they were trading. That's all this step is really about.

WHAT YOU'RE REALLY WEIGHING UP

The things people tell us mattered most

Few people move to Australia for the salary alone. These are the things healthcare professionals say they were actually weighing up, and the things they value most once they've arrived.

Climate

Sun & the outdoors

Warm weather and a coastline woven into everyday life, not just the holidays. For many, the early swim, the weekend at the beach and the long light evenings become the parts of the week they protect most.

Children

A good place to raise a family

Safe communities, strong schools and easy access to parks, sport and the outdoors are, again and again, the reasons families decide to stay. Childhood here tends to involve a lot of being outside.

Career

Room to grow

A large, modern health system across public and private care, with genuine room to develop, specialise and move. The scale of the country means real choice over where and how you work.

Mobility

One country, many lives

From a harbour city to a regional town, a national registration that travels with you means you can change pace or place without starting your paperwork over.

Honesty

Cost of living, told straight

Australia isn't a cheap country, and housing in Sydney and Melbourne is the part that surprises people most. Pay is fair, but it pays to plan around real numbers rather than hope.

Belonging

Community & welcome

Australia is one of the most multicultural countries on earth, so most newcomers find a community that already feels familiar, and colleagues and neighbours who fold them in quickly.

MORE THAN YOUR MOVE

A decision for the whole family

With a partner or children this is not your decision alone, and the families who settle best tend to be the ones who made it together. The questions worth talking through early, around your own kitchen table.

Your partner's work & world

Will they be able to work here, and would they want to? Many partner and skilled visas allow open work rights. Just as important is whether they'll find their own footing: friends, purpose, a routine that's theirs.

Your children, at their age

A four-year-old and a fourteen-year-old experience a move very differently. Younger children usually settle fast; teenagers may need more time and more say. Schooling is generally welcoming and easy to access.

The people you'd leave

Distance from grandparents and old friends is the hardest part for most families, and it's worth naming honestly. It doesn't have to be a dealbreaker, but it should be part of the conversation, not a surprise later.

Sophie's insight

I won't pretend an international move is a fairy tale. There are days the distance from home is hard, and it's right to weigh that honestly. But what I'd say to anyone considering Australia is this: don't wait to feel completely certain, because nobody does. Picture the ordinary days, not just the highlights, the school run, the weekend, the quiet Tuesday, and ask whether that life feels like yours. If it does, the rest is just steps, and you won't be taking them alone.

SophieCEO & Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

THE HONEST PART

The trade-offs worth knowing

A move this big always costs something. None of these are reasons not to come, but knowing them now is how you avoid being caught off guard later.

1

It's a long way from home

Flights back are long and not cheap. For close families, the distance is the thing that takes most getting used to. Plan for how you'll stay connected.

2

Big-city housing is expensive

Especially in Sydney and Melbourne. Rent and house prices surprise many newcomers, so it's worth modelling your real budget before you fall in love with a postcode.

3

You're starting over, socially

New colleagues, new systems, new admin. Most people find their feet within a few months, but the first stretch asks for patience and a bit of courage.

4

The paperwork takes time

Registration, skills assessment and visas take time to line up. It's all very doable, it just rewards starting early and not rushing the big decisions.

FROM EXPERIENCE

What often surprises people

The things newcomers mention again and again: observations, not sales pitches.

-

How much you're outdoors

The coast, the parks and the climate mean being outside becomes a normal part of the week, not a special occasion.

-

How big the country is

States are vast and varied, a move interstate can feel like a different country, which is part of the appeal.

-

How multicultural it is

Most newcomers find an established community from home already here, which makes the early months far easier.

-

How team-based care feels

A relatively flat, collaborative culture of practice, it takes a little adjustment, and most people come to value it.

A GENTLE GUT-CHECK

How to tell if this might be your move

There's no scorecard, and no right answer. But after years of these conversations, a few honest patterns tend to show up.

This could be a good fit if...

You want warmth, the outdoors and a lifestyle around the work.

You'd value a large, modern health system with room to grow.

You're open to a fresh start and a bit of early uncertainty.

Your partner is part of the dream, not just along for it.

You like the idea of real choice over where in the country you live.

It may not be the right time if...

Being close to ageing parents is non-negotiable right now.

You'd struggle with the cost of housing in a major city.

A teenager at a decisive stage isn't ready, and can't be brought along.

You're hoping the move alone will fix something at home.

You need certainty before you can take any first step.

COMMON QUESTIONS

The things people ask us first

Will my partner be able to work?—

In many cases, yes. Partners on skilled and many employer-sponsored visas are often eligible to work, frequently with open work rights. The bigger question is usually about their world rather than their visa, finding their own purpose and people. We're happy to talk through what's realistic for your situation, alongside a licensed migration adviser.

Will my children settle?+

Is it expensive to live there?+

How far is it really from home?+

Do I need to decide now?+

 **HELPFUL ALONGSIDE THIS STEP**

Read a little deeper



NEW ZEALAND



AUSTRALIA

THE DECISION GUIDE

Australia or New Zealand?

*Two countries, one
honest comparison*

A side-by-side look at two of the best places in the world to build a healthcare career, and a life. Health systems, registration, visas, pay, lifestyle and how to decide. No pressure, no spin.



Kettle on. A longer read — about 12 min

9 sections

Updated August 2026

Free • no sign-up

SECTION 01 • THE HEADLINE

The two countries at a glance

Before the detail, here's the honest headline on each. The thing people tend to remember once the research is done.

Australia

Bigger, faster, more of everything

A large, wealthy country with major public health systems in every state and territory *and* one of the biggest private healthcare markets in the world. More roles, more settings, more specialisation, and warm weather across much of the year.

If scale, career breadth and earning potential sit near the top of your list, Australia tends to answer well.

New Zealand

Smaller, calmer, closer-knit

A smaller country running one national public health service, Health New Zealand – Te Whatu Ora, alongside a private sector. An acute, well-documented shortage of clinicians means demand is high and the welcome is genuine.

If balance, autonomy and a strong sense of community matter most, New Zealand is hard to beat.

The honest trade-off

It often comes down to **scale versus balance**. Australia gives you more of everything, roles, private options, sunshine and, frequently, pay. New Zealand gives you a gentler pace, real autonomy and a country that feels knowable. Neither is "better". They're different lives, and plenty of clinicians would be happy in either.

SECTION 02 • THE SYSTEMS

How the health systems work

Both countries run universal public healthcare funded largely through taxation, with a private sector alongside. How that's organised is where they differ.

	Australia	New Zealand
Public system	Run at state and territory level, each jurisdiction manages its own public hospitals and services, within a national framework and Medicare.	One national service, Health New Zealand – Te Whatu Ora, delivering public hospital and community care across the country.
Private sector	Very large and well established, especially in imaging, surgery and diagnostics, a major source of roles.	Present and growing, but smaller; most acute care sits within the public service.
Scale	Large population spread across big cities and vast regional areas.	Smaller population concentrated in a handful of cities, plus high-demand regional centres.
What it means for you	More employers and settings to choose between; you'll often weigh public against private.	A more unified system; simpler to navigate, with strong demand almost everywhere.

Ethicare insight

In Australia, part of your decision is often *public or private*, two quite different working cultures. In New Zealand, the bigger question is usually *which part of the country*, because the system itself is more consistent from place to place.

SECTION 03 • REGISTRATION

Getting registered to practise

You can't work as a clinician in either country until the relevant regulator has registered you. The principle is the same; the machinery differs.

Australia

One national scheme

Australia regulates health professions through a single national scheme administered by **Ahpra** (the Australian Health Practitioner Regulation Agency), with a national board for each profession. Registration applies Australia-wide, so it travels with you between states. Many roles carry a **protected title**.

For several professions, qualifications from comparable overseas regulators (for example the UK's HCPC or Ireland's CORU) can be recognised through a faster pathway.

Otherwise the relevant board assesses your qualification, and a national examination is sometimes required.

Registration and a migration skills assessment are **separate processes**; you may need one, the other, or both.

New Zealand

Profession-specific boards

New Zealand regulates each profession through its own **responsible authority or board**, and once registered you hold an **Annual Practising Certificate (APC)** that you renew each year. For most internationally-trained clinicians the process is well-trodden.

The board assesses your qualification, recent clinical experience and competence against New Zealand standards.

Routes are often a comparable-country pathway (more streamlined) or a qualifications-assessed pathway.

You'll typically need verified qualifications, evidence of recent practice, a criminal-history check and, where required, English-language evidence.

The honest trade-off

Australia's single national register is elegant once you're in, but the front door can involve more steps. New Zealand's per-profession boards mean the path is usually more direct, with an annual certificate to keep current. Your exact route depends on your profession and where you trained, our profession pages walk through each one.

SECTION 04 · PAY & LIVING COSTS

Pay & the cost of living

This is the section everyone wants a single number for, and the one where a single number would mislead you. Here's how pay actually works in each country, and what to weigh alongside it.

Australia

Agreements, awards & super

Public-sector pay is set by state-based enterprise agreements and awards, which also define progression, overtime and allowances. On top of pay, employers pay compulsory **superannuation** (retirement contributions).

The very large private sector, with high volumes in some specialties, can support strong earning potential, but figures vary by state, setting and role.

New Zealand

Collective agreements & balance

Public pay is largely set by national collective agreements, which give clear, consistent bands and progression across the country. Private work can add to this for some roles.

Many clinicians tell us the draw isn't only the number, it's the manageable workload and the life around the job.

"What will I actually earn?" is a per-role question, so we answer it per role.

Cost of living matters just as much as headline pay. Both countries have affordable regional areas and pricier big cities; housing is the biggest variable in each. The right comparison is always *take-home pay against local costs for the specific place you'd live*, not one country's average against another's.

SECTION 05 · VISAS

Visas & the right to work

Both countries actively want skilled healthcare workers and have clear routes for them. Including options that bring your partner and children with you, often with work and schooling rights.

	Australia	New Zealand
Common work route	Employer-sponsored temporary work visas are the usual entry for skilled clinicians, with skilled and nominated pathways alongside.	The Accredited Employer Work Visa is the usual route, tied to an accredited employer and a skilled role.
Residence	Employer-nomination and skilled-migration routes can lead to permanent residence for eligible clinicians.	Healthcare roles feature strongly on the skills lists, with work-to-residence and straight-to-residence options for many.
Your family	Partner work rights and schooling for children are typically available on the main skilled routes.	Partners can usually work and children can attend school, generally on domestic terms while you hold an eligible visa.
Good to know	Some visa routes also require a migration skills assessment, separate from professional registration.	Registration and visa steps are best sequenced together, usually a job offer first, then the visa.

Ethicare insight

Both countries reward getting the order right: registration, offer and visa need to happen in the correct sequence, and small timing details (like the validity window on certificates) trip people up. We help you sequence it, and work with licensed immigration advisers. We don't give immigration advice ourselves, but we make sure nothing happens out of order.

SECTION 06 · LIFE & FAMILY

Lifestyle, geography & family

For most families, this is where the decision is really made. Both countries are safe, English-speaking, outdoors-oriented and welcoming, but they feel different to live in.

Australia

Warm, big and buzzy

A warmer, sunnier climate across much of the country, large coastal cities with plenty going on, and enormous variety, from beaches to outback. Distances are big, which shapes travel and where you settle.

Great for those who want energy, choice and reliable sunshine.

New Zealand

Green, compact and calm

A cooler, greener landscape of mountains, coast and lakes, rarely far away. Cities are smaller and more relaxed, commutes are shorter, and the outdoors is on your doorstep.

Great for those who want space, nature and a slower, family-friendly rhythm.

Both countries offer strong, accessible schooling and universal healthcare for your family, safe communities, and a real culture of work-life balance. Māori culture is woven through everyday life in New Zealand; Australia's draw is often its sheer scale and diversity of places to build a life.

Picture an ordinary Tuesday, not just the holiday photos, that's the life you're choosing.

SECTION 07 • CAREER

Career & scope of practice

Where will your career grow faster, and how will the day-to-day feel? Scale and shortage pull in slightly different directions here.

	Australia	New Zealand
Market size	Large, major public systems plus one of the world's biggest private sectors, so more roles and settings.	Smaller, but with an acute, sustained shortage that keeps demand high across the country.
Specialisation	Broad scope to sub-specialise, with clear career ladders in bigger centres.	Broad general scope with room to develop expertise; often more autonomy earlier.
Ways of working	Choice between public and private cultures; high volumes in some private settings.	Mostly public, with modern kit and manageable lists frequently cited by clinicians.
The feel	Busy, varied, career-forward.	Steady, sustainable, people-first.

The honest trade-off

Australia's scale gives you more directions to grow and more private options. New Zealand's shortage gives you strong demand, real autonomy and a workload people describe as sustainable. Both are good places to build a long career, the difference is tempo.

SECTION 08 • DECIDING

Which might suit you?

There's no scorecard that decides this for you, but these leanings help many people see where their instincts already point. Read both columns; notice which one you nod along to.

Australia may suit you if...

Career breadth and specialisation matter most

You'd like the option of public *or* private work

Earning potential is high on your list

You want warm weather and big-city energy

You're comfortable in a larger, faster environment

New Zealand may suit you if...

Work-life balance is your priority

You value autonomy and a broad general scope

You want a compact, nature-first way of living

A close-knit community appeals to you and your family

A simpler, more unified system sounds right

A gentle reminder

You don't have to choose forever. Plenty of clinicians start in one country and move to the other later. The two systems have a lot in common, and experience in one is valued in the other. The goal right now is the *next* good step for you and your family.

Sophie's insight

People often come to us convinced they have to get this "right" the first time. You don't. Both countries are wonderful, and both value your skills, so the honest question isn't which is better, it's which fits the life you want next. Tell me what matters most to you and your family, and I'll tell you straight where I think you'd be happiest. Sometimes that's Australia, sometimes New Zealand, and sometimes it's starting where the door opens first.

Sophie Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

COMMON QUESTIONS

The things people ask us first

Is it easier to get registered in Australia or New Zealand?—

It depends entirely on your profession and where you trained. New Zealand's per-profession boards are often more direct; Australia's national scheme is elegant once you're in but can involve more steps, and sometimes a national exam or a separate migration skills assessment. Our profession pages walk through each pathway, and we'll map yours specifically.

Where will I earn more?+

Can my family come with me?+

Do I have to choose one forever?+

I'm not from the UK, does this still apply to me?+

 **EXPLORE FURTHER**

Read a little deeper

REFERENCE GUIDE

Understanding healthcare in Australia

Whether you'll be practising in it or relying on it for your family, it helps to know how Australian healthcare fits together, and where you stand from the day you land.

PAGE AT A GLANCE

Kettle on. A longer read — about 19 min

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THE BIG PICTURE

A universal system, with private care alongside

Reviewed July 2026 · checked against current Services Australia and Department of Health guidance. Eligibility rules and thresholds change, always confirm your own position at the source.

Australia runs a universal public system, funded through taxation and a Medicare levy, alongside a substantial private sector. Most people use a mix of the two across their lives.

Healthcare is delivered by the states and territories but underpinned by national funding and a national medicines scheme, which is why standards are broadly consistent wherever you live. For clinicians, that scale and that public–private mix are part of the appeal: broad experience, and real choice over where and how you work.

There are two questions on most people’s minds when they read a page like this. *Will my family be looked after? And what will it cost us?* This guide answers both honestly, including the parts Medicare doesn’t cover, which are the parts newcomers are most often surprised by.

The short version. If you arrive as a permanent resident, you enrol in Medicare and most of your care is free or heavily subsidised. If you arrive on a temporary work visa, your position depends on your passport, and for many of our clinicians it’s better than they expect. Either way, plan for dental, ambulance and optical, which sit outside Medicare for most adults.

— THE BACKBONE

Medicare, in plain terms

Medicare is the national scheme that subsidises or covers much of the cost of care. For your family, it’s the thing to sort early; for your work, it’s the system much of your practice connects to.

What it covers

Much of your care

Free treatment as a public patient in a public hospital, and rebates toward GP visits, tests and many specialist services. Some services are bulk-billed (nothing to pay); others carry a gap fee, which is the difference between the rebate and what the clinic charges.

Who’s eligible

Depends on your visa & passport

Citizens and permanent residents enrol. Many temporary visa holders qualify through a reciprocal health care agreement between Australia and their home country. Others rely on private cover, sometimes as a condition of the visa itself.

The levy

How it's funded

Most taxpayers pay a Medicare levy through income tax, a proportion of income, deducted like any other tax. Higher earners without private hospital cover may also pay a surcharge on top. Rates change; check the current figures with the ATO.

— THE QUESTION EVERYONE ASKS FIRST

Where you'll stand, by how you arrive

This is the part worth reading properly, because it's the difference between arriving covered and arriving exposed. There are broadly three positions.

1

Permanent resident or citizen, full Medicare

You enrol and you're in: public hospital care, GP rebates, PBS medicines, the lot. Your dependent children are enrolled alongside you. This is the simplest position and the one most of our clinicians reach eventually, whether they arrive that way or transition later.

2

Temporary work visa, from a reciprocal-agreement country

Australia holds reciprocal health care agreements with **eleven countries**: the United Kingdom, the Republic of Ireland, New Zealand, Belgium, Finland, Italy, Malta, the Netherlands, Norway, Slovenia and Sweden. If you hold a passport from one of these and you're here on an eligible visa, you can enrol for Medicare access to medically necessary treatment.

What that covers varies by country, and the differences matter. Most agreements include subsidised GP visits and public hospital treatment; the New Zealand and Ireland agreements are narrower and don't extend to GP visits in the same way. Check your own country's agreement at the source before you assume.

3

Temporary visa, no reciprocal agreement

If your passport isn't on that list, South Africa, the UAE, India, the Philippines and many others aren't, you won't enrol in Medicare on a temporary visa. You'll hold private health insurance instead, and for most sponsored work visas maintaining adequate cover is a formal condition of the visa (you may see it written as condition 8501). Your employer sometimes contributes; often they don't. Budget for it.

We raise this early with everyone, because it changes the family budget and occasionally the choice of route. It is never a reason not to come, but it should never be a surprise either. And to be clear: we're recruiters, not migration or insurance advisers. We'll tell you what to check and where; the answer has to come from the official source or a licensed adviser.

FIRST FORTNIGHT

Enrolling, and what to bring

Enrolment is administrative rather than difficult. The people who find it smooth are the ones who arrive with the paperwork already in a folder.

1

Enrol once you've arrived

You generally enrol after you land, in person at a service centre or online, depending on your circumstances. It isn't something to do from abroad, so don't worry that you're behind before you fly.

2

Bring passports and visa evidence

Passports for every family member, and evidence of your visa grant. If you're enrolling under a reciprocal agreement, you'll usually need to show you're enrolled in your home country's system too.

3

Have an Australian address ready

A card has to be posted somewhere. Temporary accommodation is generally fine, but a rental agreement or a utility bill makes everything faster, another reason to sort housing early.

4

Set up a myGov account

MyGov is the front door to most government services here, Medicare included. Linking Medicare to it means claims, records and your digital card all sit in one place. Do it in your first week.

5

Interim cover in the gap

There can be a short window between landing and your card arriving. Travel or private cover across those first weeks is cheap peace of mind, particularly with children.

6

Then choose a GP

Card in hand, register the family with a local practice. Don't wait for someone to be unwell. New-patient appointments can take a fortnight or more in busy areas.

TWO SYSTEMS, WORKING TOGETHER

Public and private

Understanding how the two relate makes the whole system click into place, both as a patient and as a clinician.

The public system

State-run hospitals and services provide emergency, acute and much elective care, free or heavily subsidised through Medicare. It's where a great deal of teaching, training and complex work happens, and where most of the roles we recruit for sit.

The private system

Private hospitals and clinics offer choice of provider and often shorter waits for elective care, funded by insurance and out-of-pocket fees. Many clinicians work across both, and some build a portfolio deliberately.

How patients move between them

The same specialist may see you publicly or privately; the same scan may be bulk-billed at one clinic and charged at another. Elective waits are the usual reason families take out cover, urgent care doesn't wait for anyone in either system.

TOLD STRAIGHT

Private health insurance, honestly

Whether you need it depends on your visa, your income and your family. Here's the shape of the decision, without the sales pitch.

If it's a visa condition, it isn't optional. Many temporary work visas require you to hold and maintain adequate health cover for yourself and every family member for the whole time you're here. Letting it lapse is a visa problem, not just a health one.

If you're Medicare-eligible, it's a genuine choice. The public system will look after you. Families choose cover for shorter elective waits, a choice of doctor, a private room, and "extras" policies that put something back toward dental, optical and physiotherapy, the things Medicare largely doesn't fund for adults.

Two rules are worth knowing before you decide. Higher earners without private hospital cover pay an additional surcharge at tax time, so for some households cover costs less than not having it. And there's a loading that increases premiums for people who take out hospital cover later in life, with concessions for recent arrivals, so the timing of your first policy can matter for years. Both are threshold-and-percentage rules that change; get the current numbers from the ATO and the government's comparison site rather than from a broker's brochure.

Policies also carry **waiting periods**. Months before some services can be claimed, longer for pregnancy and pre-existing conditions. If a baby or a known procedure is on the horizon, that timing deserves real attention before you pick a policy.

The honest position: don't buy the first policy you're shown, and don't let anyone tell you the public system isn't good enough. It is. Cover buys convenience, choice and the extras, which for some families is worth a great deal and for others isn't.

— EVERYDAY CARE

GPs, referrals and the PBS

Day-to-day healthcare runs through general practice, with a national medicines scheme keeping prescriptions affordable.

Your **GP** is the front door: the first stop for most concerns and the gatekeeper for referrals to specialists and many tests. Unlike some systems you may know, you don't register with one practice for life. You can see any GP anywhere, but continuity is worth having, so most families settle on one.

Bulk billing and gap fees. A bulk-billing practice accepts the Medicare rebate as full payment, so you pay nothing at the desk. Many others charge a fee and Medicare refunds part of it, leaving you a gap. Bulk billing is more common for children, concession-card holders and in some regional areas; it has become less common generally, so ask when you book rather than assuming. Specialists usually charge a gap, sometimes a substantial one, and you'll want to ask the cost before the appointment. Nobody minds the question.

The PBS. Prescription medicines are subsidised through the **Pharmaceutical Benefits Scheme**, which caps what most people pay for listed medicines, with a lower cap for concession-card holders and a safety net once a household's spending passes a yearly threshold. Not every medicine is listed, and brand names differ from what you may be used to, so check your family's regular prescriptions against the PBS before you move, and bring a written summary of your medical history and current doses.

Ask if a clinic bulk-bills Ask a specialist's fee up front Check prescriptions against the PBS Bring a written medical summary Register the family early

— THE PART PEOPLE DON'T EXPECT

What Medicare doesn't cover

Clinicians from tax-funded systems are rarely surprised by the hospital care. They're often surprised by these.

Adult dental

Largely private and out of pocket. There is public dental care for eligible concession-card holders, usually with long waits, and schemes that help with children's dental for eligible families. For most working adults, plan to pay, and factor it into the year's budget, especially if anyone is due significant work.

Ambulance

This one catches people out. Ambulance cover is arranged state by state rather than nationally, in some places it's provided, in others you subscribe or insure, and an uncovered call-out can be a unpleasant bill. Check the arrangement in your state in your first week.

Optical, allied health & more

Glasses, contact lenses, most physiotherapy, psychology beyond limited referred sessions, podiatry and similar sit largely outside Medicare, or attract only partial rebates. These are what "extras" insurance is designed for.

None of this is a reason for alarm, it's a reason to plan. Families who know about ambulance and dental before they arrive absorb them easily. Families who find out via a bill do not.

— IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

Knowing where to go, before you need to

Worth reading once and remembering. Most newcomers' first real interaction with the system is unplanned.

Emergency

Call 000

Triple zero reaches ambulance, fire and police. It's the number to teach your children on day one.

Emergency departments at public hospitals treat anyone who needs them, regardless of cover, care first, paperwork later.

Urgent, not an emergency

Urgent care & after-hours GPs

Between a GP appointment and an emergency department sit urgent care clinics and after-hours services, with growing bulk-billed provision. For a sprain, a fever or stitches, they're usually the faster, kinder option.

Not sure

Healthdirect · free advice

A national free health advice line and website staffed by registered nurses, available around the clock. When you're new and unsure whether something warrants a hospital, it's exactly the right first call.

WHERE YOU COME IN

Practising in Australian healthcare

For clinicians, the system offers broad experience and a collaborative, patient-centred culture, with national registration that lets you move between states without starting again.

You might work in a public health service, a private provider, or community and primary care, and many roles offer a mix of the two. Practice tends to be **team-based and relatively flat**: your professional opinion is expected, not merely permitted, and being asked "what do you think?" by a senior colleague is normal rather than a test. Clinicians arriving from more hierarchical systems tell us this takes a few weeks to trust and then becomes the thing they'd least want to give up. That said, it's a tendency rather than a guarantee: culture varies from one workplace and team to the next, so it's worth asking what a particular department is really like when you interview, and talking to people already doing the job.

There is a genuine emphasis on **culturally safe care**, including for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander patients, and you'll meet it in induction, in documentation and in how teams talk about patients. It is treated as clinical quality, not as an add-on.

The honest counterweights: services are busy, some regions carry real workforce pressure, and distance is a clinical factor in a country this size, retrieval, telehealth and outreach are ordinary parts of practice rather than exceptions. Your profession guide goes deeper into scope, demand and what the day-to-day is really like for your role.

Ready to see how your role fits? **Stage 04 · Can I work in Australia?** sets out the registration pathway, and each profession page covers scope, demand and pay.

TOLD STRAIGHT

What's worth knowing before you rely on it

Six things we'd rather you heard from us than discovered later.

1

Bulk billing is less universal than it sounds

"Free GP visits" is how Medicare gets described abroad. In practice many clinics charge a gap. Ask when you book.

2

Elective waits are real

Urgent care is prompt and excellent. Non-urgent surgery in the public system can mean a long wait, which is precisely why many families hold cover.

3

Ambulance cover varies by state

There is no single national answer, and an uncovered call-out is expensive. Check your state, not the internet's general advice.

4

Your visa condition is yours to maintain

If cover is required by your visa, keeping it current is your responsibility for the whole stay, including through job changes.

5

Thresholds and rates change

The levy, the surcharge, PBS caps and insurance loadings all move. Anything you read anywhere, here included, should be checked against the current official figures.

We don't give insurance or tax advice

We'll tell you what to look into and flag what usually applies to clinicians in your position. The advice itself must come from the official sources or a licensed adviser.

Sophie's insight

Two things reassure most families fastest: that healthcare here is good and universal, and that sorting their own access is simpler than they feared. Get your Medicare position clear before you accept the role, choose a family GP early, check your prescriptions before you fly, and find out how ambulance works in your state. That's most of it.

The one I always raise unprompted is dental. It's the cost people don't plan for, and it's much easier to absorb when you knew it was coming. For your work, the public-private mix is a real strength, it's part of why clinicians find the experience here so broad.

Sophie CEO & Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

— OFFICIAL SOURCES

Check it at the source

The system evolves and thresholds move every year. These are the sites worth bookmarking, for your family's care and for your own professional context.

Medicare & eligibility

Enrolling, cards & agreements

[Services Australia · Medicare](https://www.servicesaustralia.gov.au/medicare) (<https://www.servicesaustralia.gov.au/medicare>) [Reciprocal health care agreements](https://www.servicesaustralia.gov.au/reciprocal-health-care-agreements) (<https://www.servicesaustralia.gov.au/reciprocal-health-care-agreements>) [myGov · link your services](https://my.gov.au) (<https://my.gov.au>) | The authority on whether you can enrol, and on what your country's agreement actually covers.

Medicines, cover & tax

The costs side

[PBS · subsidised medicines](https://www.pbs.gov.au) (<https://www.pbs.gov.au>) [privatehealth.gov.au · compare cover](https://www.privatehealth.gov.au) (<https://www.privatehealth.gov.au>) [ATO · levy & surcharge](https://www.ato.gov.au) (<https://www.ato.gov.au>) | Check whether your medicines are listed, compare policies without a broker, and get current thresholds.

Care & practice

When you need help, and how you register

[healthdirect · free nurse advice](https://www.healthdirect.gov.au) (<https://www.healthdirect.gov.au>) [Department of Health & Aged Care](https://www.health.gov.au) (<https://www.health.gov.au>) [Ahpra · professional registration](https://www.ahpra.gov.au) (<https://www.ahpra.gov.au>) | In an emergency call **000**. For anything you're unsure about, healthdirect is the right first call.

COMMON QUESTIONS

The things people ask us first

Will my family be covered by Medicare?–

It depends on your visa and your passport. Citizens and permanent residents enrol in Medicare and so do their dependent children. Many temporary visa holders qualify through one of Australia's eleven reciprocal health care agreements, the UK, Ireland, New Zealand, Belgium, Finland, Italy, Malta, the Netherlands, Norway, Slovenia and Sweden. If your passport isn't on that list, you'll hold private cover instead, often as a condition of the visa. We flag this early, because it affects your budget.

Do I need private health insurance?+

How soon can I enrol after arriving, and what do I bring?+

How do I see a doctor as a newcomer?+

Is everything really free?+

What about ambulance cover?+

Will my regular medication be available?+

Are waiting lists long?+

How different will practising here feel?+

— READ A LITTLE DEEPER

Helpful alongside this guide

Can I work in Australia?

If the life makes sense, the next question is whether you can practise here.



Kettle on. A longer read – about 13 min

— WHAT DO YOU NEED HELP WITH?

Three things you can do right now

Pick the one you need now. The full guide is underneath for when you have a cup of tea and half an hour.

I don't know which pathway is mine

Check my pathway

Answer a few questions about your profession, where you trained and your current registration. Two minutes, and it points you at the official Australian routes.

Open the pathway checker I want the detail for my profession

Find my profession

What registration actually involves for your role, board by board, with the requirements that apply to you rather than to everyone.

See the professions I want the official links

Get the forms and contacts

Ahpra, the National Boards and the official pages you'll need, in one place and kept current.

Open the directory

— THE SHORT VERSION

Registration is what lets you practise, and it's very doable

Reviewed July 2026 · checked against the current published guidance of the relevant Australian national board or accrediting authority

Australia runs one national scheme, so once you are registered it is recognised in every state and territory. For most medical-imaging professions that means Ahpra and the MRPBA, though a couple of roles sit slightly differently.

The one thing to hold onto: **registration lets you practise; a visa lets you live and work here**. They're separate, run by different bodies, and getting them in the right order is most of the battle. We'll come to visas in Stage 07; this stage is about the right to practise.

“Can I work there?” is four questions, and registration is one of them

Ahpra and your National Board decide whether you can practise. Whether you can live and work in Australia at all is decided elsewhere, and each part has its own owner. This page is the first.

Registration — the right to practise. This page, then **your profession**.

The visa — the right to live and work here, decided by the Department of Home Affairs, not the board, and for most clinicians sponsored by an employer. A skills assessment for migration is a third, separate thing. **Immigration & visas** owns all of that.

English, health and character — asked by the board and by Home Affairs in slightly different forms. **English requirements**.

Time and money — months rather than weeks, with fees at each stage. **How long it takes**; what it costs sits in **Make the numbers work**.

The quickest first pass is **Check my pathway**: your profession, where you trained and what you already hold, and the route most likely to apply to you.

There's a second thing worth knowing early: for the professions that use radiation, **national registration is separate from a state radiation use licence**. Registration is Australia-wide; the licence to operate radiation equipment is issued by each state or territory, and your employer usually helps you arrange it.

— THE DISTINCTION THAT TRIPS PEOPLE UP

Registration and migration are two separate things

International clinicians routinely confuse these. They sound alike, they're run by different bodies, and you may need one, the other, or both, depending on your visa.

To practise

Professional registration

Assessed by the relevant board (the MRPBA for radiographers, radiation therapists and nuclear medicine technologists). This is what legally lets you work in your role, whatever your visa says.

To migrate

A skills assessment

Required for certain skilled-migration visas, by a separate assessing authority: ASMIRT for radiographers and radiation therapists, ANZSNM for nuclear medicine. It's a migration step, not a registration one.

The order

Lead with registration

On an employer-sponsored (482) visa a skills assessment generally isn't needed just to register. Most candidates lead with registration and sort the skills assessment only if their visa route needs it.

— THE SHAPE OF IT

How registration actually unfolds

It isn't one form and a decision. It's a sequence, and knowing the order matters more than knowing the detail, because two of these steps depend on other people and can't be rushed at the end.

1

Work out which pathway is yours

Your profession, where you qualified and which regulator you're currently registered with together decide whether you're assessed as substantially equivalent, streamed through a comparable-regulator route, or assessed individually.

2

Request the slow documents first

Certificates of good standing from every regulator you've held registration with, and verified copies of your qualifications. These come from other organisations on their timetable, not yours. Start them on day one.

3

Settle the English question

Either evidence an exemption or book a test. Doing this third rather than last is what separates a smooth application from a stalled one.

4

Submit a complete application

Identity, qualifications, registration history, English, criminal-history check and your practice history, all in one properly evidenced pack. Incomplete applications don't get assessed slowly; they get set aside.

5

Respond quickly to any request

Assessors often come back with a question or ask for one more document. How fast you answer is one of the few levers you control after submitting.

6

Registration, then the state licence

Once you're registered, the professions that operate radiation equipment arrange a state or territory radiation use licence. Employers deal with this routinely and usually help.

Where we fit: we can't assess or approve anything, and we'd be wary of anyone who says they can. What we can do is tell you which pathway looks like yours before you spend money, keep the role and the visa moving alongside the registration, and flag a gap while it's still cheap to fix.

THE DETAIL LIVES ON YOUR PROFESSION PAGE

Find your profession

Australia is opening in stages, beginning with medical imaging and radiation therapy. Each profession has its own full guide, the regulator, the pathway, scope of practice and what the work is like. Start with yours.

What every application needs

Whatever your profession, a clean, complete documentation pack is the single biggest factor within your control on timing. The specifics vary, but you'll generally be assembling the same core.

Your qualifications

Your qualifying award and full academic transcript, and, where required, evidence of supervised clinical training and recent practice.

Good standing & identity

Certified proof of identity, your registration history, and a current Certificate of Good Standing from each authority you're registered with.

English language

You'll meet the board's English Language Skills Registration Standard, by an approved test or an exemption. Confirm the current requirement before booking anything.

Two things some applicants also meet: a **national MRP examination** (where your qualification isn't assessed as substantially equivalent: comparable-regulator applicants are generally exempt), and a **state radiation use licence** for the professions that operate radiation equipment. Your profession page sets out which apply to you.

Start these now, they depend on other people

Certificates of good standing from every regulator you've registered with

Verified or certified copies of your qualifying award and transcripts

Police or criminal-history checks from each country you've lived in

Certified translations of anything not in English

References who can be reached, and who know you're using them

These you can settle yourself

A clear, dated practice history with no unexplained gaps

Your continuing professional development records

Evidence of recent practice in your profession

Proof of identity, certified as the board requires

An English test booking, or the evidence for an exemption

— THE ONE PEOPLE UNDERESTIMATE

The English requirement, plainly

Every national board sets an English language skills standard, and it catches out more experienced clinicians than anything else on this page, usually because they assumed years of practising in English would speak for itself.

You may already be exempt

Boards recognise pathways based on where you were educated and where you've practised, in English, over a sustained period. If that's you, gather the evidence rather than booking a test.

If you do sit a test

Several approved tests are accepted, and the minimum scores are set per component, not as an average. One low component can fail an otherwise strong result, so prepare for your weakest, not your strongest.

Results have a shelf life

Test results expire, and registration and immigration don't always accept the same tests or the same scores. Check what both require before you book, rather than paying to sit twice.

The honest advice: confirm your position on English in your first week of looking into this, not your last. It's the single item most likely to add months, and the one most easily sorted early.

— THE QUESTION EVERYONE ASKS

How long it takes, honestly

We will not print a number, because it depends on your pathway and how complete your application is. What we can tell you is what makes it fast and what makes it slow.

1

Faster: a comparable-regulator route

Where your qualification and current registration are recognised as comparable, assessment is more streamlined and an examination generally isn't required.

2

Faster: one complete submission

Applications that arrive complete get assessed. Applications that arrive missing a document wait, then wait again for the answer to come back.

3

Slower: individual assessment

Where your qualification needs assessing on its own merits, expect more evidence, more questions and, sometimes, an examination.

4

Slower: documents from elsewhere

Good-standing certificates, verified transcripts and overseas police checks all move at another organisation's pace. This is the most common reason a timeline slips.

5

Slower: a gap in practice

Boards look at recency of practice. A significant break isn't a barrier, but it usually means more evidence and sometimes a supervised period.

6

Slower: leaving English to the end

If a test turns out to be needed, booking, sitting and waiting for results can add months to an application that was otherwise ready to go.

Sophie's insight

Registration looks daunting on paper, but it's really a sequence, and the people who move fastest are the ones who started the slow items early and kept their evidence organised. Our job is to tell you, honestly, which pathway is yours, help secure the role and sponsorship, and flag issues while they're still easy to fix. The decisions rest with the boards; getting you to them in good shape is where we come in.

Sophie CEO & Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

COMMON QUESTIONS

The things people ask us first

Is my registration valid in every state?—

Yes. Australia's registration is national, so once you're registered (or accredited, for sonographers) it's recognised in every state and territory. The exception is the radiation use licence, which is issued by each state separately for the professions that operate radiation equipment.

Do I need to sit an exam?+

Can I start applying for jobs before I’m registered?+

How long does it take?+

Do I need a skills assessment as well?+

What if I’ve had a break from practice?+

Will my overseas CPD count?+

What does it cost?+

Do you charge me for any of this?+

 HELPFUL ALONGSIDE THIS STEP

Read a little deeper

Immigration & visas

The most factual chapter. There's no single right visa, the route depends on your profession, your employer and your plans.



Kettle on. A longer read – about 14 min

— WHAT DO YOU NEED HELP WITH?

Three things you can do right now

Pick the one you need now. The full guide is underneath for when you have a cup of tea and half an hour.

I want to know what it will cost

Price up the move

Visa fees, flights, shipping and the first month here, worked out for your household rather than a generic average.

Open the cost calculator I want the official immigration links

Get the official links

Home Affairs, the skilled occupation lists and the forms you'll actually need, gathered in one place.

Open the directory I want someone to sequence it with me

Talk it through

We explain the routes and keep your file moving. The decisions stay with Home Affairs, but you won't be guessing at the order.

Ask us about your visa

FIRST, THE BIG PICTURE

Two main ways in, and how they meet registration

Reviewed July 2026 · checked against the Department of Home Affairs' current published guidance. Immigration rules change, always confirm at the source

Two routes cover most healthcare professionals: employer-sponsored, where a provider sponsors you for a specific role, or skilled migration, based on your points and occupation. Registration and visa are separate workstreams, and the trick is sequencing them so neither holds the other up.

An honest note up front: immigration is regulated, and the rules change. Nothing here is migration advice, it's a plain-English map so you know the shape of it. For your actual application we work alongside **licensed migration advisers**, and always point you to the Department of Home Affairs for the current detail.

HOW IT FITS TOGETHER

Three threads, one timeline

Registration, the role and the visa aren't a strict queue. They run alongside each other, and the skill is in starting each one early enough that none of them becomes the thing everyone is waiting on.

Thread one

Registration to practise

Your right to practise comes from the national board for your profession, or from the accrediting body where your profession isn't board-registered. It's the longest lead time of the three, so it starts first.

Thread two

The role and the sponsor

An offer from an employer willing to sponsor is what unlocks the most direct visa routes. It also anchors the timing of everything else, including when you can realistically fly.

Thread three

The visa itself

Lodged once the role and your evidence are in place. Health examinations and police certificates sit inside this thread and are the two things people most often start too late.

— THE MOST COMMON ROUTE FOR US

Employer-sponsored

An Australian employer sponsors you to fill a role they can't fill locally. For most candidates we support, this is the most direct path, and on it, a separate migration skills assessment generally isn't required just to register.

Skills in Demand (482)

The working visa

A temporary skilled visa sponsored by your employer for an eligible occupation. It lets you live and work here while you settle, often with a pathway to permanent residence over time.

Employer Nomination (186)

Toward permanence

An employer-nominated permanent route for eligible roles, sometimes available from the outset, sometimes after a period on a working visa. Your adviser will confirm what fits.

The appeal

A role and a runway

You arrive with a job, an employer invested in your move, and often relocation support, which makes the practical side of settling considerably smoother.

— THE POINTS-BASED ROUTE

Skilled migration

Skilled migration lets you apply based on your occupation, age, English, qualifications and experience, without needing a specific employer first. It's where the migration skills assessment matters most.

The points-tested visas

Subclasses such as 189 (independent), 190 (state-nominated) and 491 (regional) are scored on a points test. State and regional nomination can add points and open doors.

The skills assessment

These visas require a skills assessment by the gazetted authority for your profession: ASMIRT for radiographers and radiation therapists, ANZSNM for nuclear medicine, the ASMIRT ultrasound certificate for sonographers.

Regional incentives

Many healthcare roles are outside the big cities, and regional visas and incentives can make a regional move both easier and rewarding, something worth exploring openly.

A ROUGH SORT

Which route is likely yours

Nobody can tell you your visa from a web page, and we won't pretend otherwise. But most people recognise themselves in one of these two columns before they ever speak to an adviser.

Employer-sponsored usually fits if...

- You want a role confirmed before you commit to moving
- Your profession is one hospitals and providers are actively short of
- You'd rather arrive with an employer invested in your relocation
- You want the shortest sensible route from decision to arrival
- You're moving with a partner and children and want certainty first

Skilled migration may suit if...

- You want permanent residence from the outset, before choosing an employer
- You're happy to complete a migration skills assessment for your occupation
- You score well on the points test on age, English and experience
- You're open to a state-nominated or regional route, and the incentives that come with it
- Your timeline is longer and you'd rather trade speed for flexibility

Both can be true. Plenty of people arrive on an employer-sponsored visa and move toward permanent residence later, either through their employer or in their own right. Starting on one route rarely closes the other.

THE SHAPE OF IT

How the process usually unfolds

Every case differs, and timelines move. But the path from first conversation to first shift almost always follows this shape, and seeing it written down takes most of the fear out of it.

1

Confirm you're eligible

Before anything else, an honest look at your qualifications, experience and English against what your profession requires. This is Stage 04, and it saves months of wasted effort.

2

Start registration

The longest thread begins. Document gathering, verification and assessment run in the background while the rest of your move takes shape.

3

Secure the role

Interviews, offer, and confirmation that the employer will sponsor. This is the point where an abstract plan becomes a real date on a calendar.

4

Nomination, then visa

On a sponsored route your employer's nomination is generally lodged alongside or just ahead of your visa application. On a skilled route you submit an expression of interest and wait to be invited.

5

Health and character checks

Health examinations for everyone on the application, plus police certificates from each country you've lived in. Start these the moment you're told to; overseas certificates can be slow.

6

Grant, then the practical move

Once granted, flights, shipping, schools and housing come into focus. That's where *Preparing to move* picks up, and by then the hardest part is behind you.

— YOU'RE NOT MOVING ALONE

Bringing your family

For most work and skilled visas you can include your partner and dependent children on the same application, and partners are usually able to work.

The detail (who counts as a dependant, evidence of your relationship, schooling and health checks) depends on the visa and your circumstances. It's all routine, but it rewards getting organised early: gathering documents, booking the health examinations, and being clear about everyone you're bringing. We'll make sure nothing important is left to the last minute, and your migration adviser confirms the specifics.

Your partner can usually work

Partners included on most work and skilled visas hold work rights, often unrestricted. For a lot of couples that's the detail that makes the move viable: two careers, not one on hold.

Your children can go to school

Dependent children study here while you work. What you pay depends on your visa and the state or territory you land in, so it's worth checking before you choose a suburb.

Healthcare from the start

Access to Medicare depends on your visa, and reciprocal health care agreements cover people from a number of countries in the meantime. Most families also hold private cover, and some visas require it.

THE LONGER VIEW

Toward permanent residence

Most people we speak to aren't really asking about a visa. They're asking whether this could become home. It's a fair question to ask on day one, and worth answering honestly.

Through your employer

After a period in the role

Employer-nominated permanent routes are generally open to people who've held an eligible role for a qualifying period, and sometimes from the outset. Your employer and your adviser confirm what applies.

In your own right

Points-tested residence

If you meet the points test you can pursue permanent residence independently of any employer, including through state nomination. Some people arrive sponsored and go this way later.

Further out

Citizenship

Citizenship follows a period of lawful residence, part of it as a permanent resident. It's years away rather than months, but it's the reason many families make the move at all.

Worth saying plainly: permanence is not automatic, and eligibility rules change over time. If putting down roots is the point of the move for you, say so early. It changes which route we'd recommend exploring, and which questions your adviser should be asked first.

— THE HONEST PART

What's worth knowing before you apply

None of these are reasons to hesitate. They're the things that keep an application on track rather than catching you out halfway through.

1 The rules change

Visa subclasses, occupation lists, income thresholds and nomination criteria are all reviewed. Whatever you read, including this page, confirm the current position with the Department of Home Affairs and a licensed adviser.

2 Health and police checks take time

Medicals for every person on the application, and police certificates from every country you've lived in for a meaningful period. Overseas certificates are the single most common cause of delay.

3 There are real costs

Application charges, medicals, certificates, skills assessments and registration fees add up across a family, and some are payable per person. They're manageable when you budget for them and unpleasant when you don't.

4 English evidence has a shelf life

Test results expire, and different bodies accept different tests and scores. Check what your registration and your visa each require before you book, rather than sitting the wrong test twice.

5 Registration and visa are separate

Approval for one is not approval for the other. Both have to land, and they're assessed by different organisations against different criteria.

6 Nobody here gives migration advice

We coordinate, we chase, we keep the threads aligned. Formal advice on your application comes from a registered migration agent or lawyer, and we'll tell you when you need one.

What to start gathering now

You can make a real dent in this before you've chosen a visa, an employer or even a state. Everything below gets used more than once, so getting certified copies together early pays off repeatedly.

Almost certainly needed

Current passports for everyone moving, with plenty of validity left

Degree certificates and academic transcripts

A full employment history with dates, and references you can actually reach

Evidence of registration, past and present, in every country you've practised

English test results, if your route requires them

Police certificates from each country you've lived in

Depending on your circumstances

Marriage or relationship evidence, and children's birth certificates

A migration skills assessment from the authority for your occupation

Continuing professional development records

Certified translations of anything not in English

A change-of-name document, if your paperwork doesn't all match

Sophie's insight

Visas are the part people fear most, and almost always needlessly. The honest truth is that once you have a role and your registration is moving, the visa is a process, paperwork, timelines and patience, not a gamble. We coordinate the three threads (job, registration, visa) so they line up, and we bring in licensed migration advisers for the formal advice. You don't have to become an expert in any of it; you just have to start in the right order.

SophieCEO & Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

COMMON QUESTIONS

The things people ask us first

Which visa is right for me?—

It depends on your profession, whether you have an employer, your age and your plans. Most candidates we support come on an employer-sponsored visa; others suit skilled migration. We'll talk through which fits and bring in a licensed adviser for the formal recommendation.

Do I need the skills assessment and registration?+

Can my partner work?+

How long does a visa take?+

Do I need a job offer before I can apply?+

Will I have to move somewhere regional?+

Can I bring our pets?+

What if my application is refused?+

Do you charge candidates for any of this?+

 HELPFUL ALONGSIDE THIS STEP

Read a little deeper

Salary & pay, explained honestly

Australian healthcare pay has a published national floor and a lot of room above it. Here is how both halves work, so you can read any offer properly.

PAGE AT A GLANCE

1. [The two layers of pay](#)
2. [The national floor](#)
3. [What sets your level](#)
4. [Beyond base salary](#)
5. [Which award covers you](#)
6. [Tax & take-home](#)
7. [Pay in context](#)
8. [Knowing your exact rate](#)

Kettle on. A longer read — about 17 min

THE HONEST STARTING POINT

Nobody earns the minimum, but everyone should know it

The first thing you want to know is what you will actually earn.

Australia answers that in two parts, and most salary guides only show you one.

The first part is public and precise. A **national modern award** sets a legal minimum for your profession, the same in every state, published by the Fair Work Ombudsman and updated each July. Anyone can read it. The second part is where real offers live: **state enterprise agreements and private-market rates that sit above that floor**, often well above it.

So the award is not a forecast of your salary. It is the number below which an offer cannot legally go, which makes it the most useful reference point you have when you are new to a country and cannot yet tell a good offer from a poor one.

Read it as a floor, not a target. **If an offer is anywhere near the award minimum for your level, that tells you something.** Knowing the floor is what lets you ask the right question about everything above it.

— HOW THE SYSTEM IS BUILT

The two layers of Australian pay

Australia has no single national pay scale. It has a national safety net with state and private layers on top, and which one applies depends on who employs you.

Layer one · the floor

The national modern award

A single federal instrument per profession group, setting minimum rates, penalties, allowances and conditions. It applies everywhere in Australia and is reviewed every July by the Fair Work Commission. For most allied health and medical-imaging roles this is the Health Professionals and Support Services Award 2020.

Layer two · the public system

State & territory enterprise agreements

Public hospitals and health services are covered by enterprise agreements negotiated in each state and territory, usually with the relevant union. These sit above the award and are where most public-sector clinicians are actually paid. Because they are negotiated separately, the same job pays differently in different states.

Layer three · the private market

Private and individual arrangements

Australia has one of the world's largest private healthcare and imaging markets. Private employers must meet the award floor but are otherwise free to build their own packages, and for in-demand skills those packages compete hard.

Why this matters to you

It means "what does a radiographer earn in Australia" has no single answer, and anyone who gives you one figure is guessing. The answerable questions are: what is the floor for my level, which agreement or contract would cover this specific role, and what does that role pay. We answer those three for every role we discuss.

— THE PUBLISHED MINIMUM

The national floor, in real numbers

These are the current national minimum rates for health professional employees under the Health Professionals and Support Services Award 2020 (award code MA000027), the award covering allied health and medical-imaging professionals in the private sector.

Level	Weekly minimum	Hourly	Casual hourly
Level 1 Graduate and early-career. Entry pay point set by your qualification on entry	A\$1,174.00about \$61,000 a year	\$30.89	\$38.61incl. 25% loading
Level 2 Experienced practitioner working independently with professional judgment	\$1,493.90about \$77,700 a year	\$39.31	\$49.14incl. 25% loading
Level 3 Senior or advanced practitioner, complex work, greater professional responsibility	\$1,743.90about \$90,700 a year	\$45.89	\$57.36incl. 25% loading
Level 4 The award's most senior health professional classification	Sits above Level 3. Because Level 4 roles vary so much in scope, we confirm the current rate and pay point against the live pay guide for the specific role rather than publish one figure here.		
Pay point 1 shown. Each level contains several pay points that step up with years of service, Level 1 alone has six, so an experienced clinician entering at Level 2 does not start at the figure above. Annual equivalents are the weekly minimum over 52 weeks, before penalties, allowances or superannuation.			

Source: Fair Work Ombudsman pay guide for MA000027, effective the first full pay period on or after 1 July 2026. The 2026–27 Annual Wage Review lifted all modern award minimum rates by 4.75%, and the national minimum wage to \$26.44 an hour. Rates change every July, check the current [Fair Work pay guide](https://www.fairwork.gov.au/pay-and-wages/minimum-wages/pay-guides) (https://www.fairwork.gov.au/pay-and-wages/minimum-wages/pay-guides) or the [Pay and Conditions Tool](https://www.fairwork.gov.au/pay-and-wages/pay-calculator) (https://www.fairwork.gov.au/pay-and-wages/pay-calculator) before relying on any figure.

Read this the right way

These are minimums for the private sector, at the first pay point, before anything is added. A public-hospital offer under a state enterprise agreement will normally sit above them, and a private offer for a skill in short supply can sit well above them.

We publish the floor because it is verifiable and stable enough to be useful. We do not publish "typical" or "average" salaries, because the honest version of that number depends on your state, your employer, your pay point and your roster, and a made-up average helps nobody make a decision this big.

LANDING ON THE RIGHT RUNG

What decides your level and pay point

Two clinicians doing the same job can sit on different pay points, by design. Classification follows duties, qualifications and responsibility rather than job title.

A

Qualifications on entry

Your registration and the highest qualification you hold when you start set your entry point within Level 1, and can affect which levels you are eligible for at all.

B

Relevant experience

Years in your profession, including experience earned overseas, count towards your pay point. Documenting the full history matters, because paying someone at too low a pay point is one of the most common underpayments in this award.

C

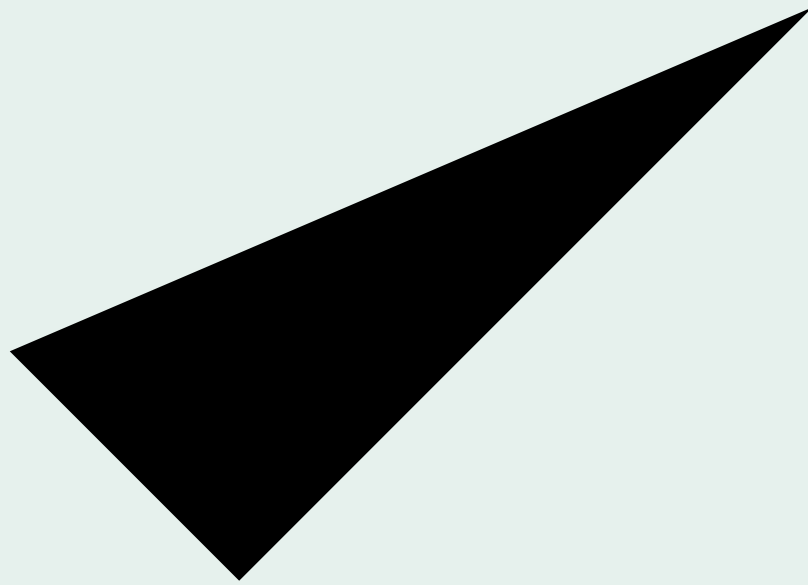
Scope & responsibility

Complexity of work, supervision of others and specialist scope move you up levels rather than pay points. Senior, lead and advanced-practice roles sit higher on the scale.

D

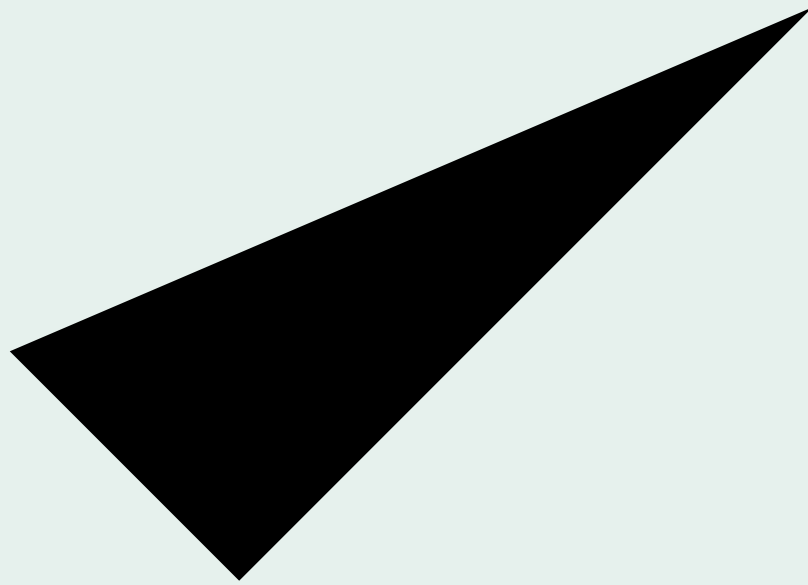
Progression over time

You typically move up a pay point each year of service, so pay grows steadily without renegotiating. Pay points should be reviewed annually. It is worth checking yours has actually moved.



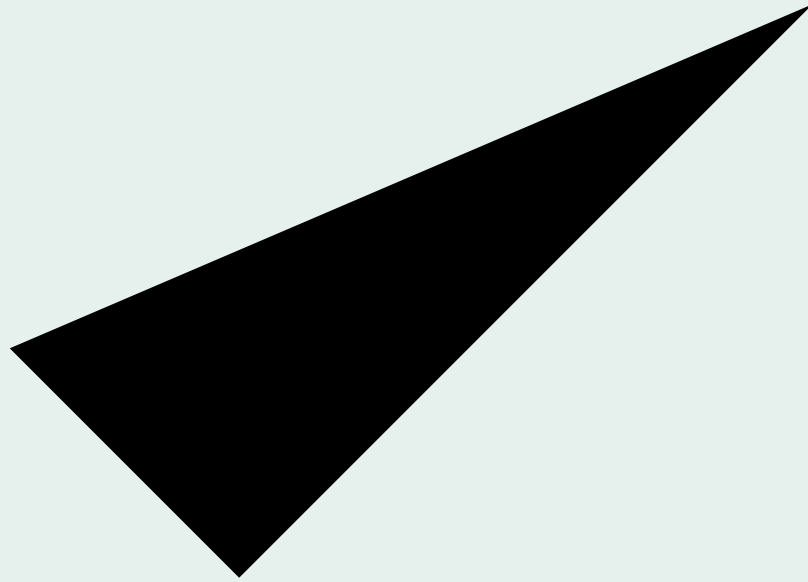
Document every year of practice

Your pay point rests on evidenced experience. Gaps or vagueness in your history cost you money, quietly and permanently.



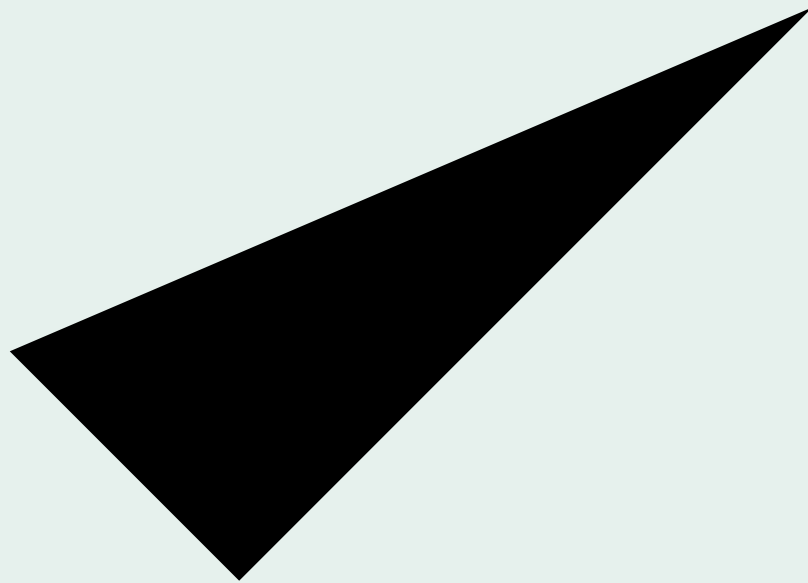
Get qualifications recognised

Post-graduate study and specialist training should be reflected in your application. They can lift both your classification and your options.



Ask which instrument applies

Award, enterprise agreement or individual contract? It changes everything about how the number was arrived at. Always a fair question to ask.



Ask for level and pay point in writing

Not just the salary, the classification behind it. An employer who cannot explain the placement plainly is worth a second look.

THE WHOLE PICTURE

Beyond the base rate

The figure at the top of an offer is rarely what lands in your account. A great deal sits on top of base pay, and shift work changes the total substantially.

150%

Saturday & Sunday

Both weekend days are paid at one and a half times the ordinary rate for full-time and part-time staff.

Casuals receive 175%.

250%

Public holidays

Two and a half times the ordinary rate, plus a substitute day off for permanent staff. Casuals receive 275%.

12%

Superannuation

Your employer contributes 12% of ordinary earnings into a retirement fund on top of your salary. It is compulsory, and it is yours.

1.5× → 2×

Overtime

Time and a half for the first hours, then double time, depending on the day. Rostered overtime can lift earnings well above base.

\$26.34

On-call, per 24 hours

Monday to Saturday, rising to \$52.56 on Sundays and public holidays. If you are called in, ordinary or overtime rates apply for the hours worked.

Shift loadings

Afternoon, night and permanent-night shifts attract loadings separate from weekend penalties, with a higher loading for permanent nights. The exact percentage depends on the shift pattern.

Leave

Four weeks of paid annual leave is the national minimum, plus personal and carer's leave, public holidays and long service leave. Shift workers are often entitled to a fifth week.

Practical allowances

Meal allowance of about \$17.30 where overtime runs long, plus uniform and laundry allowances. Small individually, but they are yours by right.

Relocation support

Not an award entitlement, but many employers recruiting internationally offer it. Where it exists, we will make sure you know exactly what is on the table.

GETTING THE RIGHT INSTRUMENT

Which award actually covers your profession

This is the detail that trips up most people reading Australian pay for the first time. There is no single healthcare award, professions are split across several, and the figures above only apply to one of them.

MA000027

Health Professionals & Support Services Award

Covers allied health professionals in the private sector: radiographers, sonographers, radiation therapists, nuclear medicine technologists, physiotherapists, occupational therapists, dietitians, podiatrists, audiologists and medical scientists. Health professional Levels 1–4, each with pay points. This is the award the rates above come from.

MA000034

Nurses Award

Registered and enrolled nurses and midwives sit under their own national award, with its own classification structure and rates, not the figures above. Aged-care personal-care staff and disability workers are covered by different awards again.

Doctors

Medical practitioners are excluded

Medical practitioners were removed from MA000027 coverage by Fair Work Commission determination from 1 July 2021. Consultant and specialist pay is set by state enterprise agreements, private practice arrangements or individual contracts, nowhere near an award minimum, and always confirmed role by role.

And if you are heading for a public hospital

Then the award is only your safety net. Your actual pay, hours, leave and progression come from the enterprise agreement covering that state or territory's public health service. Those agreements are public documents, and we will tell you which one applies and what it says for your classification before you consider a role.

Coverage is worth confirming rather than assuming, Fair Work's [Pay and Conditions Tool](https://www.fairwork.gov.au/pay-and-wages/pay-calculator) (<https://www.fairwork.gov.au/pay-and-wages/pay-calculator>) will tell you which instrument applies to a given role.

WHAT ACTUALLY LANDS IN YOUR ACCOUNT

Tax, super & take-home pay

Australian salaries are quoted before tax, and often quoted separately from superannuation, so the same role can be described two different ways. Knowing which you are being shown matters.

Income tax is deducted from each pay by your employer under **PAYG withholding**. You will need a **tax file number** soon after arriving. Giving it to your employer promptly means you are taxed at the correct rate rather than the top one. There is also a **Medicare levy**, a percentage of taxable income that helps fund the public health system, and higher earners without private hospital cover can pay an additional surcharge.

On top of your salary, your employer pays **superannuation at 12% of ordinary earnings** into a retirement fund. It is not deducted from your pay and it is not optional. When you compare an Australian offer with what you earn now, count it, it is real money, even though you cannot spend it yet. Watch for the difference between a salary quoted as base and one quoted as "package including super": the same role can look several thousand dollars apart depending on which convention the advert used.

There is **no separate National Insurance-style contribution** as in the UK, and GST is already included in displayed prices. Our [living & thriving guide](#) walks through setting up the everyday money side, bank account, tax file number and choosing a super fund, step by step.

A note on advice

Tax rates, thresholds and Medicare levy rules depend on your circumstances and visa, and they change. Always confirm the current position with the Australian Taxation Office or a registered tax agent. Ethicare are recruitment specialists, not financial advisers, but we are glad to introduce you to advisers we trust.

EARNING, AGAINST LIVING

Pay in the context of life here

A salary only means something against what it costs to live, and what it buys you beyond the bank balance. In Australia the geography does more to your money than the payslip does.

Where you live changes everything

Housing is the cost that surprises newcomers most, and it varies enormously. A regional city can stretch the same salary far further than a capital. Because pay is set state by state rather than nationally, both halves of the equation move when you move.

Regional roles often pay more

Workforce shortages are sharpest outside the big cities, so regional and remote roles frequently carry incentives, accommodation support or higher rates, alongside lower living costs and, for many, a better daily life.

The lifestyle dividend

Shorter commutes, the outdoors on your doorstep and a genuine cultural respect for time off mean many clinicians feel better off here even where the headline figure is comparable to home. Our [destination guides](#) help you weigh this up properly.

How pay is structured: Australia, New Zealand & the UK

A structural comparison, how the systems work, not what they pay. It is the shape of pay that differs most, and the shape is what you need to understand before you can read any figure.

	Australia	New Zealand	United Kingdom
How pay is set	National award floor, then state enterprise agreements above it	National collective agreements; published steps	National pay bands
Is there one national scale?	No, minimums are national, actual pay is state by state	Yes. The same role pays the same nationwide	Broadly yes
Negotiation	Collective in the public system; negotiable in private	Collective, not individual	Collective banding
On top of base	Penalties, shift loadings, 12% superannuation	Penal rates, allowances, KiwiSaver	Unsocial-hours pay, NHS pension
Tax admin	PAYG; Medicare levy; no NI equivalent	Simple PAYE; no NI; small ACC levy	PAYE plus National Insurance
Variation by location	Substantial, by state, and metro versus regional	Base is national; cost of living varies	Limited (London weighting)

Why we don't convert into your currency

Exchange rates, tax differences and cost of living make raw salary comparisons misleading. A figure that looks like a pay cut can be a substantial rise in practice, and occasionally the reverse. The useful question is monthly take-home against local costs, which is exactly the conversation we will have with you about your specific role.

— NO SURPRISES

Knowing your exact rate, before you decide

You should never have to accept a role on a vague sense of the pay. By the time you are weighing an offer, you will know precisely what you would earn and where the number comes from.

For any role we discuss, we will tell you **which instrument sets the pay**, award, enterprise agreement or contract, confirm the **current rate against that document**, tell you the **level and pay point** you would be placed on and why, and walk through the **full package**: base, penalties, shift loadings, superannuation and leave. Where pay is individually negotiated, we will say so plainly and tell you what the market is actually doing.

This is the heart of how we work: **calm, honest, no pressure**. A move this big deserves real numbers, straight answers and the time to think them over.

Sophie's insight

Money is rarely the first reason people move, but it has to add up, and it is the thing clinicians feel most awkward asking about. I would rather you ask us everything. Australia is harder to read than New Zealand, because there is no single national scale to point at, and I think that is exactly why so many salary guides end up quoting one number and hoping. We would rather show you the floor, tell you which agreement governs the role in front of you, and then talk honestly about what sits above it. You will know your real take-home, against the real cost of living where you are headed, long before you have to decide anything.

Sophie CEO & Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

— COMMON QUESTIONS

The questions we're asked about pay

Is the award rate what I'll actually be paid?—

Almost certainly not, it is the legal minimum, not the going rate. Public-hospital pay comes from the enterprise agreement for that state or territory and normally sits above the award. Private employers must meet the award floor but compete above it, sometimes well above it for skills in short supply. Use the award to sanity-check an offer, not to predict one.

Why does the same job pay differently in different states?+

Will my overseas experience count towards my pay point?+

Can I negotiate my salary in Australia?+

What is superannuation, and does it really count as pay?+

Do you publish typical or average salaries?+

How often do these figures change?+

KEEP EXPLORING

Related guides

CV & interview preparation

Your experience already speaks for itself. This step is about presenting it the way Australian employers read it.



Kettle on. A longer read – about 12 min

— WHAT DO YOU NEED HELP WITH?

Three things you can do right now

Pick the one you need now. The full guide is underneath for when you have a cup of tea and half an hour.

I want to get my CV right

Build my CV

A guided builder that puts your experience in the order Australian employers read it, and gives you a file to send.

Open the CV builder I want to prepare for interview

Prepare for my interview

The questions Australian panels actually ask, with somewhere to write and keep your own examples.

Prepare my answers I want to know if I'm ready

Check I'm ready

Registration, CV, referees, practical set-up. See what's done, what's missing and what to tackle next.

Run the readiness check

— START HERE

A clear, evidence-based CV

Australian healthcare CVs are clean and factual: what you can do and what you have done, backed by evidence, rather than a long personal statement. A busy manager should see your fit in under a minute.

A few things employers here look for that may differ from where you trained:

Your registration or accreditation status up front, registered, in progress, or eligible.

Clinical competencies and modalities stated plainly, with caseload or volume where it helps.

Reverse-chronological roles with dates, settings and responsibilities, with gaps explained briefly.

No photo, date of birth or marital status, they're not expected and best left off.

We help every candidate shape a CV that reads naturally to Australian employers, not by changing your experience, but by framing it the way the people hiring expect to see it.

— PRACTICAL

What goes in, section by section

There's no official format, but there is a shape that Australian hiring managers are used to reading. Follow it and your experience does the talking instead of your layout.

1

Name, contact, registration status

Top of page one. Whether you're registered, in progress or eligible is often the first thing a manager looks for, so don't bury it on page three.

2

A short professional summary

Three or four lines: your profession, years of experience, the settings you've worked in and what you're looking for. Not a personal statement, a précis.

3

Skills and modalities

Stated plainly, ideally with an indication of volume or independence. "Independent reporting across x and y" tells a manager more than a list of nouns.

4

Roles, most recent first

Employer type rather than brand (many managers won't know the hospital), setting, dates, and what you were actually responsible for. Brief explanations for any gaps.

5

Qualifications and CPD

Your qualifying award, where and when, then relevant post-qualification training. Recent CPD signals someone who keeps current.

6

References, on request

Two is standard, ideally including a recent clinical supervisor. Ask them before you list them, and warn them about the time difference.

LEARNED THE HARD WAY

The mistakes we see most

None of these are about competence. They're about a CV or an interview not showing the competence that's already there.

What helps

Naming your registration status in the first few lines

Describing settings and systems, not just job titles

Two or three specific stories you can tell naturally

Being clear about what you want next, and why Australia

Explaining a career gap briefly and without apology

Asking your own questions at the end

What quietly costs you

A photo, date of birth or marital status, leave them off

Assuming a manager knows your hospital, region or grading system

Untranslated local acronyms and banding shorthand
Ten pages when four would do, or one page when four are needed
Rehearsed answers that don't quite answer the question asked
Treating "why Australia?" as small talk, it's a real question

WHAT TO EXPECT

How interviews tend to run

Interviews for overseas candidates are usually done by video, and are often more conversational than formal. Knowing the shape of it takes most of the nerves away.

Format

Often a video call

A panel of one to three people, typically a manager and a senior clinician, by Teams or Zoom, allowing for the time difference. Usually one or two stages.

Tone

Conversational

Friendly and on first-name terms. They're assessing competence, but also whether you'll be a good colleague, so it's as much a two-way conversation as a test.

Focus

Real situations

Expect questions grounded in practice: how you handled something, how you work in a team, how you keep patients safe, rather than abstract puzzles.

THE WEEK BEFORE

Preparing for the call

A video interview across time zones has a few practical failure modes that have nothing to do with your clinical ability. Close those off and you can concentrate on the conversation.

1

Confirm the time twice

In their time zone and yours, in writing. Australia spans several zones and only some observe daylight saving, which catches people out every year.

2

Test the link, not just the laptop

Open the actual meeting link a day early. Check camera, microphone, and that whatever's behind you is something you're happy for a panel to look at.

3

Prepare three stories, not thirty answers

One about a difficult clinical situation, one about a team or a disagreement, one about improving something. Most behavioural questions can be answered from those three.

4

Know the service you're applying to

Not trivia, just context: what kind of service it is, the population it serves, and where your role sits in it. We'll brief you on this properly beforehand.

5

Have your own questions written down

Nerves erase them. A short list on paper, next to you, is completely acceptable and makes you look considered rather than unprepared.

6

Plan for the connection dropping

Agree a fallback in advance: a phone number to call, or who reconnects first. It happens often enough to be worth a sentence beforehand.

BE READY FOR THESE

Questions to expect

You won't be able to predict every question, but most fall into a few families. Have a couple of real examples ready for each, the "tell me about a time..." style rewards specifics.

Clinical & technical

Your scope, the modalities or cases you're confident with, how you stay current, and how you'd handle an unfamiliar situation safely.

Teamwork & communication

Working in a multidisciplinary team, raising a concern, handling a difficult interaction with a colleague or patient.

You & the move

Why Australia, why this role, and whether you've thought the relocation through, they want to know you'll stay and settle.

Worth rehearsing out loud: “Tell me about a time something went wrong and what you did.” “How do you raise a concern about a colleague’s practice?” “What would you do on a shift where you were asked to work outside your scope?” “Why Australia, and why now?” Four questions, in some form, come up in most interviews we sit in on.

— IT GOES BOTH WAYS

Questions worth asking them

You’re deciding too, and an interview where you ask nothing reads as an interview where you didn’t care. These also happen to be the questions whose answers matter most once you’ve arrived.

About the work

What does a typical week look like? What’s the case mix? How is the team staffed at the moment, and what’s the plan? What does support look like in the first few months?

About progression

How do people develop here? Is there protected time for CPD? What have previous international clinicians in this team gone on to do?

About arriving

What relocation support exists? Who helps with the practical side of landing? Is there anyone in the team who’s made the same move?

— THE THING THAT SETS CANDIDATES APART

Showing you’ll fit the team

Australian healthcare is collaborative and patient-centred, with a genuine emphasis on respectful, culturally safe care. Employers hire people who’ll add to that, not just tick the clinical boxes.

You don’t need to perform, just be ready to show, with examples, that you communicate openly, work flatly within a team, ask when you’re unsure, and treat patients and colleagues with respect. A little awareness of the local context (that you’ve thought about practising in a new system and culture) goes a long way.

What happens after the interview

The waiting is the part nobody prepares you for. Here's the honest shape of it, so silence doesn't get read as bad news.

Decisions rarely come the same day. A panel usually needs to reconvene, and public services often have an approval step after that, so a few days to a couple of weeks is normal rather than ominous. We chase on your behalf, and we'll tell you what we're hearing even when what we're hearing is "not yet".

If an offer comes, read it properly before you celebrate: the role and its level, hours, on-call expectations, start date, and what relocation support is included. Ask about anything unclear now, because it's far harder to raise once you've accepted. And if the answer is no, ask for feedback. It's usually given generously here, and it's often about timing or scope rather than you.

One thing we'd say plainly: don't resign anything, or give notice on a home, until your offer and your visa are both real. We'll tell you when that point has arrived.

Sophie's insight

The clinicians who interview well are rarely the ones with the slickest answers, they're the ones who've prepared two or three honest, specific stories and can talk about them naturally. We'll do a proper prep call before any interview: the likely questions, the panel, the role, and the small cultural things that make a difference. You'll walk in knowing what to expect, which is most of the battle.

Sophie CEO & Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

COMMON QUESTIONS

The things people ask us first

How long should my CV be?—

For most clinical roles, two to four pages is right: long enough to evidence your experience and modalities, short enough to stay readable. We'll help you trim or expand it to suit the role and your seniority.

Will the interview be in person?+

What if I'm asked something I don't know?+

Do you help with references?+

Should I explain a gap in my CV?+

Can I ask about pay in the interview?+

What if I interview badly on the day?+

How many roles should I apply for at once?+

— HELPFUL ALONGSIDE THIS STEP

Read a little deeper

— BEFORE YOU SEND IT

Not sure you're ready to apply?

Run through a quick check of your registration, CV, references and practical readiness. You'll see what's done, what's missing and what to tackle next. Nothing is stored anywhere but your own device.



● NEW ZEALAND



● AUSTRALIA

THE RELOCATION COST GUIDE

What does it really cost to get there?

The cash you need in hand, stage by stage

Not what you'll earn, and not what it costs to live. The cash you need in hand to actually execute the move, and the bit that catches people out.



Kettle on. A longer read — about 14 min

14 sections

Updated August 2026

Free · no sign-up

— THE MONEY, IN ORDER

Seven stages, and the cash each one needs

Relocation costs arrive in a sequence, not all at once, which is what makes them manageable if you plan, and brutal if you don't. Jump to any stage.

- 1Registration Fees, assessments, documents
- 2Visa Immigration, medicals, checks
- 3Flights Seats, baggage, freight
- 4Shipping Or selling and starting again
- 5Temporary home Weeks, not days
- 6First rental Bond, rent, everything inside
- 7Transport A car, sooner than expected

And then one more thing

After all seven comes the stage nobody budgets for: **the gap before your first pay day**. It lands at exactly the moment the other seven have emptied your account.

— THE PRACTICAL QUESTION

Flights are the obvious cost. They're rarely the whole story.

Moving to Australia or New Zealand for a healthcare role can be an incredible opportunity. It can also be expensive, and for anyone moving with a partner and children, considerably more so.

Professional registration, visas, medicals, temporary accommodation, rental deposits, transport and setting up a new home add up surprisingly quickly. So before accepting a role, it's worth asking a very practical question:

How much money will we actually need to make the move?

There isn't one figure that works for everybody. But there are costs you can anticipate, and a few that regularly catch people by surprise. This guide walks the sequence, then helps you build your own number rather than borrowing somebody else's, and if you would rather do the arithmetic than read it, the **cost of moving calculator** builds the same budget from your answers.

— STAGE 01

Professional registration

For healthcare professionals, the cost of relocating often begins long before the flight.

Depending on your profession and pathway, you may need to pay for some combination of:

- Registration or application fees
- Qualification assessments
- English language testing
- Certificates of good standing
- Police checks
- Certified documents and translations
- Examinations or competency assessments
- Annual practising or registration fees

A radiologist, GP, psychologist and radiographer can have completely different registration journeys. Your individual circumstances matter too, two people in the same profession may face different requirements depending on where they trained and what they've done since.

Do this first

Establish your likely registration pathway *before* you budget anything else, because it's the cost that varies most between two apparently similar clinicians.

— STAGE 02

Visas & immigration

Another area where a single headline figure misleads. What you pay depends on the country, the visa route, and whether you're relocating alone or with family.

There may also be associated costs for medical examinations, police certificates, document certification or immigration advice. Some employers cover or contribute towards these. Others don't.

The assumption that costs people money

Don't assume "visa sponsorship" means every immigration-related expense is covered. Before accepting an offer, ask exactly what the employer will pay for and what remains yours.

— STAGE 03

Flights

A one-way flight for one clinician is one thing. Flights for two adults and three children are quite another.

Prices vary significantly with the time of year, departure country, baggage requirements and how much flexibility you have over dates. And remember luggage: moving internationally on the standard airline allowance is difficult, particularly with children, so additional baggage or freight may need to be part of the budget.

Ask how, not just whether

If your employer offers a flight allowance, establish whether they book directly, reimburse afterwards, or provide a fixed contribution. That distinction matters enormously for cash flow *before* departure, a reimbursement you receive in month two doesn't help you buy the tickets.

— STAGE 04

Shipping, or starting again?

There isn't a universally correct answer, and the assumption that an international move requires a shipping container costs some families thousands they didn't need to spend.

Ship it

Slow, and not always cheap

International shipping can be expensive and slow, and large items may be less practical in your eventual home than they were in your current one. But replacing the contents of a whole family home isn't cheap either.

Start again

Personal things only

Many families take personal belongings and a few important possessions, then buy furniture after arriving. Some clinicians move ahead of their family with a couple of suitcases and arrange everything later.

Work out what suits you

Some families ship almost everything and are glad they did. Others arrive with four suitcases and never miss the rest. Decide from your circumstances, not from what an international move is supposed to look like.

STAGE 05

Temporary accommodation

This is the cost people underestimate most often.

You may not be able, or want, to sign a long-term rental agreement before seeing a property. That can mean spending your first few weeks in a hotel, serviced apartment or short-term let, and the longer it takes to find a suitable home, the more expensive it becomes. Families with requirements around bedrooms, schools and location often take longer.

Find out exactly how long

If an employer provides temporary accommodation, establish precisely how many nights. Two weeks disappears very quickly when you're starting a new job at the same time as house-hunting in a city you don't know.

STAGE 06

Getting into your first rental

Finding the property is only part of the expense. You need enough money available to actually move into it.

Upfront rental requirements differ between Australia and New Zealand and are subject to local rules, but expect to need money available for a rental bond and rent around the start of the tenancy. Then comes everything the house needs at once:

Bedding and towels

Kitchen equipment, down to a kettle

Cleaning products

Internet and utilities connection

And the dozens of small purchases that look trivial individually

None of these are significant on their own. All of them arriving in the same fortnight is a different matter, and if you're relocating with children, the list grows.

STAGE 07

You may need a car sooner than expected

Whether you need one depends heavily on where you live. Someone working and living centrally in Melbourne or Auckland has very different requirements from a clinician moving to a smaller city or regional community.

In many locations, particularly with children, a car makes everyday life considerably easier. Potential costs include buying or financing the vehicle, registration, insurance, fuel, and converting or obtaining the appropriate driving licence. If both adults will be working in different locations, you may eventually need two.

Decide this before the house, not after

Transport and accommodation are one decision, not two. Choosing a home without working out how you'll get to work is how a cheaper rent becomes an expensive year.

RUNNING ALONGSIDE

Three costs that don't sit in the sequence

These don't belong to a stage. They run underneath all seven, and they're where a carefully built budget usually springs a leak.

Your costs back home

They don't stop when you land

You may still have a mortgage or rent, insurance, storage, loan repayments, professional memberships, the costs of selling or letting your property, and other existing commitments.

If your family follows several months later, you may temporarily be funding households in two countries. That can be the most financially demanding way to relocate, even though for some families it's the most practical. **Map that overlap before committing to a start date.**

Your partner's income

Don't assume day one

Particularly important for families who normally rely on two incomes. Your partner may need time to find work, may have their own registration requirements if they're in a regulated profession, or you may decide one parent concentrates on settling the children first.

Don't build your first-year budget around both adults earning immediately. If the second income arrives quickly, excellent. If it doesn't, you don't want the whole move to become financially stressful.

And if you're moving with children

Budget differently from an individual: school uniforms, stationery, devices, childcare, before- and after-school care, sports equipment and activities. Even where individual amounts are modest, they arrive together. The first few weeks of a relocation are often a period when money seems to leave the account constantly, that's normal when you're establishing an entire household, and it's exactly why a buffer matters.

— THE GAP NOBODY BUDGETS FOR

Your first salary may be further away than you think

Starting work doesn't mean being paid. Depending on your employer's payroll cycle and your start date, there can be a real gap before your first full salary reaches your account.

It arrives at precisely the wrong moment. At the same time, you may be paying for temporary accommodation, a rental bond, furniture, transport and everyday living.

One question, asked early

"When will I actually receive my first payment?" It is a very simple question, almost nobody asks it, and the answer makes budgeting the first two months dramatically easier.

— THE OTHER SIDE OF THE LEDGER

What will your employer pay for?

This can materially change the cost of your move. Depending on the employer, profession and how hard the vacancy has been to fill, support ranges from very little to substantial.

What might be covered

Ask a better question

Relocation support might include contributions towards flights, visa costs, professional registration, temporary accommodation, shipping, general relocation expenses or immigration assistance.

Some employers offer a fixed relocation allowance. Others reimburse specified expenses up to a maximum. Some offer very little, and some particularly hard-to-fill positions come with a great deal.

So don't ask *"is there relocation assistance?"* Ask **"what exactly does the relocation package cover?"**

Watch for repayment clauses

It isn't always free money

An employer may require you to repay some or all of the contribution if you leave within a specified period. That isn't necessarily unreasonable, they're investing significant money in your move.

But you need to understand the terms before accepting. Read the contract carefully, ask what the period is, and ask what happens if you leave for reasons outside your control.

Relocation support is also one of the most negotiable parts of an offer, sometimes more so than the salary itself. Our [guide to negotiating an offer](#) covers how to raise it.

— YOUR NUMBER, NOT SOMEBODY ELSE'S

How much should you have saved?

One savings target for everyone would be misleading. A single clinician whose employer covers flights and temporary accommodation may need relatively little upfront; a family shipping belongings and establishing a four-bedroom home may need many thousands more.

So rather than borrowing an arbitrary number, build your own **relocation fund** in three parts.

Part one

Before departure

Registration, immigration, medicals and documentation, flights, and shipping if you're shipping. Everything you pay while still at home.

Part two

Arrival costs

Temporary accommodation, rental bond and initial rent, transport, and furnishing and equipping the house.

Part three

Living buffer

Enough accessible money to cover everyday life until your salary, and potentially your partner's, is properly established.

Then do the subtraction

Take off anything the employer has confirmed **in writing** that they will cover. What's left is a far more meaningful figure than anyone else's relocation budget, and it's specific enough to plan against.

Build it with your own figures

The cost of moving calculator does this arithmetic for you

Answer a few questions about your profession, your household and where you are going. It applies the published registration and visa fees, works the bond and rent in advance out of the tenancy rules where you are moving, subtracts what your employer is contributing, and gives you a figure you can print.

Every number editable

Official fees sourced and dated

Nothing personal asked



— THE LAST RULE

Keep an emergency buffer separate

If you possibly can, don't spend every available dollar getting there.

International moves don't always go to plan.

A property may take longer to find than you expected.

A partner's job may take longer to arrive.

Your belongings may be delayed in transit.

The car may need repairing.

You may need to fly home unexpectedly.

Money that remains untouched after the move makes every one of those situations considerably less stressful, and none of them less likely.

Don't let the total put you off

Added together, this can sound daunting. But not everybody pays for everything themselves. Employers contribute. Families relocate in stages. Some people sell furniture rather than shipping it. Others arrive in furnished accommodation and take their time. The important thing is knowing the likely costs *before* you

commit. A well-planned move is a completely different experience from discovering that your first salary needs to cover a bond, furniture, a car and six weeks of living all at once.

Sophie's insight

We see relocation as more than securing a job and obtaining a visa. The moment that worries me for people isn't the flight. It's week three, when the temporary accommodation is ending, the bond is due, the house is empty and the first pay day hasn't arrived. Almost nobody plans for that fortnight, and it colours how the whole move feels. So we'd rather have the unglamorous conversation early: what the employer will actually cover in writing, when you'll be paid, and what you need in the bank before you get on the plane. Getting the job is only the beginning. Arriving with financial breathing room is what lets you start the new life well.

Sophie Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

COMMON QUESTIONS

The questions we're asked about relocation costs

Can you give me a single figure to save?–

Honestly, no, and anyone who does is guessing. A single clinician whose employer covers flights and temporary accommodation needs a fraction of what a family of five shipping belongings and furnishing a house needs. Build the three-part fund above, subtract what your employer has confirmed in writing, and you'll have a number that means something.

Does “visa sponsorship” mean my immigration costs are paid?+

Should I ship my furniture?+

How long should I expect to be in temporary accommodation?+

What if I have to repay relocation assistance?+

Is relocation support negotiable?+

EXPLORE FURTHER

Read a little deeper

Living & thriving in Australia

Arriving is the start, not the finish. How you settle, at work and beyond it, decides whether the move lasts.

— PAGE AT A GLANCE

1. [Settling into work](#)
2. [Finding your people](#)
3. [The everyday life](#)
4. [Belonging & home](#)
5. [What we do after you land](#)
6. [Staying supported](#)
7. [Common questions](#)

Kettle on. A longer read — about 7 min

— THE FIRST MONTHS AT WORK

Finding your feet in a new system

Practising in a new country takes adjustment: new systems, new colleagues, a slightly different culture of care. Australian teams are used to welcoming international clinicians and describe a runway rather than a cold plunge.

Expect a proper induction, supportive colleagues and, where relevant, a period of orientation or supervision as you find your rhythm. The culture tends to be collaborative and relatively flat: first names, open communication, multidisciplinary teamwork, and many clinicians say care feels a touch less rushed than they were used to. Within a few months, the unfamiliar becomes ordinary.

One national registration means your career isn't fixed to one place: as you settle, you can develop, specialise or move between states without starting your paperwork over.

YOU WON'T ARRIVE TO STRANGERS

Finding your people

A job is only part of a life. The families who thrive are the ones who build connection early, and Australia, as one of the most multicultural countries on earth, makes that easier than most.

Your community

Already here

Whatever your background, there's likely an established community from home: cultural associations, events and networks that make the first months feel familiar.

Faith

A place to worship

Churches, mosques, temples, gurdwaras and faith communities of every kind are part of the fabric of Australian cities and towns.

Through the kids

School & sport

Children's schools and weekend sport are, for many parents, where friendships form fastest, for the whole family.

THE REASON MANY CAME

The everyday life

Not the holiday version – what an ordinary week here actually looks like, because that is the part you live.

The outdoors, on tap

Beaches, parks, bush and sport are woven into normal life. An early swim, a weekend hike, a barbecue in the park, the climate makes the outdoors a default, not an effort.

Room to breathe

Outside the biggest-city centres, space and shorter commutes give time back. For many, that reclaimed time is the single biggest change.

A childhood outside

Families consistently say it's a wonderful place to raise children: safe, active and outdoors, with strong schools and a gentler pace.

— MAKING IT LAST

From a long stay to a home

There's a difference between living somewhere and belonging there, and the move only really succeeds when it crosses that line.

It helps to stay honest about the hard parts, the distance from family is real, and most people plan trips home and regular calls to manage it. But belonging tends to creep up quietly: a local you're a regular at, neighbours who know your name, a team that feels like yours, children who sound like locals. Give it a year, keep saying yes to invitations, and the place stops being somewhere you moved to and starts being home.

— WHAT WE DO AFTER YOU LAND

You'll hear from us when it's hardest

Most agencies are busiest before you fly and quiet afterwards. We work the other way round: almost everyone hits a wobbly stretch around the third month, and our support is timed for it.

1

The week you land

We know your arrival date, and you have a mobile number that a person answers. Not a duty line or a ticket, the same people you've dealt with all along, who know your name and your situation.

2

Your first fortnight

We call once the adrenaline wears off, when the admin arrives all at once: tax file number, bank account, Medicare, school enrolment. We'll also introduce you to a family who made the same move to your area, if you'd like that.

3

Around three months

A deliberate check-in, timed for the dip, because we know it's coming. It's the call people are most surprised to get and most glad of. Not a satisfaction survey, just an honest conversation about how it's actually going.

4

A year on, and after that

There's no end date on it. A contract question, a move interstate, work for your partner, a reference years later. We'd rather you called. We measure this work by how you're living a year on, not by the placement.

We're a small team, not a concierge service. The settling in is yours to do – what we promise is that you'll always know who to call, and they'll already know your story.

Sophie's insight

We measure a good move in years, not weeks, which is why we don't disappear once you've landed. The clinicians we placed are the ones we check in on, introduce to others, and help when the next decision comes around. Settling takes a season or two; thriving takes saying yes to the place. If you keep us posted, we'll keep helping. That's rather the point of doing this properly.

SophieCEO & Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

COMMON QUESTIONS

The things people ask us first

How long until it feels like home?—

For most people, the practical side settles within weeks and the emotional side within a year. The turning point is usually social: once you have a few real friendships and a routine that's yours, it stops feeling like a move and starts feeling like life.

Will I keep progressing in my career?+

How do people manage the distance from home?+

Can I move to a different state later?+

PICK UP WHERE IT HELPS

Keep exploring

Renting in Australia

There is no national tenancy law. Eight states and territories, eight rulebooks, and one application problem every arriving clinician shares.

PAGE AT A GLANCE

1. [There is no national tenancy law](#)
2. [Your state's rulebook](#)
3. [The real obstacle: no rental history](#)
4. [Building an application that competes](#)
5. [Bond and money up front](#)
6. [What “unfurnished” means here](#)
7. [Open homes and how viewings work](#)
8. [Your rights once you are in](#)
9. [Why we would not sign before you land](#)
10. [Scams, and how to spot them](#)
11. [Common questions](#)

Kettle on. A longer read — about 18 min

START HERE

There is no national tenancy law in Australia

This is the thing that catches people out, and everything else on this page follows from it. Renting is regulated by each state and territory, not by the Commonwealth.

Eight jurisdictions, eight separate Residential Tenancies Acts, eight different bond authorities and eight different sets of rules on how often rent can rise, what minimum standards a property must meet, how much notice ends a tenancy and whether you can keep a pet. Someone who rented in Melbourne and then moves to Brisbane is learning a new system, not a regional variation of the same one.

So the useful question is never “how does renting work in Australia”. It is “how does renting work in the state I am moving to”. The table below points you at the right authority for each one – they are the primary source, they are free, and they are more current than any guide including this one.

What *is* consistent across the country is the shape of the process: you find a property listed online, you attend a short inspection, you apply afterwards in competition with other applicants, and the successful applicant pays a bond that is lodged with a government body rather than held by the agent. The rest of this page is about that shape, and about the one part of it that is harder for an arriving clinician than for a local.

THE PRIMARY SOURCE

Your state’s rulebook, and who holds your bond

Bookmark the row for your destination before you start looking. Every one of these authorities publishes plain-English tenant guides, standard lease terms and a free dispute service.

State or territory	Tenancy authority & bond holder	Worth knowing
New South Wales	NSW Fair Trading (https://www.fairtrading.nsw.gov.au/housing-and-property/renting) Bonds held via Rental Bonds Online	Bond is lodged online and released only when both parties agree or the tribunal decides.
Victoria	Consumer Affairs Victoria (https://www.consumer.vic.gov.au/housing/renting) Bonds held by the Residential Tenancies Bond Authority	Victoria has an explicit set of minimum standards a rental must meet before it is let.
Queensland	Residential Tenancies Authority (https://www.rta.qld.gov.au/) The RTA holds bonds directly	The RTA runs a free dispute resolution service before anything reaches a tribunal.
Western Australia	Consumer Protection WA (https://www.commerce.wa.gov.au/consumer-protection/renting-home) Bonds lodged with the Bond Administrator	Worth reading early if you are moving to a resources region, where the market moves fast.
South Australia	Consumer and Business Services (https://www.cbs.sa.gov.au/renting-letting) CBS holds bonds	Bond amounts are tiered by the weekly rent, so check which tier your property falls into.
Tasmania	Consumer, Building and Occupational Services (https://www.cbos.tas.gov.au/topics/housing/renting) Rental Deposit Authority holds bonds	A small, tight rental market. Start looking earlier than you would elsewhere.
Australian Capital Territory	Access Canberra (https://www.accesscanberra.act.gov.au/) Bonds lodged with the ACT Revenue Office	The ACT has some of the strongest tenant protections in the country.
Northern Territory	Consumer Affairs NT (https://consumeraffairs.nt.gov.au/for-consumers/residential-tenancies) Bond arrangements set under NT tenancy law	Many Top End roles come with subsidised or provided housing, ask before you search.

Authorities and their web addresses occasionally change. If a link here does not resolve, search the authority name plus “renting” and tell us, and we will correct the page.

THE HONEST DIFFICULTY

The real obstacle is not money. It is that you have no history here.

Australian agents rarely accept or reject an application. They rank the applications they receive and put a shortlist to the owner, who chooses. Understanding that changes what you should be trying to do.

A local applicant arrives with things you do not have: a rental ledger showing two years of payments on time, references from an Australian agent, and a local credit file. You are not being judged as unsuitable. You are being judged as unknown, and an owner choosing between a known quantity and an unknown one will usually take the known one unless you have given them a reason not to.

The good news, and it is good: a signed healthcare employment contract is one of the strongest documents in that pile. Clinical employment reads as stable, well-paid and unlikely to evaporate. Many arriving clinicians are, on paper, a better financial prospect than the local applicant with the rental ledger. The task is to make that legible.

In our experience

The applications that succeed are the ones that answer the questions nobody asked out loud

An agent looking at an overseas application has three unspoken worries: can this person actually pay, will they still be in the country in a year, and can I verify any of this. A pack that answers all three before being asked tends to move to the top of the pile.

The single most effective thing we see is a short covering note. Three or four sentences, no more, that says what you do, who you are employed by, when you start and that you are happy to provide anything else. It costs nothing and it is startlingly rare.

WHAT TO PREPARE

Building an application that competes

Have all of this ready as PDFs before you view anything. Applications are usually submitted through an online platform within hours of an inspection, and the ones that go in complete and first do best.

What every application asks for

Photo identification. Passport, and your driving licence if you have it. Most platforms score you on points of ID.

Proof of income. Your signed employment contract or offer letter is the key document. Recent payslips from your current post help.

Proof of funds. A bank statement showing you can cover bond, rent in advance and the first weeks.

Rental references. From your current landlord or agent, wherever in the world that is. Translated if not in English.

Personal or professional references. A colleague or manager is fine, and easy to arrange before you leave.

Visa evidence. Your grant notice or application status, which tells the owner how long you can stay.

What separates a strong application

The covering note. Three sentences: what you do, where you will be working, when you arrive. Nothing more.

Offering to pay more rent in advance rather than more bond. Bond is capped by law; rent in advance usually is not, and it reassures without breaking any rule.

Being contactable in Australian hours during the week you apply, even if that is inconvenient from your time zone.

Applying to fewer properties, properly. Six complete applications beat twenty rushed ones.

A local guarantor if you happen to have one, useful, but never necessary, and never worth delaying for.

Honesty about pets. Rules vary by state and hiding an animal is the fastest way to lose a tenancy.

— THE MONEY, AS RULES

Bond and what you pay up front

We deliberately publish no rent or bond amounts anywhere on this site. They move every quarter, and a figure that was true when this was written would mislead you later. The rules behind the numbers are what last.

Bond is expressed in weeks, not dollars

It is a multiple of the weekly rent, and it is capped by your state or territory's tenancy law. Four weeks is the common maximum for an unfurnished home, with some jurisdictions allowing more where the property is furnished or the rent is above a threshold. Because it is a multiple, it tracks the market automatically, which is exactly why quoting an amount here would be pointless.

You will also pay rent in advance

Typically two weeks, sometimes more, paid at signing on top of the bond. Together these are the largest single outlay of the whole move for most people, and the one worth having liquid and ready before you land.

A government authority holds your bond, not the agent

This is a genuine protection and it is worth understanding. In every state and territory the bond is lodged with the relevant authority from the table above, and neither you nor the owner can release it unilaterally at the end of the tenancy. You should receive written confirmation of the lodgement. If you do not, ask for it.

Rent is usually paid fortnightly

Australian rent is quoted per week and most commonly paid fortnightly or monthly by direct debit. If you are used to thinking in monthly rent, multiply the weekly figure by 52 and divide by 12 rather than by four. The difference over a year is most of an extra month.

Letting fees are not charged to tenants

Unlike some countries, you should not be asked to pay a fee to the agent for the privilege of applying or being granted a tenancy. If you are, that is a warning sign worth checking against your state authority.

For what a month actually looks like in a particular city, which lines are large, which are small, and which catch people out, each of our [destination guides](#) has a cost-of-living chapter written for that place, with live calculators so you can compare against the city you are leaving.

A PRACTICAL SURPRISE

“Unfurnished” does not mean what you might expect

This one costs arriving families real money in their first fortnight, and almost nobody warns them.

Usually not included

A fridge. The single most common surprise. Unfurnished means no fridge, and you will want one on day one.

A washing machine, and a dryer, though in much of Australia a line in the sun does the job for most of the year.

A dishwasher in older stock, though newer builds and apartments usually have one fitted.

Furniture of any kind, including beds, in the ordinary sense of unfurnished.

Usually included

Built-in wardrobes in most bedrooms. Freestanding wardrobes are far less common here than in Europe.

Oven, cooktop and rangehood, fitted as standard.

Window coverings, blinds or curtains, which matters more than it sounds given the summer sun.

Air conditioning or a reverse-cycle heat pump in most of the country, and increasingly treated as essential rather than a luxury.

Ceiling fans, often in every room in the warmer states.

The practical answer is to buy second-hand for the first year. Australia has a large, entirely unsnobbish second-hand market for whitegoods and furniture, and buying a used fridge and washing machine in your first week is completely normal behaviour rather than a sign of struggling. Replace them properly once you know which suburb you actually want to stay in.

— HOW IT ACTUALLY GOES

Open homes, and how quickly this moves

The rhythm is different from a private appointment with an agent, and it rewards preparation over deliberation.

Most properties are shown at an **open home**. A fixed slot, often fifteen minutes on a Saturday morning, where anyone who has registered turns up at once. You will be one of several groups walking through the same rooms. You register online beforehand, you are asked to sign in on arrival, and the agent is there to answer questions rather than to sell you anything.

You do not negotiate at the inspection and you do not make an offer there. You go away, submit an application through whichever online platform that agency uses, and wait. Decisions frequently come within a day or two in a busy market, and properties are commonly leased within a week of first being listed.

Two practical consequences. First, have your documents assembled before you attend anything, because the gap between viewing and applying is hours, not days. Second, if you are arriving into a tight market, expect to be unsuccessful a few times before you are successful. That is the normal experience of a good applicant in a competitive market, not a signal that something is wrong with your application.

If you cannot attend in person, most agencies will accept an application from someone who has viewed by video or had a friend attend on their behalf. It is not ideal, and the next section explains why we would still rather you waited.

— ONCE YOU ARE IN

Your rights as a tenant

Australian tenancy law is reasonably protective, and it is enforced through free, accessible tribunals rather than the courts. The detail varies by state; the principles are broadly shared.

Condition report

Photograph everything on day one

You will be given a condition report to check and return within a few days of moving in. Complete it properly and take date-stamped photographs of every room, every mark and every appliance. This document is what protects your bond at the other end, and it is the single most-skipped step in the process.

Repairs

Urgent and non-urgent are different in law

Every jurisdiction distinguishes urgent repairs. No hot water, a burst pipe, an unsafe electrical fault, from ordinary maintenance, with faster obligations and a route to arrange the work yourself if the owner does not act. Report in writing, always, even after phoning.

Rent increases

Limited in frequency, and notice is required

Rent cannot be raised whenever the owner likes. Every state limits how often an increase can occur during a periodic tenancy and requires written notice, and several have tightened those rules recently. Your state authority publishes the current position.

Entry

The owner cannot turn up

Inspections, repairs and viewings all require notice, in a form and period set by your state. Routine inspections happen. Commonly a couple of times a year, and are entirely normal rather than a sign of suspicion.

Ending a tenancy

Notice periods run both ways

Fixed-term leases are the norm, typically six or twelve months, after which most roll into a periodic tenancy. Breaking a lease early is possible but usually carries a cost. Ask what it would be *before* you sign, particularly if your role has a probationary period.

Disputes

Free tribunals, and they are used

Every state has a tenancy tribunal that is accessible, low-cost and used routinely by ordinary tenants. You do not need a lawyer. Most disputes about bond are resolved this way, and going there is not an escalation to be embarrassed about.

OUR ADVICE

We would not sign a lease before you land

This is the one piece of housing advice we give everyone, and the one people most often want to ignore because uncertainty is uncomfortable.

A twelve-month lease signed from photographs commits you to a suburb you have never stood in. Photographs do not carry the sound of the road at seven in the morning, which way the living room faces in February, whether the walk to the station is pleasant or grim, or how the commute to your actual hospital feels on a wet Monday. Those are the things that decide whether you like where you live, and none of them survive a listing.

What we suggest instead: book four to six weeks of temporary accommodation near where you will be working, arrive, and spend the first fortnight looking properly while you settle into the job. It feels less organised. It consistently produces better decisions, and it costs less than breaking a lease.

In our experience

Every clinician we have placed who regretted their first home had signed it remotely

Not one of them chose badly through carelessness. They chose from the information available, which was photographs and a map, and the information available was not enough.

The families who settle fastest are usually the ones who arrived with somewhere to sleep for a month and no lease, which sounds like the riskier plan and is not. If your employer offers temporary accommodation as part of the package, take it, and if they have not mentioned it, it is a reasonable thing to ask for.

— PROTECT YOURSELF

Scams, and how to spot them

Overseas applicants are targeted specifically, because the scam depends on you being unable to visit the property. The pattern is nearly always the same.

Treat any of these as a stop sign

A request for bond or rent before a lease is signed. No legitimate agent asks for money to hold a property you have not been granted.

An agent who will not do a live video walkthrough. If they cannot show you the property in real time, on request, there may not be a property.

Payment by anything other than bank transfer to a business account, gift cards, cryptocurrency, a personal account, a money transfer service. Never.

A bond that is not being lodged with the state authority. Ask which authority and request the lodgement confirmation. A real agent produces it without hesitation.

Pressure and a deadline. “Three other applicants are waiting, I need the deposit today” is the core of the scam. Real competition exists; real agents do not take deposits to end it.

A price noticeably below the market for the suburb, especially with photographs that appear elsewhere online. Reverse-image search the listing photos.

An agency you cannot verify. Licensed agents are searchable on your state authority’s register. Check the licence, not the website.

If something feels wrong, send it to us before you send anyone money. We would much rather read a listing for you than help afterwards, and it takes us a few minutes.

— COMMON QUESTIONS

The things people ask us first

Can I rent with no Australian rental history?—

Yes, and most arriving clinicians do. Remember that agents rank applications rather than accepting or rejecting them, so the aim is to remove every reason to rank you lower: a complete pack, your employment contract, references translated where needed, proof of funds, and a three-sentence covering note. A signed healthcare contract is a genuine strength.

How much bond will I need?+

Who holds my bond?+

Does unfurnished mean completely empty?+

Should I sign a lease before I arrive?+

Can I keep a pet?+

Is it better to buy instead?+

 READ A LITTLE DEEPER

Helpful alongside this guide

Money, tax & banking in Australia

Four things to set up, one refund people routinely miss, and one decision most clinicians accept by default when they should make it deliberately.

PAGE AT A GLANCE

1. [The order to do things in](#)
2. [Your Tax File Number](#)
3. [Opening a bank account](#)
4. [Superannuation, and the choice](#)
5. [Insurance you may already have](#)
6. [How income tax works](#)
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9. [Moving money into Australia](#)
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11. [Common questions](#)

Kettle on. A longer read – about 17 min

START HERE

The order to do things in

Almost all of this is straightforward. It goes wrong when people do it in the wrong sequence, and the commonest version of that is starting work before the tax office knows you exist.

Before you fly

Open a bank account online

The major banks let you open a transaction account from overseas, then verify your identity at a branch when you arrive. It costs nothing and it means your bond and your first salary have somewhere to land.

Week one

Apply for your Tax File Number

Free, online, and only possible once you are in the country with work rights. Until your employer has it, they are obliged to withhold tax at the top rate.

Week one

Verify your identity at a branch

Passport and, ideally, a local address. This activates the account you opened from overseas and usually gets you a card the same week.

Before your first pay run

Choose your super fund, deliberately

Your employer will ask, or will quietly default you. This is the one decision on this page that compounds for forty years, and the section below is about why it deserves ten minutes.

First month

Sort out Medicare, or your exemption

Either enrol if you are entitled, or get the statement that lets you claim an exemption from the levy.

Both routes need doing; neither happens automatically.

First month

Decide about private hospital cover

Not a lifestyle question but an arithmetic one, because of the surcharge. Explained below.

Ongoing

Keep your first-year paperwork

Arrival date, visa grant, any foreign income, and the date you started work. Your first tax return is the one where residency and part-year thresholds matter, and the paperwork makes it painless.

— THE ONE THAT UNLOCKS EVERYTHING

Your Tax File Number

A TFN is your permanent personal reference with the Australian Taxation Office. One number, issued once, yours for life. Including if you leave Australia and come back a decade later.

You apply after you arrive, online, once you hold a visa with work rights. It is **free**. There are commercial sites that will charge you to submit the same form, and there is no version of the process where paying is faster or better. Apply through the ATO directly.

Give the number to your employer as soon as it arrives, and to your bank and your super fund. Until your employer has it they are legally required to withhold tax at the highest rate, which you would get back eventually through your return, but it makes your first month or two considerably leaner than it needs to be.

One habit worth keeping from day one: your TFN is a sensitive identifier. Legitimate parties who ask for it are your employer, your bank, your super fund and the ATO. Nobody else needs it, and no genuine organisation will ever ask for it by email or text.

PRACTICAL SET-UP

Opening a bank account

Easier than in most countries, and one of the few things worth doing before you get on the plane.

How it works

Apply online from overseas. The major banks all offer a migrant or newcomer account you can open before arrival, months ahead if you like.

Verify in a branch on arrival with your passport. Bring your visa grant notice too; it saves questions.

Everyday banking is app-first and payments between accounts are near-instant, including to businesses and individuals.

You will need a BSB and account number to give your employer, the two numbers that together identify an Australian account.

Cheques are effectively extinct. Do not budget any part of your move on being able to pay by cheque.

Worth knowing

Monthly account fees are common but usually waived above a modest monthly deposit, which a salary comfortably clears. Ask rather than assume.

Give your bank your TFN when it arrives. Without it, tax is withheld from any interest you earn.

Tap-and-go is universal, and a surcharge for card payment is legal and common in cafés and taxis.

Keep your home-country account open for at least the first year. Closing it early makes transfers, pensions and any lingering direct debits harder than they need to be.

Credit history does not travel. You start from nothing here, which matters for borrowing later but not for everyday banking.

THE DECISION THAT COMPOUNDS

Superannuation, and the choice most people accept by default

Superannuation is Australia's compulsory retirement saving, and it is one of the better features of working here. Your employer pays a legislated percentage of your earnings into a fund *on top of* your salary.

The rate is set by law rather than negotiated, it has been rising in steps, and you should check the current figure, but the important point is structural: it is additional to your pay, not deducted from it. When you compare a package here against one at home, super is real money that a salary comparison alone will miss.

In most cases **you can choose the fund**. If you do not choose, one of two things happens: your existing fund is used if you already have one, or your employer's default applies. Health sector employers commonly offer an industry fund, and industry funds are generally low-fee and perfectly reasonable, but there is a difference between choosing that and being defaulted into it without looking.

What to actually look at, in order: the fees, the long-run net performance, the insurance built into the default option and whether you need it, and the investment mix relative to your age and your plans. Ten minutes on the government's comparison tool is enough to make a defensible choice, and small fee differences compound into large numbers across a career.

In our experience

The one thing clinicians most often regret is ending up with several small super accounts

It happens quietly: a locum stint here, a fixed-term contract there, each one defaulting you into a different fund. Every account charges its own fees and often its own insurance premiums, and the total quietly erodes.

Keep one fund and tell each new employer where to pay. Consolidating later is possible and worth doing, but check what insurance cover you would lose before you close anything, because that is the one part of consolidation that can bite.

The insurance you probably do not know you have

This is the part that surprises almost every arriving clinician. Most Australian super funds include **default insurance** inside the fund, with the premiums deducted from your balance rather than billed to you. Typically that means **life cover, total and permanent disability cover**, and sometimes **income protection**.

Two consequences worth understanding. The first is that you may already be insured for more than you assume, which matters if you were about to buy a separate policy. The second is the reason for the warning above: consolidating several accounts into one closes the others, and closes their cover with them. If you have developed a health condition since that cover started, you may not be able to replace it on the same terms.

So the order matters. Find out what cover each fund provides, decide what you actually need against your mortgage and dependants, and only then consolidate. If the default cover is more than you need you can usually reduce or cancel it and stop paying the premiums, and if it is less than you need, a super fund is often not the cheapest place to top it up. Neither of those is a decision we are licensed to make for you, but both are worth ten minutes of a licensed adviser's time.

If you eventually leave Australia permanently on a temporary visa, you may be able to claim your super back through the departing Australia superannuation payment, taxed at a rate set for that purpose. It is not a reason to plan differently, but it is worth knowing the money is not lost.

— HOW IT WORKS

Income tax, in outline

Australian income tax is progressive and administered federally — unlike tenancy law, there is no state income tax to learn. We do not print rates or thresholds here, because they change with each federal budget.

Tax is withheld from your pay by your employer under a system called PAYG. Pay as you go, so for most employed clinicians the amount arriving in your account is already net. The financial year runs from **1 July to 30 June**, which catches people out in a small but persistent way: it is not the calendar year and it is not the April year some of you are used to.

You lodge a return after 30 June, and for a straightforward salaried position this is simple: much of it arrives pre-filled, and the ATO's own online service is free. Most clinicians in their second year onwards do it themselves in under an hour.

Two things that are worth an accountant in your *first* year specifically: a part-year residency position, and any income or assets still generating money in your home country. Both are ordinary situations, both have a right answer, and both are easier to get right once than to unpick later.

Where to get the current numbers

Australian Taxation Office (<https://www.ato.gov.au/>), the primary source for rates, thresholds, the residency tests and lodging your return. Free, and more current than any guide.

Moneysmart (<https://moneysmart.gov.au/>). The government's independent money guidance, including a pay calculator and a super fund comparison tool. No products sold.

ATO: superannuation (<https://www.ato.gov.au/individuals-and-families/super-for-individuals-and-families/super>), the current employer contribution rate, choice-of-fund rules and consolidation.

Services Australia – Medicare (<https://www.servicesaustralia.gov.au/medicare>), enrolling, reciprocal agreements, and applying for a Medicare Entitlement Statement.

A DISTINCTION THAT MATTERS

“Resident for tax purposes” is not the same as your visa

This is the single most misunderstood thing on this page, and it changes what you pay.

Tax residency has nothing to do with citizenship and only an indirect relationship with your visa. It turns on your actual circumstances: where you live, where you work, where your family is, what you have set up, and whether you intend to stay.

Someone on a temporary employer-sponsored visa who takes a twelve-month lease and starts a permanent clinical role is very often a resident for tax purposes, despite the word “temporary” on the visa.

It matters because residents generally get a tax-free threshold and resident rates, while non-residents are taxed from the first dollar at higher rates. The gap is not trivial.

Most arriving clinicians who move properly. Job, home, family, intention to stay. Are residents for tax purposes from close to their arrival date, which is usually the better outcome. But it is your circumstances that decide it, not a form you fill in, so confirm your own position with the ATO’s residency tests or an accountant in year one.

Where this goes wrong

Two mistakes we see. The first is assuming that a **temporary visa means non-resident for tax**, and paying more than necessary for a year before anyone notices.

The second is the reverse: assuming residency and forgetting that as a resident you generally need to **declare worldwide income**, including rent from a property you kept at home. Both are fixable. Both are much easier to get right at the start.

— THE LEVY, AND THE REFUND PEOPLE MISS

The Medicare levy and the surcharge

Two separate things with confusingly similar names. Clinicians are affected by both, and one of them is a refund routinely left unclaimed.

The Medicare levy

What it is: a percentage of taxable income paid by most residents, funding the public health system. It appears in your tax return rather than as a separate bill.

If your country has a reciprocal health care agreement with Australia, you may be enrolled in Medicare and liable for the levy in the ordinary way.

If you are not entitled to Medicare, you can apply to Services Australia for a **Medicare Entitlement Statement** and claim an exemption in your return.

This is the missed refund. Plenty of arriving clinicians pay a levy for a health system they were not entitled to use, because nobody told them the statement exists.

The Medicare levy surcharge

What it is: an additional charge on higher earners who do not hold an appropriate level of private *hospital* cover.

Why it matters to you: many clinical salaries sit above the threshold, so this is likely to apply.

The arithmetic: a basic hospital policy frequently costs less than the surcharge it avoids. That is precisely why so many Australian households hold cover they rarely claim on.

Extras is not hospital cover. Dental and optical extras do not exempt you from the surcharge, and this is the most common expensive misunderstanding.

Run your own numbers against your actual income rather than taking a rule of thumb, including ours.

How the public and private systems fit together, and what Medicare actually covers, is explained properly in [how the health system works](#). This section is only about the money.

— GETTING YOUR MONEY HERE

Moving money into Australia

Transferring your savings is one of the largest single financial events of the move, and one where the default option is usually the expensive one.

The cost of an international transfer is rarely the advertised fee. It is the exchange rate margin. The gap between the rate you are given and the real mid-market rate, and on a sum large enough to fund a bond, a car and three months of living, a poor margin costs meaningfully more than any fee.

Compare your bank against a specialist transfer service, on the same day, for the same amount, and look only at how many Australian dollars actually arrive. That is the whole comparison. Banks are convenient and often not competitive; specialists are usually better on rate and require a little setup.

Two practical points. Split your transfer rather than moving everything on one day, because you have no way of knowing whether today's rate is good and splitting removes the need to guess. And expect to be asked to document the source of large sums. That is ordinary anti-money-laundering compliance, not suspicion, and having a payslip or sale document ready makes it a five-minute conversation.

In our experience

Nobody regrets keeping a buffer at home for the first six months

Moving everything at once feels decisive and occasionally goes wrong. A delayed start date, a rental application that falls through, a family reason to fly home unexpectedly. A reserve in your home currency is not indecision, it is what makes the first months calm.

— THE OTHER END

What you leave behind at home

We are not qualified to advise on the tax system you are leaving, and neither is any recruiter who says otherwise. What we can do is tell you which questions to ask while the people who can answer them are still a local phone call away.

Your pension. Whatever scheme you are in, find out before you leave what happens to it when you stop contributing, whether it can be transferred, and whether transferring is actually a good idea. Frequently it is not. Get this in writing while you are still in the country.

Property you are keeping. If you rent out a home at home, that income may be declarable in both countries. Double tax agreements exist precisely so you are not taxed twice, but they do not apply themselves.

Your final part-year return. Most systems require one for the year you leave, and it is often the year you are owed a refund. Easy to forget from twelve thousand miles away.

Student loans. Many countries require continued repayment from abroad, on a different basis from at home, and some charge a fixed amount rather than an income-linked one. Check the rule for your own scheme before you go.

One accountant conversation in your last month at home and one in your first Australian year will cost less than either mistake. This is the part of the move where paying a professional is straightforwardly worth it.

— COMMON QUESTIONS

The things people ask us first

What is a TFN and when should I apply?–

Your permanent tax reference with the ATO, one number, yours for life. Apply online once you have arrived and hold a visa with work rights. It is free, and no commercial site can get it faster. Until your employer has it, they must withhold tax at the top rate, so week one is the right time.

Can I choose my own super fund?+

Do I have to pay the Medicare levy?+

Is private health insurance worth it?+

Am I a resident for tax purposes?+

Do I need life insurance or income protection?+

What about professional indemnity insurance?+

When is the tax year?+

What is the cheapest way to move my savings over?+

READ A LITTLE DEEPER

Helpful alongside this guide

Driving & licences in Australia

Your licence, your deadline and your insurance are all set by the state you land in, and the deadline is the one that catches people out.

PAGE AT A GLANCE

1. [The deadline nobody mentions](#)
2. [Your state's road authority](#)
3. [Converting your licence](#)
4. [Compulsory third party insurance](#)
5. [The other car insurances](#)
6. [Buying a car](#)
7. [Shipping your own car](#)
8. [Driving here, honestly](#)
9. [Do you actually need a car?](#)
10. [Common questions](#)

Kettle on. A longer read – about 16 min

START HERE

The deadline nobody mentions until it has passed

You can almost certainly drive on your overseas licence when you arrive. What varies, and what people get wrong. Is how long for, and when the clock starts.

Like tenancy law, and unlike income tax, driver licensing in Australia is **state and territory business**. Eight jurisdictions, eight road authorities, eight sets of conversion rules and eight different grace periods. There is no national driving licence and no federal answer to “how long can I use mine”.

The trap is subtler than a different number, though. In several states the clock is tied not to your arrival date but to **when you become a permanent resident**, so a clinician on a temporary work visa may drive on an overseas licence for years quite legally, then have a short window after their permanent residency is granted, at exactly the moment they are least likely to be reading road authority websites.

Driving on a licence that has quietly stopped being valid is not a technicality. It can void your insurance cover in an accident, which turns an ordinary bad day into a financial catastrophe. This is the one thing on this page worth checking in your first week rather than your first year.

What to do about it

Find your state's road authority in the table below, read its page on overseas licence holders, and **write your own deadline in your calendar with a reminder a month before**.

If your visa status changes later, and for most clinicians it eventually does, check the rule again on the day it changes. That single reminder is the whole of the advice.

— THE PRIMARY SOURCE

Your state's road authority

These are the only authoritative answers on your deadline, your conversion route and how CTP works where you live. All free, all more current than any guide including this one.

State or territory	Road authority	How CTP insurance works here
New South Wales	Transport for NSW (https://www.nsw.gov.au/driving-boating-and-transport) Service NSW handles licence transactions	You choose a CTP insurer separately – the “green slip” – before you can register a vehicle.
Victoria	VicRoads (https://www.vicroads.vic.gov.au/) Licensing and registration	Included in your registration, administered through the state injury insurer. Nothing separate to arrange.
Queensland	Department of Transport and Main Roads (https://www.qld.gov.au/transport) Licences, registration, CTP	Bundled with registration, but you nominate which licensed insurer provides it.
Western Australia	Department of Transport WA (https://www.transport.wa.gov.au/licensing/) Driver and vehicle services	Included in your registration through the state insurer. Nothing separate to arrange.
South Australia	Service SA (https://www.sa.gov.au/topics/driving-and-transport) Licensing and registration	Bundled with registration, with a choice of approved insurer.
Tasmania	Transport Tasmania (https://www.transport.tas.gov.au/) Registration and licensing	Included in registration through the state motor accidents scheme.
Australian Capital Territory	Access Canberra (https://www.accesscanberra.act.gov.au/) Road transport services	Bundled with registration; you select from the licensed insurers.
Northern Territory	NT Motor Vehicle Registry (https://nt.gov.au/driving) Licences and registration	Included in registration through the territory scheme.

Authorities occasionally reorganise and rename. If a link here does not resolve, search the authority name plus “overseas licence” and tell us, and we will correct the page.

THE PROCESS

Converting your licence

For most of the clinicians we place this is straightforward paperwork rather than a test. Whether that is true for you depends on one thing: where your licence was issued.

Australia treats a list of countries as having **comparable licensing standards**. If you hold a full licence from one of those, you can generally convert by application, identity, evidence of your licence, an eyesight check, a fee, without sitting a practical driving test. The United Kingdom, Ireland and a number of others sit on those lists.

If your licence is from a country not on your state's list, expect to sit some combination of a knowledge test, a hazard perception test and a practical driving test. That is a normal and passable process, not a rejection, but it takes time and needs booking, which is the other reason to find out early rather than late.

Because the lists are maintained state by state, a country recognised in one jurisdiction is not automatically recognised in another. Check the list held by *your* road authority, not a general one.

Check your state's recognised-country list

This single answer determines whether the rest is paperwork or an exam. Do it before anything else.

Gather your evidence

Your overseas licence, an official English translation if it is not in English, your passport and visa, and proof of your Australian address. A licence that has expired complicates things considerably, so convert before yours lapses.

Book, or just attend

Some authorities take walk-ins, most now prefer an appointment. Appointments in the larger cities can be weeks out, which is a very common reason people miss a deadline they knew about.

Expect to surrender your overseas licence

Many states keep it when they issue yours. If you want it as a keepsake or for driving in a third country later, ask what the policy is before you hand it over.

Keep your driving history

Ask your home authority for a letter confirming your licence history and any claims record before you leave. It is what lets an Australian insurer treat you as an experienced driver rather than a beginner, and it is much harder to obtain once you have gone.

In our experience

The document people wish they had brought is a letter about their driving history

Your Australian licence will say you passed a check. It says nothing about the fifteen years you drove without a claim, and insurers price on exactly that.

A one-page letter from your home licensing authority or your current insurer, obtained before you fly, routinely saves more on premiums in the first two years than the whole conversion costs. Almost nobody thinks of it.

— THE COMPULSORY ONE

Compulsory third party insurance

If you are arriving from New Zealand or the UK, this is unfamiliar, and getting it wrong means driving illegally rather than merely uninsured.

What CTP is

It covers injury to people in a motor accident, other drivers, passengers, pedestrians. Not vehicles, not property.

It is compulsory everywhere. You cannot legally register or drive a vehicle in Australia without it. This is not the optional-but-sensible category.

It attaches to the vehicle, not to you as a driver, which is why it is tied to registration rather than sold as a personal policy.

How you buy it varies by state. In some it arrives inside your registration bill; in others you must choose an insurer yourself before you can register at all. The table above says which applies where you are.

Why New Zealand arrivals find this odd

New Zealand has no CTP because ACC covers accidental injury on a no-fault basis for everyone, funded partly through levies including one on petrol and registration.

Australia has no ACC. Injury cover comes through this compulsory motor insurance instead, and it works on a fault-based model in most states.

The practical consequence: in New Zealand car insurance is not legally compulsory at all. In Australia part of it is. Advice carried across the Tasman is wrong in both directions.

And it is only part. CTP leaves your own car, and everyone else's, entirely uncovered, which is what the next section is about.

THE OPTIONAL ONES

The other car insurances, and which you actually need

CTP is the floor, not the ceiling. Above it sit three tiers, and the honest answer about which to buy depends on what your car is worth rather than on any rule of thumb.

Third party property. Covers damage you do to other people's vehicles and property, and nothing of your own. This is the genuine minimum most drivers should hold above CTP, because the risk it covers is unlimited: a modest older car can write off something expensive, and you would be liable for the whole of it.

Third party fire and theft. The middle tier. Other people's property, plus your own car if it is stolen or burns. Worth considering for a car with some value but not enough to comprehensively insure.

Comprehensive. Covers your own vehicle as well, whoever was at fault. Sensible for anything newer or financed, and the default for most households.

The reasonable approach for an arriving clinician: hold third party property from the day you own a car, and choose between the higher tiers based on what the car is worth and how much you could absorb losing it. Nothing about your visa status changes what is available to you.

Home contents cover is a separate matter and sits with [renting in Australia](#). Life, disability and income protection are usually held inside your super fund, which is covered in [money, tax and banking](#).

PRACTICAL

Buying a car

We publish no prices anywhere on this site, so this is about the process and the checks rather than what anything costs. The checks are where money is actually saved.

Before you hand over money

Run a written-off vehicle and finance check. Every state provides or points to a register showing whether a car has been written off, stolen, or still has money owing on it. A car with finance owing can be repossessed from you even after you have paid the seller.

Get an independent inspection. The state motoring clubs offer pre-purchase inspections and they are worth every cent on a private sale.

Check the roadworthy requirement. Several states require a roadworthy or safety certificate for a private transfer, and whose job it is differs.

Confirm the registration transfers properly. Registration is state-based, and a car registered interstate needs re-registering where you live, sometimes with an inspection.

Worth knowing

Dealer or private is a real trade-off. Dealers cost more and carry statutory warranty obligations; private sales are cheaper and sold as-is.

Stamp duty applies on transfer, set by each state, on top of the purchase price. Budget for it rather than discovering it.

Interstate moves need re-registration, so if you expect to move states within a year, factor that in. **Buying with no Australian credit history** is fine for cash but harder for finance, the same blank-slate problem as renting. Paying cash for a modest first car avoids the issue entirely. **Utes and large SUVs dominate** the market and hold value well. Small cars are cheaper to buy and run, and perfectly adequate for city work.

— TOLD STRAIGHT

Should you ship your own car?

Almost certainly not, and we would rather say so plainly than let you find out at the port.

Australia has strict vehicle import rules, and a personally imported car generally needs an import approval before it is shipped and compliance work after it arrives. Add sea freight, quarantine cleaning, duty and taxes, any modifications required to meet Australian design rules, and the delay while all of that happens, and the total commonly exceeds what the same car is worth on the local market.

There are narrow exceptions, a rare or classic vehicle, or a personal import concession that fits your circumstances exactly. If you think you are in one of those, get proper advice from a customs broker rather than a shipping company's sales team, because their interests differ from yours.

In our experience

The clinicians who ship a car regret it. The ones who sell up and buy on arrival do not.

It is an emotional decision more than a financial one, and we understand why. A car is one of the few large familiar objects you could theoretically bring. But it arrives weeks after you do, needs work before it can be driven, and by then you have already had to solve the problem another way.

Sell at home while you are there to manage it, and buy something modest and second-hand in your first month. Upgrade once you know your commute.

— THE ROAD ITSELF

Driving here, honestly

Australians drive on the left, which will either be a relief or a fortnight of concentration. Beyond that, a few things are different and one of them is dangerous.

Enforcement

Speed limits are enforced, properly

Fixed cameras, mobile cameras, average-speed enforcement and low tolerances. Australian enforcement is stricter than many arrivals expect, penalties are real, and demerit points accumulate against your new licence quickly. Assume the limit is the limit.

The dangerous one

Distance is not what it looks like on a map

The single most underestimated risk. Journeys between regional towns are longer, emptier and more tiring than the distance suggests, phone coverage disappears, and fuel stops can be hundreds of kilometres apart. Plan long drives properly, carry water, and tell someone your route.

Wildlife

Dawn and dusk are the risk

Kangaroos and livestock on regional roads are a genuine hazard, worst at first and last light. Many locals avoid driving country roads at those hours, and that is sound advice rather than folklore.

Alcohol

Random breath testing is routine

Police stop drivers at random as a matter of course, not on suspicion. The limit is low, the enforcement is constant, and for a registered health practitioner a drink-driving conviction is a professional problem as well as a legal one.

Cities

Tolls, and the parking arithmetic

Sydney, Melbourne and Brisbane have extensive toll networks needing an electronic tag or a pass; Perth and Adelaide have none. Inner-city parking is expensive and hospital staff parking is often limited and waitlisted. Worth asking about before you assume you will drive to work.

Conditions

Heat, glare and flooding

Summer heat is hard on older cars and on tyres. Low sun at either end of the day is worse than in higher latitudes. And in the north, a road that is fine in June may be cut in February. Never drive into floodwater, which is advice locals repeat every single wet season for good reason.

BEFORE YOU BUY ANYTHING

Do you actually need a car?

Worth answering deliberately, because a car is one of the largest costs of the first year and for some people it is optional.

In the inner suburbs of Sydney, Melbourne and Brisbane, plenty of households manage without one: public transport is decent, parking is expensive, and car-share and ride-hailing fill the gaps. If you will live centrally and work at a well-connected site, try the first two months without buying and see.

Almost everywhere else the answer is yes, and in outer-suburban and regional Australia a household often needs two, which is a real cost that a salary comparison will not show you.

The deciding factor is usually your roster, not your suburb. Public transport that works perfectly for a nine-to-five does not help at the end of a late shift when services have stopped, and a taxi home several nights a week is worse than owning something modest. If you work nights, weekends or on-call, assume you need a car.

Which is the argument for deciding after you arrive rather than before. Give it a month, learn the actual commute, then buy, the same logic as not signing a lease from photographs. What a car costs to run in a specific city, and whether a second one is realistic there, is covered in the cost chapter of each [destination guide](#).

Where to check the current rules

Your state or territory road authority, from the table above, the only authoritative source on your deadline, your conversion route and CTP.

Department of Infrastructure and Transport (<https://www.infrastructure.gov.au/infrastructure-transport-vehicles/vehicles>). Federal vehicle import rules, if you are still considering shipping.

The motoring club in your state, pre-purchase inspections, roadside assistance and written-off vehicle checks.

COMMON QUESTIONS

The things people ask us first

Can I drive on my overseas licence?—

Usually yes at first, but the period is set by each state and in several it starts when you become a permanent resident rather than when you land. That is the trap. Check your own road authority in your first week and put your deadline in your calendar with a reminder a month before. Driving on a lapsed licence can void your insurance.

Will I have to sit a driving test?+

What is CTP and is it compulsory?+

Is car insurance compulsory like in New Zealand?+

Should I ship my car?+

Do I need a car at all?+

What should I bring from home?+

READ A LITTLE DEEPER

Helpful alongside this guide

Education & schools in Australia

For a family moving across the world, school is often the question that matters most.

— PAGE AT A GLANCE

1. [The big picture](#)
2. [How it's structured](#)
3. [Childcare & early years](#)
4. [Choosing a school](#)
5. [What it costs](#)
6. [Enrolment & zones](#)
7. [Beyond school](#)
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Kettle on. A longer read — about 9 min

— THE BIG PICTURE

High-quality, welcoming and well-organised

Education is run by each state and territory, so starting ages, year-level names and term dates vary by where you settle. The overall shape is the same nationwide, and follows a common Australian Curriculum.

Schooling is compulsory from around age six until at least sixteen, and most children attend from the year they turn five. For newcomers, the practical headline is simple: places are generally easy to access, support for new arrivals is well established, and children tend to settle quickly.

THE STAGES

How it's structured

From early childhood to the final certificate, here's the journey a child moves through, with the caveat that exact ages and year names shift a little between states.

Before school

Early childhood

Long day care, preschool and kindergarten programs in the years before formal school: widely available, and a gentle on-ramp for younger children.

Primary

Foundation to Year 6

The first year (called Prep, Foundation, Kindergarten or Reception depending on the state) through to Year 6, the grounding years, usually from around age five.

Secondary

Year 7 to Year 12

High school through to a senior secondary certificate. The final years lead to the ATAR, the rank used for university entry, though it's far from the only pathway.

THE EARLY YEARS

Childcare & early learning

If you're moving with little ones, childcare is often the first thing to arrange, and the costs and rules are worth understanding before you arrive, because they can differ from what you're used to.

The options

Types of care

Long day care (centre-based, from babies to school age), family day care in a carer's home, occasional care, and preschool or kindergarten in the year or two before school. School-age children can use outside-school-hours care before and after school and in the holidays.

The cost

Subsidy depends on your visa

Childcare is a real household cost. The federal **Child Care Subsidy** lowers fees for eligible families, but eligibility depends on your residency and visa status, so many families on a temporary visa (including the 482) don't qualify and pay full fees. It's worth budgeting for, and checking your position early.

Getting a place

Enquire before you move

Popular centres. Especially in cities and inner suburbs, can have waiting lists. Registering your interest before you arrive, with a couple of options in mind, takes the pressure off those first few weeks.

Whether the Child Care Subsidy applies to you comes down to your visa, so we'll help you understand where you stand, and factor childcare into the bigger picture of the move, before you commit.

THREE SECTORS

Choosing a school

Families choose between three broad sectors. All follow the national curriculum and are well regarded, the right one depends on your priorities, your budget and where you live.

Government schools

Public schools, funded by the state, free or low-cost (small fees and costs apply). The large majority of children attend them, and places are usually tied to your home address.

Catholic schools

A large, well-established system open to families of many backgrounds, with modest fees. A popular middle path for many relocating families.

Independent schools

Private and faith-based schools with higher fees, offering particular philosophies, facilities or programs. Many have waiting lists, so it's worth enquiring early.

WHAT IT COSTS

School fees, and the part that depends on your visa

What you'll pay depends on the sector you choose and, crucially, on your residency status. For most relocating families the biggest variable isn't the school, it's the visa.

Government schools

Free or low-cost for citizens and permanent residents. You'll still meet voluntary contributions, uniforms, excursions and materials, but tuition itself is covered.

Catholic schools

Modest tuition fees that rise gradually through the year levels, an affordable middle path for many families.

Independent schools

Higher fees that vary widely by school, reflecting facilities, programs and philosophy. Worth enquiring early, as many have waiting lists.

Residents and temporary residents pay differently

On a permanent visa, government schooling is free or low-cost and you are generally eligible for the Child Care Subsidy. On an employer-sponsored 482 you are a temporary resident, and two things change: your children may pay an annual tuition contribution at a government school, which varies by state and is waived for many of the occupations we place, and you usually will not qualify for the Child Care Subsidy. Because the amounts and exemptions are set state by state and revised each year, they live in one place rather than three: **School fees on a visa** holds the current figures by state, who is exempt, and the official page for each.

Out-of-school and holiday programmes run through the long summer break and each term break, and they book out early in the popular suburbs.

THE PRACTICAL PART

Enrolment & zones

For public schools, where you live usually decides which school your child can attend, which is why the suburb decision and the school decision go hand in hand.

Most government schools have a **catchment zone**, and living within it gives your child a place. That makes it worth researching schools *before* you choose a rental, especially if a particular school matters to you. Catholic and independent schools enrol more broadly but may have waiting lists and their own application timelines. Newly arrived children whose first language isn't English are usually well supported through **English as an Additional Language** programs, so a language gap is rarely a barrier to settling in.

The specifics, zones, fees and what's available near you, differ by state and suburb, so we'll point you to the **relocation guide for your state** and the right state education department as those are published.

AFTER SCHOOL

University & vocational pathways

School is one chapter; Australia's tertiary system offers strong options beyond it, for your children in time and perhaps for you.

Australia has a well-regarded **university** sector and a parallel **vocational system (TAFE)** for hands-on, industry-focused training. Entry to university is most often via the ATAR from Year 12, but there are many alternative pathways too.

Domestic or international fees?

Here the visa matters again, and it's worth knowing early if you have older teenagers.

Citizens and permanent residents are treated as **domestic students**, eligible for government-subsidised Commonwealth Supported Places, and (for citizens) the HECS-HELP loan that lets you defer fees. **Temporary-visa holders, including dependents on a 482**, are generally treated as **international students**: full

international fees, and no access to HELP loans. If your family moves to permanent residency before or during study, that picture can change, so the timing of a teenager's university start is worth planning around.

Moving with a teenager close to university age? Talk to us early, whether you're on a temporary or permanent pathway can make a real difference to tertiary fees, and it's worth weighing alongside the rest of the move.

Sophie's insight

School is the worry I hear most from parents, and almost always the one that resolves most happily. Children settle faster than their parents expect, schools are welcoming to new arrivals, and the support for kids finding their feet is real. My one piece of practical advice: if a particular public school matters, check its zone before you sign a lease. That single step saves families a lot of stress.

SophieCEO & Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

The end of the day is where a lot of settling happens: sport, clubs and the walk home with people your children will know by the second week.

COMMON QUESTIONS

The things parents ask us first

Will my child get a place easily?–

Generally yes. Government schools must provide a place for children living in their catchment zone, and Catholic and independent schools enrol from a wider area (sometimes with waiting lists). The main thing is to align your housing choice with the school you'd like.

What if English isn't my child's first language?+

How much do schools cost?+

We're on a 482 visa. Do we pay for a government school?+

Can we get the Child Care Subsidy on a 482?+

Will my child's year level transfer?+

 READ A LITTLE DEEPER

Helpful alongside this guide

Will I have to pay school fees?

Possibly, and it is one of the things families should check *before* choosing where to relocate, not after.

PAGE AT A GLANCE

1. [The short answer](#)
2. [Why your visa decides it](#)
3. [School fees by state](#)
4. [Costs that apply anyway](#)
5. [Catholic & independent schools](#)
6. [Check before choosing where to live](#)
7. [Comparing two offers](#)
8. [Common questions](#)

Kettle on. A longer read – about 10 min

THE HONEST ANSWER

Australia has an excellent public system. It isn't automatically free.

Public education in Australia is not free for every family living there on a temporary visa. The rules vary between states and territories, and can also depend on the visa you hold.

That makes this particularly relevant for healthcare professionals relocating on **employer-sponsored temporary visas**, which is how a great many internationally trained clinicians arrive.

If you are relocating with two or three school-aged children, **don't compare the salaries offered in Queensland, Western Australia, Victoria or New South Wales**. Check the schooling position attached to your visa in that state as well. It can change the economics of an offer substantially.

— THE MECHANISM

Why your visa decides this, not the school

Education is run by each state and territory rather than nationally, and each sets its own position on what dependants of temporary visa holders pay. The same family, on the same visa, can face a different answer in two states.

Citizens & permanent residents

Government schooling is free or low-cost, on the same basis as any local family. The everyday costs below still apply, but there is no tuition contribution.

Temporary visa holders

Several states and territories charge an annual tuition contribution for dependants, and several don't. Exemptions, waivers, income tests and regional concessions all exist, and all vary.

Which visa, specifically

Eligibility is usually tied to the exact visa subclass, and sometimes to your occupation being on a skills list. Two clinicians on different subclasses can be treated differently in the same state.

This is why we won't give you a figure on this page. The number depends on your state, your subclass, your occupation and sometimes your household income, and the rules change. **We'll check the current position for your actual circumstances** before you weigh an offer.

— WHERE TO LOOK

School fees by state & territory

Each state and territory publishes its own current rules for dependants of temporary visa holders. These are the departments that set them, check the position for your subclass directly, and confirm it in the year you're actually moving.

New South Wales

NSW Department of Education sets the temporary-resident tuition fee and its exemptions. Notably, families on eligible temporary skilled visas moving to **regional** NSW can currently access public schooling without the temporary-resident tuition fee, so metropolitan and regional positions differ.

Western Australia

WA's Department of Education applies a **family** tuition fee for holders of certain temporary skilled visas, including subclass 482, rather than a separate full fee for every child, which changes the arithmetic considerably for larger families.

Victoria

The Victorian Department of Education sets the position for international and temporary-resident students, including which visa subclasses enrol as local students. Confirm your subclass against their current schedule.

Queensland

Queensland's Department of Education publishes the rules for dependants of temporary visa holders, including any waiver or application process that applies to skilled visa families.

South Australia

The South Australian Department for Education sets fees for temporary residents, with eligibility criteria that can include income testing and sibling arrangements. Check both.

Tasmania

Tasmania's Department for Education, Children and Young People publishes the position for temporary visa holders, including any levy that applies in place of tuition.

Northern Territory

NT's Department of Education sets the rules for dependants of temporary visa holders. Confirm the current position and any enrolment requirements for your subclass.

Australian Capital Territory

The ACT Education Directorate publishes its own fee position and eligibility for temporary residents. Worth checking alongside NSW if you're considering the Canberra region.

Indicative government-school fees for 482 dependants

Rough figures to plan against, not quotes. They are revised each year, several are income-tested, and many of the healthcare occupations we place are exempt entirely. Confirm the current figure with the state department before you budget.

State / territory	Indicative fee for 482 dependants	Worth knowing
Victoria	Generally none	Children enrol as local students; school levies and materials still apply.
Queensland	Generally none	Fee waiver for 482 dependants; a small annual application fee may apply.
Northern Territory	None	No tuition fees for 482 dependants.
Tasmania	No tuition; small levy	A school levy of roughly A\$300–\$750 a year; hardship support exists.
New South Wales	circa \$5,000–\$6,000 per student	Regional NSW (outside Greater Sydney and Wollongong) waived from 2025; skills-list occupations may be exempt; income-based waivers.
South Australia	circa \$5,000–\$7,000 per student	Greater Adelaide, income-tested and waived below roughly \$74,000; 10% sibling discount; some country schools exempt.
Western Australia	circa \$4,000 per family	Charged per family rather than per child; hardship waivers available.
Australian Capital Territory	Fees apply	Exempt where your occupation is on the skills list; otherwise among the higher schedules in the country.

Indicative only, and rounded down so neither end overstates. Reviewed September 2026. State rules, exemption criteria and eligible subclasses all change, so confirm the current position with the relevant state department for your visa subclass, in the year you are moving. Catholic and independent schools set their own fees separately.

Two states worth flagging for anyone weighing offers: **New South Wales treats regional and metropolitan moves differently**, and **Western Australia charges per family rather than per child** for certain skilled subclasses. If you have several children, those two differences alone can be worth more than a pay difference between states.

— EITHER WAY

Public school doesn't mean no school costs

Even where your child is entitled to tuition-free public education, budget for the everyday expenses of schooling. They vary considerably between schools and families, and they arrive together in your first term.

Uniforms and shoes

Books and stationery

Laptops or other devices
School camps and excursions
Sports and extracurricular activities
Transport

Before- and after-school care

Voluntary contributions or school-specific charges

None of these is large on its own. All of them landing in the same month, alongside a rental bond and furnishing a house, is a different matter, our [relocation cost guide](#) puts them in the context of everything else you'll be paying for at once.

— THE OTHER SECTORS

What about Catholic & independent schools?

Australia has a substantial Catholic and independent school sector, and fees vary enormously across it – more than the phrase “private school” suggests to most families arriving.

Catholic schools

Often considerably less expensive than families expect when they hear “private school”. Fees typically rise gradually through the year levels, and for many families this is an affordable middle path.

Independent schools

An enormous range. Australia's most prestigious independent schools charge substantial annual fees; many others sit far below that. Facilities, programs and philosophy all feed into it.

If this matters to you

Research the specific schools and their current fees in the particular area you're considering, before accepting a role. Many have waiting lists, so enquire early rather than after you arrive.

— THE PRACTICAL PART

Check before choosing where to live

Schools influence your choice of accommodation more than most families expect, because many Australian government schools have designated local enrolment areas or catchments. Particularly where demand is high.

A property that looks perfect online may not place your child within the enrolment area of the school you have chosen. And by the time you've signed a twelve-month tenancy, that is an expensive thing to discover.

Our advice is simple: **look at the job, the school and the home together**. Don't secure accommodation first and start thinking about schools afterwards. And if you're moving on a temporary visa, check the current state education rules applying to your subclass before you calculate your relocation budget at all.

— COMPARING OFFERS

One of the hidden differences between two states

School fees are exactly the kind of cost that doesn't appear anywhere in an employment contract but can change which offer is better for a family.

Two roles with identical salaries in two different states are not equivalent offers if one state charges tuition for your children and the other doesn't, or if one charges per child and the other per family. For a clinician moving with three school-aged children, that difference can outweigh a meaningful gap in pay.

So when you're weighing states, put the schooling position beside the salary. Our **money guide** works through the other costs that shift the answer the same way, and the **education guide** covers how Australian schooling is structured, childcare and the tertiary pathways.

— COMMON QUESTIONS

The questions parents ask us about fees

We're on a 482 visa. Will we pay for a government school?–

It depends entirely on the state or territory. Some charge dependants of temporary visa holders an annual tuition contribution; others don't; and several operate exemptions, waivers, income tests or regional concessions. Check the current position with the relevant state department for your exact subclass before you plan around it.

How reliable are the figures above?+

Does moving regionally make a difference?+

Is it cheaper if we have several children?+

Will becoming a permanent resident change it?+

What about New Zealand, is it the same?+

Moving with *pets*

There's one member of the family who isn't mentioned in the employment contract. The dog. Or the cat. And for a great many families, leaving them behind isn't an option.

● AUSTRALIA

— PAGE AT A GLANCE

1. [Start planning early](#)
2. [The two countries' rules](#)
3. [Will they quarantine?](#)
4. [They needn't travel with you](#)
5. [Finding a pet-friendly home](#)
6. [What it costs](#)
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9. [The first few weeks](#)
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Kettle on. A longer read — about 13 min

— THE SHORT VERSION

Absolutely possible. Not remotely last-minute.

Moving pets to Australia works from many countries, and thousands of families do it every year. But it requires considerably more planning than booking an extra seat on the flight.

Australia operates strict biosecurity requirements designed to protect their unique environments and animal health. That means your pet's move needs to be planned alongside your own, not a few weeks before departure.

For most owners, a pet isn't cargo to be transported after the move. They're part of who's moving.

— SECTION 01 • TIMING

Start planning early

This is the single most important thing on the page. The process your pet follows depends on the country you are moving *from*, not the fact that you're heading to Australia.

Requirements can include microchipping, vaccinations, rabies testing, parasite treatments, veterinary examinations, official documentation, import permits and quarantine. And the **order** matters: where a test or treatment has to happen within a specified window, getting the sequence wrong can delay the whole move.

When to start

As soon as Australia becomes a serious possibility, not when the removal boxes are packed. You don't need a signed contract to start researching your pet's requirements, and starting early is the cheapest thing you can do.

— SECTION 02 • THE RULES

What Australia requires

Australia sets requirements according to the animal-health and biosecurity risk of your country of export, so two families moving the same breed from different countries can face different processes.

Australia

Among the strictest in the world

Requirements depend on the country your pet is travelling from and the type of animal. Dogs and cats from approved countries may need to complete a series of veterinary and biosecurity steps before departure.

Identification by microchip

Rabies vaccination and testing

Parasite treatments

Veterinary certification

An import permit

Some animals will also need to spend time in post-entry quarantine after arriving. There are additional restrictions affecting certain breeds and circumstances, so don't assume that because somebody else's dog moved successfully, yours follows the same route.

The regulator is the **Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry**. It sorts countries of export into groups by rabies risk and publishes a separate step-by-step guide for each group, so the first thing to establish is which group your country sits in. That guide is then your checklist: [agriculture.gov.au – step-by-step guides](https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/cats-dogs/how-to-import/step-by-step-guides) (<https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/cats-dogs/how-to-import/step-by-step-guides>).

Check the source

Regulations change. A checklist somebody used a few years ago, or even relatively recently, should never replace current government guidance. Check the source, not the forum post.

SECTION 03 • QUARANTINE

Will my pet have to quarantine?

Possibly. It depends on the animal and the country it is travelling from
— Australia sorts countries into groups by rabies risk, and that determines the process.

If quarantine is required, **availability becomes part of your relocation timeline**. Facilities book up, and that's one of the clearest reasons pet travel shouldn't be left until the end of the process.

Three dates, not one

Your employment start date, your family's flights and your pet's travel date may not be the same. Plan them as three linked decisions rather than assuming everyone arrives together.

SECTION 04 • SEQUENCING

Your pet doesn't necessarily have to travel with you

This can feel strange at first, particularly if your pet has always been part of family life. But it is often the most practical option.

A clinician might travel first, begin work, move out of temporary accommodation and secure a pet-friendly long-term rental before their partner, children and pets follow. Other families move together and arrange for the pet to arrive separately.

There isn't one correct way. Think about what makes the transition easiest for both your family and your animal, and remember that arriving into a settled home is a much gentler landing for a dog than arriving into a serviced apartment and a house-hunt.

— SECTION 05 • SOMEWHERE TO LIVE

Finding a pet-friendly rental

Getting your pet into the country is only half the problem. You also need somewhere to live that will have them.

Check the rules around pets before assuming a property is suitable, and pay particular attention to temporary accommodation. A serviced apartment or short-term let that works perfectly for a family may not accept a dog or cat. If your pet is arriving after you, use that window to find suitable long-term accommodation.

Then think beyond whether the landlord permits pets:

Is there enough space?

Is there a secure garden, if you have a dog?

Are there good places nearby for walking?

How long will your pet be alone while you're working?

The right home for your family needs to work for them too.

— SECTION 06 • COST

How much does it cost?

Pet relocation can be expensive. The total depends on where you're travelling from, your destination, the size and type of animal, veterinary requirements, transport arrangements and whether quarantine is required.

Potential expenses include veterinary appointments, vaccinations, blood tests, official certification, permits, airline transport, travel crates, pet relocation companies and quarantine. For a large dog or multiple animals, the total can become

a significant part of the family's relocation budget.

Get quotes early

It is far easier to plan for this six months out than to discover it once you've committed most of your savings to flights, accommodation and setting up the new home. Our [relocation cost guide](#) shows where this sits against everything else you'll be paying for.

SECTION 07 • THE JOURNEY

What is the flight actually like for them?

Understandably one of the biggest worries for owners, and international pet travel is very different from taking an animal on a short domestic journey.

The journey

Ask for it stage by stage

Depending on the route and airline arrangements, your pet may travel in a specially designed crate in an appropriate part of the aircraft rather than alongside you in the cabin. There may also be stopovers or transfers.

A reputable pet transport specialist or airline should be able to explain the journey clearly, including where your animal will be during each stage. If your pet is elderly or has a medical condition, discuss the proposed route with your vet well in advance.

Medication & sedation

Not your decision to make alone

If you're worried about how your pet will cope, speak to your vet *and* the company responsible for transporting them.

Sedation can create additional risks during air travel and may not be permitted or recommended in some circumstances. The right approach depends on the individual animal and the requirements of the carrier, so ask both, and follow the advice.

Should you use a pet relocation company?

You don't have to manage all of this alone. Specialists can coordinate veterinary timelines, documentation, travel crates, flights and quarantine arrangements. At a cost. Some families value having someone run a complicated process while they're simultaneously dealing with visas, registration, jobs, schools and their own move; others prefer to manage it themselves. If you do use one, establish exactly what the quote includes and what you'll still need to arrange separately.

SECTION 08 • CHECK BEFORE YOU SPEND

Older pets, restricted breeds & other animals

Three situations where the answer needs checking before you spend any money on the process.

Older pets

A different conversation

Moving a healthy three-year-old dog and moving a fourteen-year-old dog are very different decisions. For an older animal, the length of the journey, underlying conditions and ability to cope with transport all need careful thought.

That doesn't automatically mean an older pet can't relocate. It means the decision belongs with your vet, rather than resting on whether the paperwork permits it.

Breeds & species

Some animals can't come

Australia restricts the importation of certain dog breeds or types, and there can be restrictions affecting hybrid animals. If there's any possibility your dog falls within a restricted category, check the official rules first, don't rely on appearance, breeder descriptions or informal advice.

For pets other than dogs and cats, birds, rabbits, reptiles, don't assume the dog-and-cat process applies. Check whether your animal can legally be imported before making any plans. For some species and countries of origin, it may not be possible at all.

SECTION 09 • SETTLING IN

The first few weeks after arrival

The journey is only one part of your pet's transition. Everything familiar has changed. Their home has gone, the smells are different, the routine has changed, and the family is stressed and surrounded by boxes.

Establish a predictable routine as quickly as you can. Find a local vet, update identification details where required, and learn the local rules for registration, microchipping and dog control.

Then do the enjoyable part. Find the walks. Find the parks. Find the beach.

For a lot of families, exploring the new neighbourhood with the dog is the first thing that makes the place feel like home.

— SECTION 10 • THE PACKAGE

Could your employer help?

Pet relocation isn't normally a standard employment benefit, but that isn't quite the end of the question.

If your employer is providing a general relocation allowance rather than paying only specified expenses, you may have some flexibility over how that money is used.

Never assume pet transport is covered. Ask what the relocation contribution can and cannot be used for before making any bookings.

Our [offer guide](#) covers how to raise this well, and relocation support is often more negotiable than the salary itself.

— USEFUL CONTACTS

Specialists & quarantine facilities

You don't have to organise an international pet move alone. Specialist relocation companies can coordinate veterinary requirements, documentation, flights, travel crates and quarantine arrangements. For candidates relocating from the UK, established providers include:

PetAir UK

A vet-led international pet relocation company providing services to Australia and New Zealand.

Airpets International

Heathrow-based international pet transport specialist with veterinary and animal-handling facilities.

PBS Pet Travel

UK pet relocation company arranging international transport for dogs, cats and other animals.

Quarantine in Australia

One government facility

Cats and dogs requiring post-entry quarantine in Australia are accommodated at the Australian Government's Post Entry Quarantine Facility at Mickleham, near Melbourne.

Requirements for importing animals depend on the country your pet is travelling from, and they change without notice – always check the current [Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry guidance](https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/cats-dogs) (<https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/cats-dogs>) before making arrangements. **Ethicare does not receive commission from any of the providers listed here.** We'd recommend obtaining several quotes and confirming current government requirements directly before you book anything.

Sophie's insight

I should declare an interest: we are all completely soft about animals here, and there are two dogs in the Ethicare office on any given day. So when someone tells me they won't move without their dog, I don't treat that as a complication to be worked around. It's just one of the things that has to work. What I'd say honestly is that this is the part of a relocation people leave latest and regret most, because the timings are fixed by regulation and no amount of goodwill speeds them up. Raise it with us in the first conversation, not the last. It's far easier to build the whole move around your pet's timeline than to discover six weeks before departure that the sequence doesn't work.

Sophie Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

COMMON QUESTIONS

The questions we're asked about moving with pets

How far in advance should I start?—

As soon as the move becomes a serious possibility. Several of the veterinary steps have to happen in a particular order and within specified windows, and quarantine facilities have finite availability, so the timeline is set by regulation rather than by how organised you are. Starting early costs nothing and prevents the most common delays.

Will my dog definitely have to go into quarantine?+

Can my pet travel on the same flight as me?+

Should my pet be sedated for the journey?+

My dog is a restricted breed, is that the end of it?+

What about a rabbit, bird or reptile?+

Will an employer pay for pet relocation?+

EXPLORE FURTHER

Read a little deeper

[Previous](#)[Your move, step by step](#)[All chapters](#)[Next](#)[Before you leave home](#)

Moving with your family

Whether your partner can work, what childcare costs, which school your children can attend, and how it all works if you're doing it on your own. It's all here.

— PAGE AT A GLANCE

1. [Can my partner work?](#)
2. [Childcare, honestly](#)
3. [Moving as a single parent](#)
4. [Preparing the children](#)
5. [Surviving the long flight](#)
6. [The first 48 hours](#)
7. [The first few weeks](#)
8. [Choosing where to live](#)
9. [Settling, age by age](#)
10. [Looking after yourself](#)

Kettle on. A longer read — about 22 min

— THE REASSURING PART

Children travel further than we give them credit for

It's a long flight, and most parents dread it more than any other part of the move. In our experience it's the bit families remember least — the settling afterwards is what stays with them.

Children take their cue from you. If the move is framed as an adventure and the practicalities are quietly handled in the background, most children adapt remarkably quickly, often faster than the adults. Australia's outdoor, friendly, sport-loving culture is good for kids, and schools are well used to welcoming children from all over the world. This guide walks through both halves: getting there in one piece, and helping everyone feel at home once you've arrived.

If there's one thing to hold onto, it's this: **a few unsettled weeks are completely normal and almost always temporary.** Wobbles, clinginess and the odd tearful evening don't mean you've made the wrong decision, they mean a small person is doing something brave.

— THE QUESTION THE MOVE TURNS ON

Can my partner work?

Two salaries or one changes what you can afford and where you can live. It often shapes how the person coming with you feels about going at all.

The short version: your partner's right to work comes from your visa, not from a job offer of their own. Partners are usually included in your application, and what they are permitted to do follows from the visa you are granted and the conditions attached to it. That is why the honest answer is never a flat yes or no, but *check it against the route you are actually on* – and check it before you accept, not after.

WHOSE VISA DECIDES IT

Yours, not theirs

Work rights attach to being included in your application. Change route – temporary to permanent – and theirs changes with it.

Read the conditions on the visa you are granted, not the one you applied for.

WILL THE QUALIFICATION COUNT?

A separate question entirely

Permission to work and recognition to practise are two different processes. Regulated professions run through the Australian regulator or assessing authority for that field; everything else is judged by employers.

Start it early. Assessments take longer than anyone expects.

HOW LONG UNTIL THEY EARN?

IF THEY ARE A CLINICIAN TOO

Two registrations, two timelines

Theirs may well be the longer one. Run both from the start rather than in sequence – a second timeline

Budget the first months on one income

Even with full work rights, job-hunting while unpacking, enrolling children and learning a new city takes time. Families who plan for one income and are pleasantly surprised do far better than families who plan for two.

discovered late is the most common reason a family ends up arriving months apart.

Check their pathway alongside yours.

What to settle before you accept

Ask the employer which visa they intend to sponsor and what conditions come with it. Ask what support, if any, extends to a partner. Then have the honest conversation at home about what six months on one income looks like. None of this is awkward at the offer stage; all of it is expensive later.

Visa conditions are set and changed by government, so we point you at the source rather than paraphrasing it: **Department of Home Affairs** (<https://immi.homeaffairs.gov.au/>). We will talk through what your route means in practice, and we will tell you when a question needs a registered migration agent rather than us. See also **visas and immigration**.

UNDER FIVE

Childcare, honestly

Two things surprise people: the vocabulary is different, and the binding constraint is places rather than price. In popular suburbs the waiting list is the problem, and it starts long before you land.

1

Learn the names

Long day care covers the full working day. Family day care is a smaller setting in an educator's own home, and is often the more flexible option. Preschool and kindergarten are the year or two before school, run by each state under its own name and its own rules – which is why advice from a friend in another state may not apply to you.

2

Join waiting lists before you fly

You can enquire and be listed from overseas. Do it as soon as you have a suburb in mind, and list at more than one centre. A place you do not need is easy to decline; a place that does not exist is not.

3

Check the subsidy against your own visa

Fees are quoted per day, and the Child Care Subsidy reduces what families actually pay – but eligibility depends on your residency status, so a temporary-visa family should confirm their position before budgeting on the subsidised figure. This is the single most expensive assumption we see families make.

4

Test it against a clinical roster

Standard centre hours were not designed around a 7am start or a late finish. Ask about the earliest drop-off and the latest pick-up, ask what happens when you are held past handover, and plan for the gap – a nanny share or family day care often covers what a centre cannot.

Official sources: **Child Care Subsidy (Services Australia)** (<https://www.servicesaustralia.gov.au/child-care-subsidy>) for eligibility and rates, and your state education department for preschool. For school-age children, **schools and education** covers enrolment, catchments and fees.

DOING IT ON YOUR OWN

Moving as a single parent

Almost everything written for families quietly assumes a second adult. Plenty of single parents make this move, and the ones who found it manageable tell us very little came as a surprise.

Two things need handling early, and both are easier to do at home than from the other side of the world.

Consent to take a child abroad

Where someone else holds parental responsibility, you will generally need their written consent or a court order — and it can be asked for twice: once by the visa application, and again by an airline or a border officer. Get it in writing, get copies certified, and carry them in your hand luggage rather than the shipping container.

- Full birth certificates showing both parents, not the short form.
- Any parenting or custody orders, certified.
- A signed consent letter with the other parent's contact details, or evidence of sole parental responsibility.
- Where a parent has died, the death certificate.
- Immunisation records and medical notes, which schools and clinics will ask for.

ONE INCOME, TWO COSTS

Childcare is the line that decides it

Work the numbers on your own salary with care included at full price, and check the subsidy question above before you rely on it. The first three months are the most expensive of the whole move.

NO SECOND ADULT

Build the network before you need it

Before and after-school care, school-holiday programmes, a neighbour, and one colleague who will swap a shift. Set these up in the first fortnight, not the first emergency.

THE ROSTER

SCHOOL HOLIDAYS

Negotiate it before you accept

Nights, weekends and on-call are a different proposition without another adult at home. Say so at offer stage – it is a normal conversation, and a far harder one to start once you have arrived.

Longer than you are used to

The summer break is substantial and falls over Christmas. Holiday programmes book out early. Check the term dates for your state before you plan your leave for the year.

Tell us your situation early and we will sequence it with you – what to gather, in what order, and who actually decides. Consent and documentation requirements are set by government: see **Department of Home Affairs** (<https://immi.homeaffairs.gov.au/>), and **talk to us** if you would rather work through it with someone.

BEFORE YOU FLY

Preparing the children for the move

The weeks before you leave tend to do more for a smooth landing than anything on the day itself – the familiar things a family can line up in advance.

Tell them early

Talk it through, often

Share the news in good time and keep the conversation going. Look at photos and maps of where you're heading, watch videos together, and let them ask the same questions as many times as they need to.

Make it real

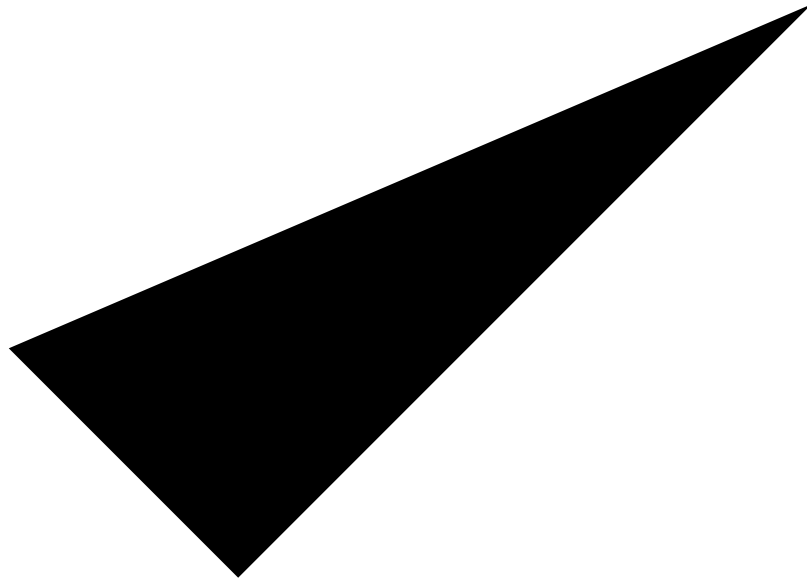
Picture the new life

Explore the new town online, find the local beach, park or pool, and if you can, look at their school's website together. The more they can imagine the everyday, the less frightening it feels.

Honour the goodbye

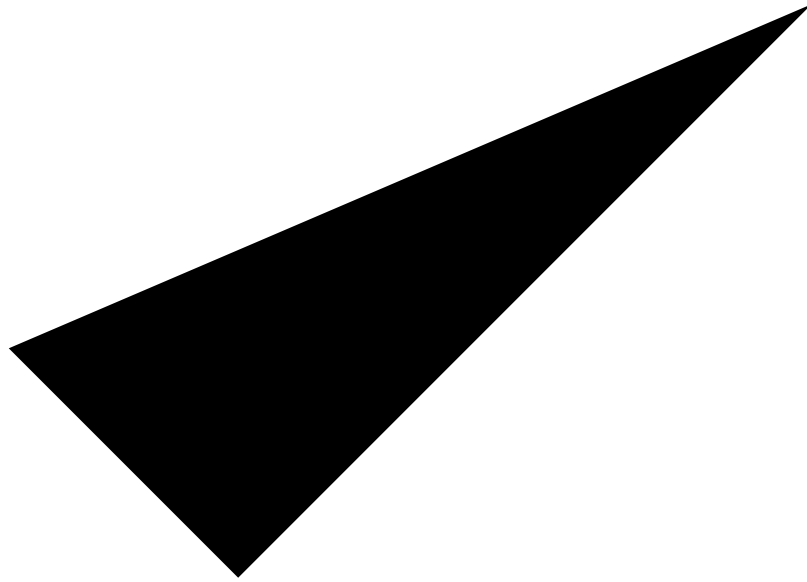
Let them say farewell

A proper goodbye matters. Help them mark leaving friends, family and a familiar home, a small party, a memory book, swapping addresses, so the move feels like a beginning, not a loss.



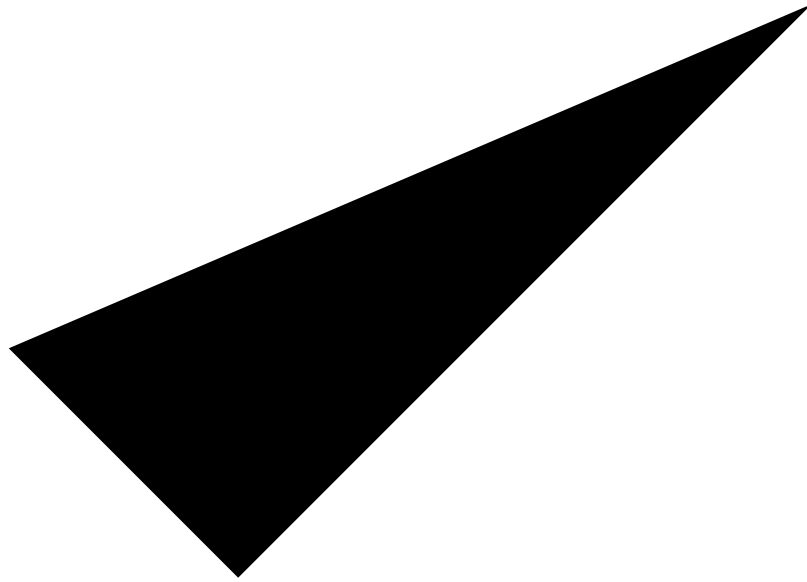
Keep one comfort close

A favourite toy, blanket or pillow should travel in the hand luggage, never the hold. Familiar things are anchors when everything else is new.



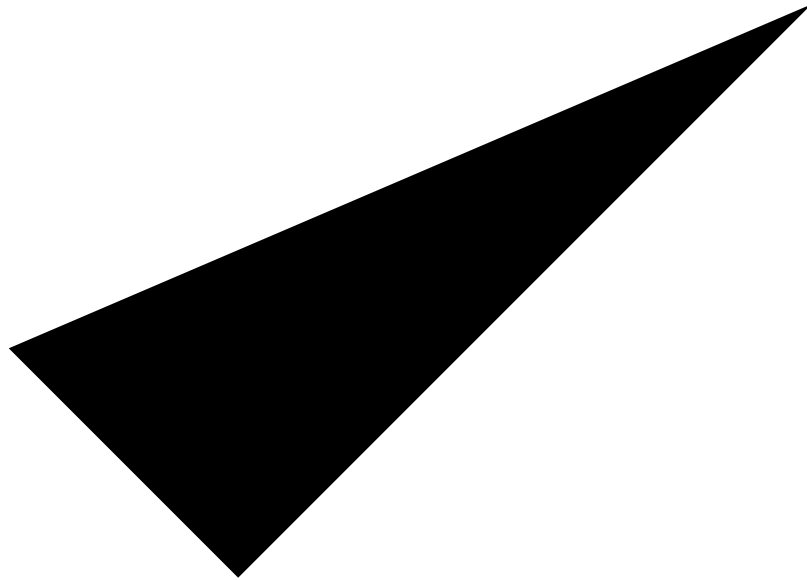
Plan to stay connected

Reassure them that grandparents and friends are a video call away. The time difference takes some juggling, but knowing loved ones haven't disappeared makes the distance easier.



Involve them in packing

Let older children choose a few of their own things to bring. A little ownership over the move turns something happening to them into something they're part of.



Sort documents & health

Carry passports, visas, and copies of immunisation records, medical notes and any prescriptions in your hand luggage. Australia's biosecurity rules are strict, so check what food and items you can bring before you pack.

— THE BIG ONE

Surviving the long flight

It's usually 20 to 24 hours with a stop somewhere. Airlines see families every day, and most parents tell us the planning is what turned it from an ordeal into a story.

Break the journey

Consider a stopover

A night's stopover en route (common hubs include the Gulf, Singapore, Hong Kong or Kuala Lumpur) can split an overwhelming trip into two manageable ones and let small bodies stretch, sleep and reset.

Ask for help

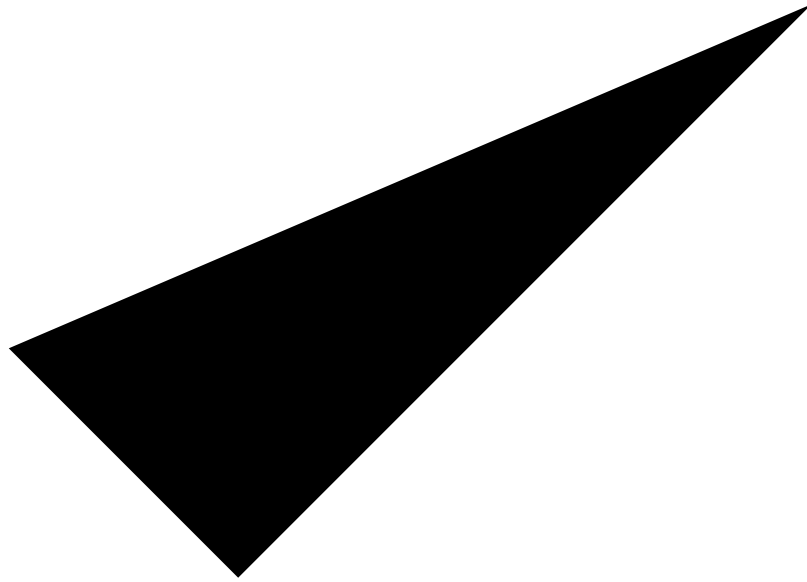
Tell the airline early

Request bassinets, children's meals and seats together when you book, and use family boarding. Cabin crew are well used to travelling children and will lend a hand if you ask.

Beat the boredom

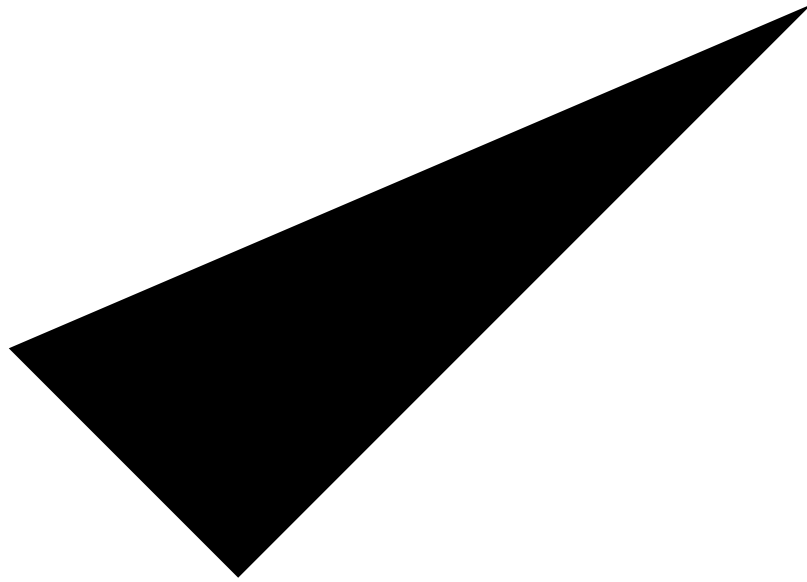
Pack a bag of surprises

Snacks, headphones, downloaded shows, and a few small wrapped activities handed out across the hours work wonders. Novelty buys you precious quiet stretches.



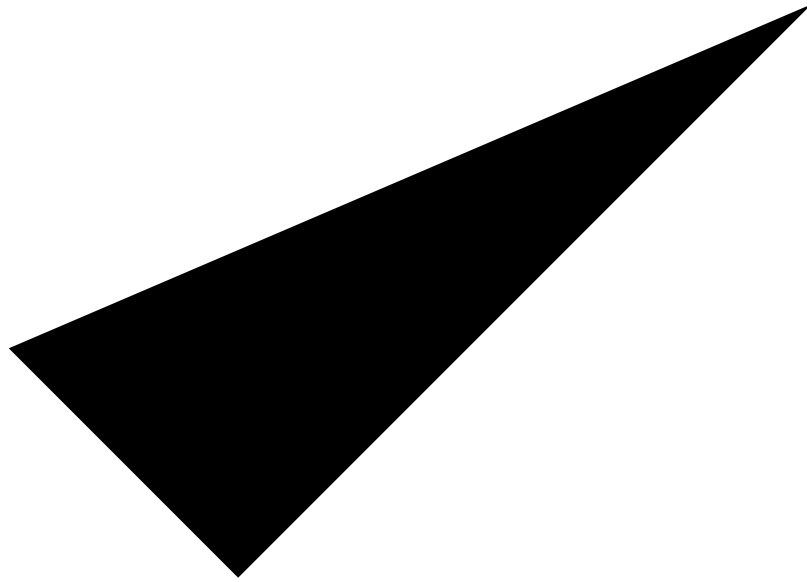
Dress for sleep

Comfy layers and familiar pyjamas signal bedtime even at 35,000 feet, and layers cope with cabins that swing from warm to chilly.



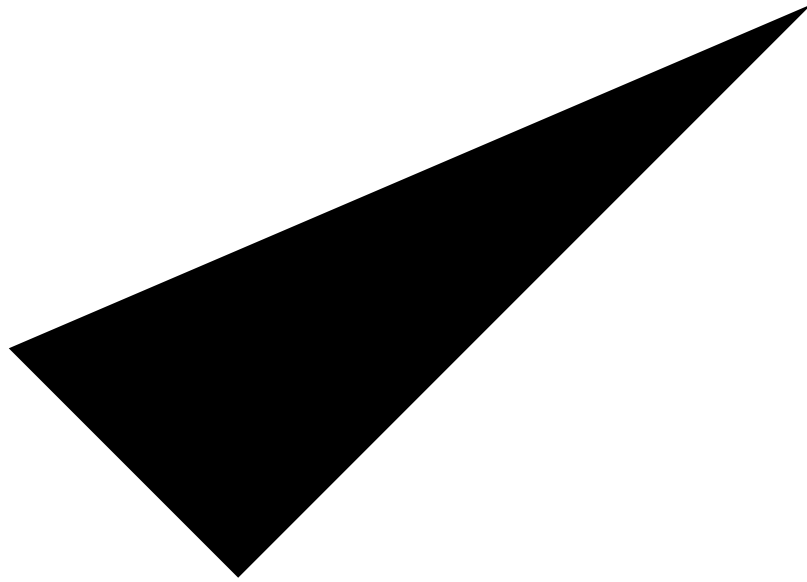
Ease little ears

Feeding, a drink or a chew during take-off and landing helps with pressure. Pack more nappies, wipes and spare clothes than feels sensible.



Go gently on jet lag

The time difference is large, so nudge towards local time over the first few days with daylight, fresh air and patience. Expect early starts and odd-hour wakings for a week or so.



Mind the biosecurity gate

Declare any food, and don't pack fresh produce. Australia's arrival biosecurity is strict. Knowing this in advance saves a stressful first hour at the airport with tired children.

— WHEN YOU LAND

The first 48 hours

You'll land tired, probably at an odd hour, and into bright sun if it's summer. Most families find the first couple of days are best kept small — rest, food, a gentle look around.

Rest & hydrate

Don't fight the jet lag with a packed schedule. Let everyone sleep, eat simply, and surface slowly, and in the heat, get the children drinking water, slip-slop-slapping on sunscreen and out of the midday sun.

Find the everyday

A trip to the local supermarket, park or beach in the first day or two makes the new place feel ordinary and knowable, fast, for children especially.

Recreate small routines

The familiar bedtime story, the same breakfast, the favourite cup. Tiny rituals carried from home are how children feel safe somewhere new.

— FINDING YOUR FEET

The first few weeks

Once the jet lag lifts it becomes gentle, steady work: a rhythm, school or care, and time for them to make this place their own.

Get into school soon

Routine and friends are the fastest cure for homesickness, so enrol and start school or early learning sooner rather than later. Our [education guide](#) walks through how it works, including the bits that depend on your visa.

Say yes to invitations

Playdates, birthday parties, Nippers at the surf club, weekend sport: these are where Australian childhood friendships form. Accepting invitations, for parents too, is how a family puts down roots.

Expect the wobble

A few weeks in, the novelty fades and the missing-home feelings can arrive, for children and adults alike. It's a normal stage, not a setback. Keep routines steady and it passes.

— THE DECISION THAT SHAPES THE REST

Choosing where to live, with the family in mind

For families, where you settle often matters as much as the role. A diverse city suburb and a small regional town are both good lives, and quite different ones — children tend to notice the difference as much

as anyone.

In the cities, you'll find the widest choice of schools, the most established communities, and classmates from every background, so a child who's a visible minority is one of many. In small country towns and the remote outback, the pace is gentler and the welcome often warm, but there's less diversity, fewer services and a child may be one of very few from their background. For some families that closeness is a gift; for others it can feel isolating. **It's worth thinking about honestly, with your children's needs in the picture.**

There's a practical layer too: in most states, a government school place is tied to your home address through a **catchment zone**, so the suburb and the school decision go hand in hand. It's well worth researching schools *before* you choose a rental. Our **community guide** goes deeper on how diversity changes by place.

This is exactly the kind of thing we'll talk through with you: your children's ages, what matters to your family, and the honest character of the places you're considering. We'd far rather help you choose well up front than watch a family settle somewhere that was never going to suit them.

DIFFERENT AGES, DIFFERENT NEEDS

Settling, age by age

A toddler, a school-age child and a teenager experience the same move in completely different ways. Knowing what to expect, and what helps, at each stage takes a lot of the worry out of it.

Babies & toddlers

The portable ones

0–4

The easiest to relocate and the quickest to settle: their world is you. Protect sleep and feeding routines, keep their comfort items close, and they'll be at home wherever you are within days.

Primary age

The fast adapters

5–11

Usually settle within weeks. Friendly, outdoor, sporty Australian classrooms make friends easy to come by. Children this age often adapt before their parents have unpacked the last box.

Twens

The ones to watch

12–13

Old enough to feel the loss of friends keenly, young enough to make new ones readily. Help them stay in touch with old friends while gently encouraging clubs and activities that build new circles.

Teenagers

The ones who need a say

14+

Moving at a decisive age is hard, and they need more time and more involvement. Bring them into decisions, take homesickness seriously, mind how the senior-school years (and the ATAR) line up, and give the first term or two before judging how it's going.

THE DECISION CHECKLIST

Moving with your family: the questions to settle first

The career can be right and the move still wrong for the people coming with you. These are the questions that decide whether it adds up, settle them before you fall for a suburb.

WHAT WILL MY PARTNER DO?

Two careers move, not one, and their right to work comes from your visa rather than a job offer of their own. [Can my partner work?](#) on this page sets out what decides it, what to ask before you accept, and what to do if they are a clinician too. [Immigration & visas](#) explains how a partner fits the main application.

WILL WE PAY SCHOOL FEES?

It depends on your state and your visa: public schooling is not automatically free for every temporary-visa family, and the rules differ meaningfully between states. [Will I have to pay school fees?](#) answers it properly, read it before you choose a state, not after.

WHAT WILL CHILDCARE COST?

Under-fives are a different budget line entirely, and in popular suburbs the constraint is places rather than price. [Childcare, honestly](#) covers the options, the waiting lists, the subsidy question and what a clinical roster does to all three.

CAN WE MANAGE ON ONE INCOME AT FIRST?

Don't guess. Do the subtraction: net salary, minus rent, childcare, school costs, insurance, a car and the weekly shop. If the result works before a second income arrives, everything that follows is easier. [Salary & pay](#) and [the cost of relocating](#) give you the pieces.

WILL MY FAMILY HAVE HEALTHCARE COVER?

Medicare is not automatic on every temporary visa, and private health cover can be a visa condition in its own right. Check your family's position early, bring enough regular medication for the first weeks, and carry copies of medical records. [Understanding healthcare](#) covers Medicare and the private system.

WHEN IN THE SCHOOL YEAR SHOULD WE MOVE?

Aim for the long summer break and children get a clean start, though schools handle mid-year joins well too. Teenagers approaching their senior assessment years need the most care, plan around exam cycles, not flight prices.

DOES MY CHILD NEED EXTRA LEARNING SUPPORT?

Support does not transfer automatically with overseas paperwork. Get current reports and assessments before you leave, contact shortlisted schools before you commit to an address, and ask each one directly what support it can offer and how long assessments take to arrange.

CAN OUR PARENTS AND GRANDPARENTS JOIN US?

In stages, yes, the tiers mirror New Zealand's. Family-stream visitor visas (subclass 600) cover regular visits; the Sponsored Parent (Temporary) visa (subclass 870) allows stays of three or five years at a time, up to ten years in total, with sponsorship and health-insurance conditions, an annual cap and no work rights, and no pathway to residence. Permanent routes exist too: the Parent visa (subclass 103) carries a queue measured in decades, while the Contributory Parent visa (subclass 143) moves far faster in exchange for substantially higher contribution charges. Caps, charges and processing change, check the official [Home Affairs parent visa pages](https://immi.homeaffairs.gov.au) (<https://immi.homeaffairs.gov.au>) before promising anything to the grandparents.

TEMPORARY FIRST, OR PERMANENT RESIDENCE?

For families this is the quiet big one, because residence status, not the job, drives the school-fee, Medicare and subsidy answers above. Most clinicians arrive on the employer-sponsored Skills in Demand visa (subclass 482) with the family as secondary applicants; some roles support the permanent Employer Nomination Scheme (subclass 186) sooner, and regional classifications open further routes. Reaching permanence flips several of the costs on this page. [Immigration & visas](#) covers the pathways.

WHAT IF SOMEONE IN THE FAMILY HAS A HEALTH CONDITION OR DISABILITY?

This is the hardest question on the page, and the one to face earliest. Every applicant. Dependants included, must meet Australia's migration health requirement, and the test is projected cost, not diagnosis: a Medical Officer of the Commonwealth assesses whether a condition is likely to cost more than the Significant Cost Threshold, currently A\$86,000, over ten years (or the visa length). Regardless of your ability to pay privately. Classic triggers include high-cost PBS medicines (biologics such as adalimumab), dialysis- or transplant-level care, and autism-related support needs in a child, which is why autism can complicate an application even when the child is thriving. If one family member fails, the whole application can be refused; health waivers exist on some visa subclasses only, and are discretionary. Declare everything honestly, gather specialist reports and costed treatment plans before you apply, and for anything borderline take advice from a registered migration agent. This is the one part of a move where that professional advice earns its fee. The official [Home Affairs health requirement](https://immi.homeaffairs.gov.au/help-support/meeting-our-requirements/health) (<https://immi.homeaffairs.gov.au/help-support/meeting-our-requirements/health>) pages carry the current rules; whether a particular medicine is PBS-funded is a separate question again, see [Understanding healthcare](#).

We're recruitment specialists, not registered migration agents, and none of this is immigration, tax or financial advice. Visa conditions and eligibility rules change, so confirm the current position with the Department of Home Affairs and the schools themselves before committing.

Looking after yourself, too

It's a quiet truth of moving with children: you'll pour everything into settling them and forget to settle yourself. But a calm, supported parent is the single biggest thing a child needs to feel safe somewhere new.

Give yourself permission to find it hard. You're holding down a new job, running an unfamiliar household and being everyone's reassurance, often without your usual support network nearby, and the distance from family back home can feel further from Australia than almost anywhere. Build your own footholds early: say yes to the school-gate chat, find one or two other parents, and lean on the communities who've made the same move. You don't have to do it perfectly, and you certainly don't have to do it alone.

If you ever feel you're struggling more than seems normal, reach out, to your GP, to a helpline, or to us. **Asking for support is part of doing this well, not a sign you've got it wrong.**

Sophie's insight

I've sat with so many parents who lay awake over this exact question, the flight, the schools, whether they're doing the right thing by their children. Here's what I've seen, again and again: the kids are usually fine, and often more than fine. They take to the beach and the outdoor life, they make friends at the park, and within a term this is home. My honest advice is to look after yourselves as carefully as you look after them, and to choose where you live with the whole family in mind, not just the commute. Pointing families towards the right town, the right school and the right people is one of the parts of this work I love most.

Sophie CEO & Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

COMMON QUESTIONS

The questions parents ask us

When's the best time of year to move with school-age children?—

The Australian school year runs from late January to mid-December, in four terms, so arriving around late January lets children begin with everyone else. That said, schools take new arrivals throughout the year and are well practised at it, the right time is mostly the one that fits your job and visa, so don't force it to line up perfectly.

How long until the children really settle?+

What about childcare while we're both finding our feet?+

Will being on a temporary visa affect my child's schooling?+

Can you help us choose where to live with the family in mind?+

 **KEEP EXPLORING**

Related guides

Finding your people in Australia

A new job is only half of a move. The other half is belonging: faith, culture, friendship and a taste of home.

PAGE AT A GLANCE

1. [Faith & worship](#)
2. [Cultural communities](#)
3. [Diversity by place](#)
4. [First Nations & a fair go](#)
5. [An inclusive welcome](#)
6. [A taste of home](#)
7. [Finding your community](#)
8. [Communities & networks](#)

Kettle on. A longer read — about 18 min

WHY THIS MATTERS

Belonging is what makes a move last

The clinicians who settle for good aren't the ones with the biggest salary. They're the ones who found their people — a place to worship, a familiar festival, a friend who cooks the food of home.

Australia is one of the most multicultural countries in the world. Almost half its people were born overseas or have a parent who was, and the big cities are a true mix of cultures, faiths and languages from every corner of the earth. The healthcare workforce itself is wonderfully international.

But here's the honest part, and it's the most important thing on this page: **that diversity is not spread evenly across the country.** The capitals are among the most cosmopolitan cities anywhere; large regional cities are reasonably mixed; and small country towns and the remote outback are predominantly Anglo-Australian, where a newcomer who looks or worships differently can feel far more visible. None of that means a place is unwelcoming, but it changes the day-to-day, and you deserve to know before you choose where to live.

Our promise in this guide is simple: **we'll tell you the truth about a town before you move there.** Where your community already exists, what life tends to feel like for people from your background, and whether somewhere is likely to suit your family, honestly, with no pressure either way.

FAITH & PLACES OF WORSHIP

A place to worship, whatever your faith

Freedom of religion is protected in law, and there are active communities across all the major faiths. In the cities especially you'll find established congregations across many traditions, though in smaller towns the choice narrows, sometimes sharply.

Kirtan at a Melbourne gurdwara. Whatever your tradition, the congregation is usually already there — the question is how far from the hospital it is.

Christian

Churches of every tradition

From Catholic, Anglican and Uniting to Pentecostal, Orthodox and a wide range of ethnic-specific congregations, Christian communities are found in every city and most towns: many with services in languages other than English.

Muslim

Mosques & Islamic centres

Long-established Muslim communities in the major cities run mosques, Islamic centres and schools, and halal food is easy to find. In regional and remote areas, mosques and halal options are far fewer and worth checking before you move.

Hindu

Temples & cultural life

A large, active Hindu community supports temples and cultural associations in the cities, with festivals such as Diwali celebrated publicly, often as major city-wide events.

Sikh

Gurdwaras & community

A fast-growing Sikh population maintains gurdwaras across the cities and a number of regional centres, offering worship, langar and a strong, practical welcome for new arrivals.

Buddhist

Temples & meditation

Buddhist temples and meditation centres reflect Australia's diverse Asian communities, welcoming both heritage practitioners and newcomers to the practice.

Jewish & others

Settled communities

Well-established Jewish communities are concentrated in Sydney and Melbourne, with synagogues, schools and kosher food. Many other faith communities are present too, mostly in the larger cities. Faith communities are often the fastest route to friendship and practical help when you arrive: many run welcome groups, share local knowledge and lend a hand with the early settling-in. It's worth reaching out before you even land. If your faith matters to you, tell us; it can shape which town is the right one.

CULTURAL & DIASPORA COMMUNITIES

Chances are, your community is already here, in the cities

Healthcare professionals come here from all over the world, and communities form where people settle — mostly around the capitals. Knowing where yours is established can help when you're choosing a base.

Established diaspora networks

Large, active communities from the UK, Ireland, India, the Philippines, South Africa, China, Vietnam, the Middle East and across the Pacific mean cultural associations, social events and familiar faces are rarely far away in the cities.

Professional peer groups

Because so many clinicians have made this exact move, from the UK, South Africa, the UAE and beyond, you'll find others in your profession who share your background and understand both the work and the journey.

Cultural festivals & events

Diwali, Eid, Lunar New Year, Holi, Vaisakhi and many more are celebrated openly and often city-wide: public, joyful occasions that make it easy to stay connected to your heritage and share it.

Community language & schooling

Many communities run weekend language and culture schools so children stay connected to their heritage language and traditions while they grow up as young Australians.

Social media & local groups

Active online groups for almost every nationality and city are where newcomers ask questions, find housing, swap recommendations and arrange the first real-life catch-ups.

Sport & shared interests

Cricket, football, netball, cultural dance, choirs and hobby clubs are some of the easiest, most natural ways to meet people who share your interests and, often, your background.

THE HONEST PART

Diversity changes enormously by place

Australia is diverse on average, and the average hides a wide gap between a city suburb and a remote town. If your faith or culture is central to your life, where you settle matters as much as the job.

Most diverse

The big cities

Sydney · Melbourne · Perth · Brisbane · Adelaide

Among the most multicultural cities on earth. In many suburbs the majority of residents were born overseas, you'll hear dozens of languages, and almost every faith, cuisine and community is well represented. For most people from any background, the capitals feel cosmopolitan and easy to belong in.

This is where established diaspora communities, places of worship, cultural grocers and international schools are concentrated, and where being from somewhere else is completely ordinary.

Mixed

Large regional cities

e.g. Newcastle · Geelong · Townsville · Cairns · Toowoomba

The bigger regional centres are reasonably diverse and growing more so, partly because healthcare and universities draw people from everywhere. You'll usually find at least one mosque, temple or cultural association, some international groceries, and other migrant families, though less choice than a capital, and it varies a lot from town to town.

Least diverse

Small towns & the remote outback

Inland NSW/QLD/SA · remote WA & NT communities

Small country towns and remote areas are predominantly Anglo-Australian, alongside significant Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander populations in parts of the outback. There may be no mosque, temple or gurdwara for hundreds of kilometres, little or no halal or cultural food, and you may be one of very few people of your background in town.

Being honest: most people find country Australians warm, direct and welcoming, and many newcomers thrive in the close-knit pace. But as a visible minority you will be more conspicuous, and a minority of people do encounter staring, awkward assumptions or, occasionally, outright prejudice. It's not the norm, but it's real, and it weighs differently for a family than for a single clinician on a fixed contract.

So a Black clinician from South Africa, a Muslim family from the UK or a Hindu radiographer from India might love a busy Perth or Melbourne suburb, and find a tiny outback town isolating. **That's exactly the kind of trade-off we'll talk through with you, town by town, before you accept anything.** Sometimes the answer is a regional city rather than a remote one; sometimes it's choosing the suburb carefully. There's almost always a way to get both the role and the community, it just takes an honest conversation first.

THE CULTURE YOU'RE JOINING

First Nations Australia & the 'fair go'

Australia has the world's oldest continuous living cultures, cared for by Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples for more than 60,000 years. In remote and regional areas you may work closely with Aboriginal communities.

In healthcare this matters practically. Many services place real emphasis on **cultural safety**: care that respects a patient's culture, history and identity, and you may take part in cultural awareness training, hear an *Acknowledgement of Country* at the start

of meetings, or work alongside Aboriginal Health Workers. You don't need to know all of this on arrival; a willingness to learn and to show respect goes a very long way, and it's one of the quiet privileges of working here.

Australians talk a lot about a **“fair go”**, the idea that everyone deserves a fair chance regardless of background. It's a genuine part of the national character and you'll feel it in how flat, first-name and unpretentious workplaces tend to be. Like any ideal it isn't lived out perfectly everywhere, but it's a real and widely-held value, and it sits behind much of the warmth newcomers describe.

If you're considering a remote role with a large Aboriginal community, we'll talk you through what the work and the cultural context are like, so you arrive prepared and respectful rather than surprised.

AN INCLUSIVE WELCOME

A country that welcomes you as you are

Australia has strong anti-discrimination law covering race, religion, sex, sexual orientation and disability, at work and in everyday life. The protections apply everywhere; the lived experience is warmest in the cities.

LGBTQ+ communities

Marriage equality has been law since 2017, protections are nationwide, and the cities have visible, thriving communities and major events such as Sydney's Mardi Gras. Smaller towns are often quieter and more conservative, but the law protects you everywhere.

Equality at work

Workplaces, including across the health system, take inclusion and anti-discrimination seriously under the Fair Work framework. You should expect to be treated with respect and fairness as a matter of course.

Families of every shape

Single parents, blended families, same-sex parents and multi-generational households are all an ordinary, accepted part of Australian life.

A TASTE OF HOME

The small comforts that matter most

It's the little things that catch people out: the spice you can't find, the snack from childhood. In the cities most are surprisingly close; in the regions, most people end up planning ahead and ordering online.

Food & groceries

The big supermarkets, Woolworths, Coles and ALDI, carry growing world-food aisles, and the cities have large Asian, Indian, Middle Eastern, African and European grocers. Halal, kosher and a huge range of cultural foods are easy to find in metro areas; online ordering fills most gaps elsewhere.

Restaurants & community kitchens

From South Indian and Filipino to Lebanese, Vietnamese, Korean and beyond, city restaurants serve the real thing, and community events where home cooking is shared generously are some of the best ways to meet people.

Festivals & traditions

The celebrations you grew up with are very likely marked here too, often publicly in the cities. Keeping your own traditions alive, and being invited into others', is part of what makes life here rich.

Halal

Halal food is widely available in the cities: many mainstream supermarkets and butchers stock halal-certified meat, and metro areas have dedicated halal butchers, grocers and restaurants. In regional and remote areas the choice narrows considerably, so it's worth checking what's available in a specific town before you commit.

Kosher

Kosher options are concentrated in Sydney and Melbourne, which have kosher stores, butchers and delis alongside established Jewish communities. Elsewhere it's mostly online or through the local community, the peak Jewish bodies in the [useful links](#) are the best people to point you to current suppliers.

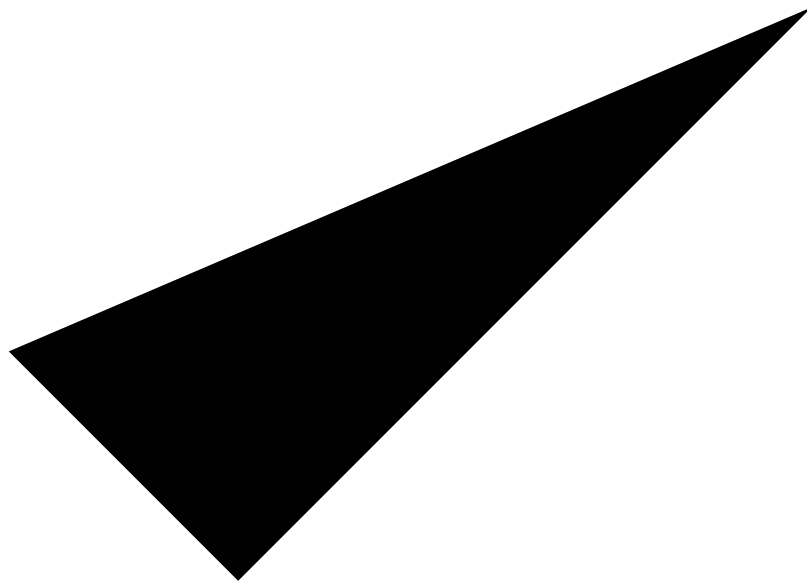
African & South African

Biltong, boerewors and braai staples, plus West and East African groceries, are available through specialist stores in the cities and a number of online retailers that ship Australia-wide, a real comfort if you're moving from South Africa or elsewhere on the continent.

PRACTICAL FIRST STEPS

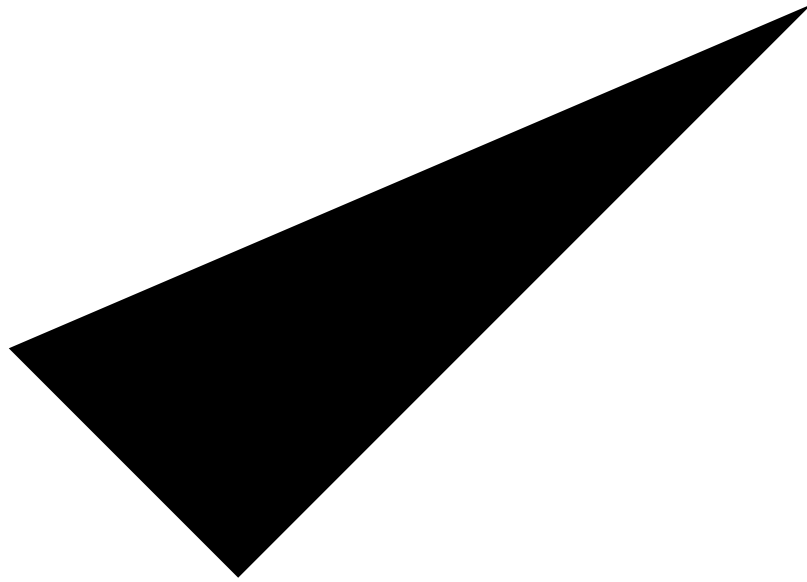
How to find your people, quickly

Community rarely just appears, but a little intention in your first weeks makes all the difference. These are the things we suggest to every clinician we place, and they work.



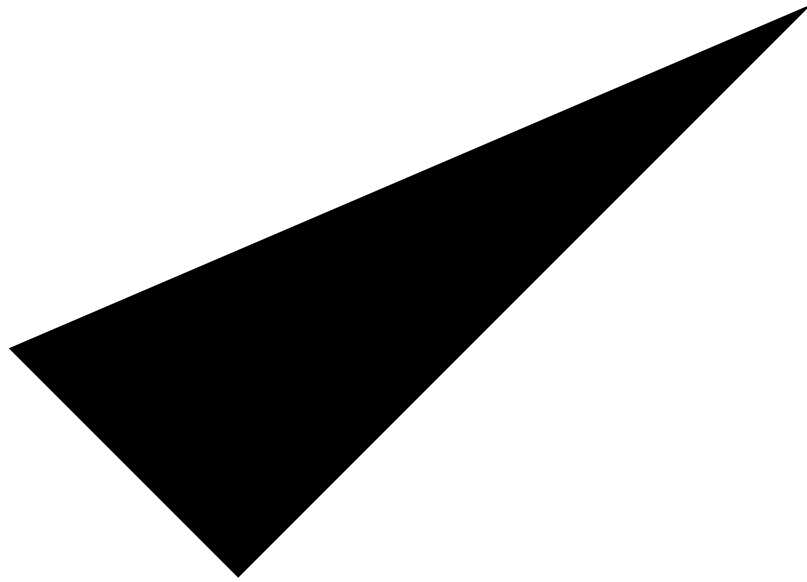
Connect before you arrive

Search online for groups linked to your nationality, faith or city. Introducing yourself early means a friendly contact or two before you even land.



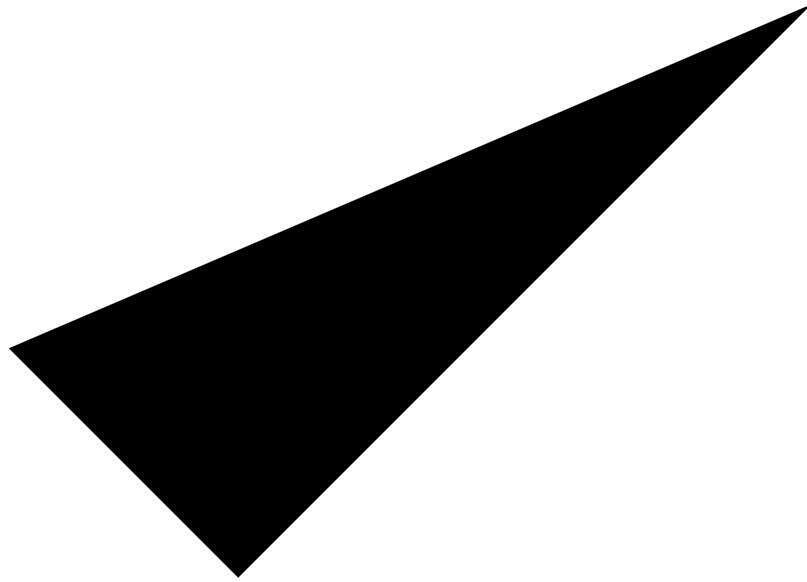
Choose your suburb with care

In a big city the suburb shapes everything: community, schools, places of worship, the food shops. We'll help you pick one that fits your family, not just your commute.



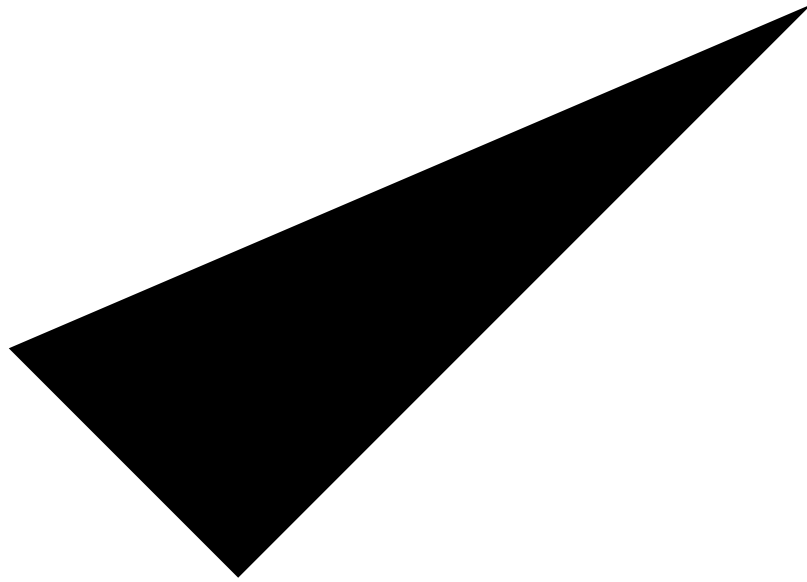
Use your workplace

Colleagues are often your first community, and many have made the same move. Ask them where to worship, shop and gather, they'll know.



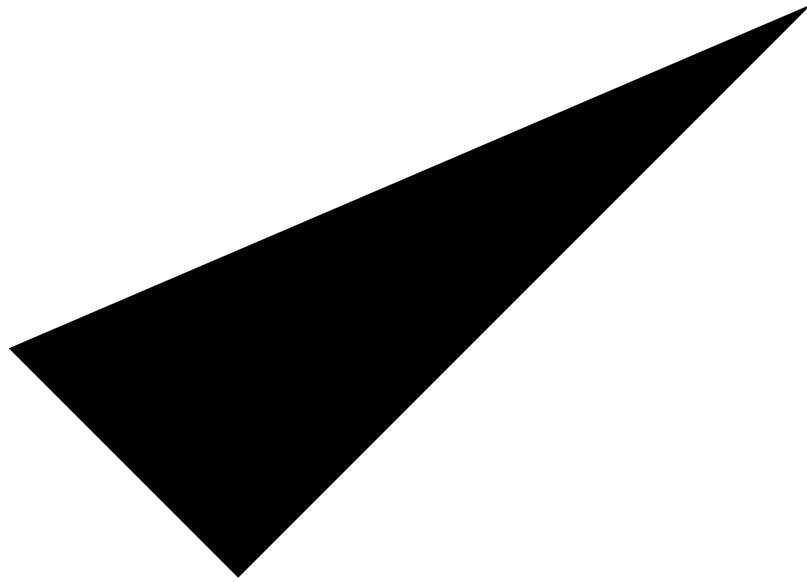
Join one regular thing

A weekly class, sports team, choir or place of worship gives your week an anchor and the same faces each time, which is how acquaintances become friends.



Bring your culture with you

Cook for new neighbours, share your festivals, contribute what's yours. Belonging flows both ways, and people love being welcomed into something new.



Ask us

We know the makeup of the towns we place people in, and we'll be honest about where you're likely to find your community, and where you might not.

— COMMUNITIES & SUPPORT NETWORKS

A curated directory to help you belong

The job is one part of it. The rest is finding your people, keeping your traditions and knowing where to turn — so we've gathered those networks and services in one place.

Your profession

Professional communities

Connect with clinicians who've already made the move. These groups are a good place to ask the practical questions, compare notes and start building your network before you even arrive, a quick search surfaces the most active communities in your field.

Doctors

[UK Doctors in Australia](https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=uk%20doctors%20in%20australia) (<https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=uk%20doctors%20in%20australia>) [Doctors in Australia](https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=doctors%20in%20australia) (<https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=doctors%20in%20australia>)

Nurses

[UK Nurses in Australia](https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=uk%20nurses%20in%20australia) (<https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=uk%20nurses%20in%20australia>) [Nurses in Australia](https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=nurses%20in%20australia) (<https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=nurses%20in%20australia>)

Medical imaging

[Radiographers Australia](https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=radiographers%20australia) (<https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=radiographers%20australia>) [Sonographers Australia](https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=sonographers%20australia) (<https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=sonographers%20australia>)

Allied health

[Physiotherapists in Australia](https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=physiotherapists%20in%20australia) (<https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=physiotherapists%20in%20australia>)

[Occupational Therapists Australia](https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=occupational%20therapists%20australia) (<https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=occupational%20therapists%20australia>)

General

[International Healthcare Professionals Australia](https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=international%20healthcare%20professionals%20australia) (<https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=international%20healthcare%20professionals%20australia>)

Your people

Diaspora communities

Find your community before you even arrive: people who share your language, culture and the experience of moving.

[British Expats · Australia](https://britishexpats.com/forum/australia-54/) (<https://britishexpats.com/forum/australia-54/>) [InterNations Australia](https://www.internations.org/australia-expats) (<https://www.internations.org/australia-expats>) [Brits Moving to Australia](https://www.facebook.com/groups/britsmovingtoaustralia/) (<https://www.facebook.com/groups/britsmovingtoaustralia/>) [South Africans in Australia](https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=south%20africans%20in%20australia) (<https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=south%20africans%20in%20australia>) [Indians in Australia](https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=indians%20in%20australia) (<https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=indians%20in%20australia>) [Filipinos in Australia](https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=filipinos%20in%20australia) (<https://www.facebook.com/search/groups/?q=filipinos%20in%20australia>)

What's on

Festivals & cultural events

Celebrate your own culture and discover Australia's. There's something happening all year round.

[What's On · Australia](https://www.australia.com/en/events.html) (<https://www.australia.com/en/events.html>) [Sydney Festival](https://www.sydneyfestival.org.au/) (<https://www.sydneyfestival.org.au/>) [Melbourne · What's On](https://whatson.melbourne.vic.gov.au/) (<https://whatson.melbourne.vic.gov.au/>) [Harmony Week](https://www.harmony.gov.au/) (<https://www.harmony.gov.au/>) [NAIDOC Week](https://www.naidoc.org.au/) (<https://www.naidoc.org.au/>)

For the family

Language & cultural schools

Help your children stay connected to their heritage language and culture as they grow up here.

[Community Languages Australia](https://communitylanguages.org.au/) (<https://communitylanguages.org.au/>) [SBS Languages](https://www.sbs.com.au/language/en) (<https://www.sbs.com.au/language/en>) [My School](https://www.myschool.edu.au/) (<https://www.myschool.edu.au/>) [Australian Government · Education](https://www.education.gov.au/) (<https://www.education.gov.au/>)

Meeting people

Local & social groups

One of the easiest ways to feel at home is to get involved locally. Find people who share your interests.

[Meetup Australia](https://www.meetup.com/en-AU/) (<https://www.meetup.com/en-AU/>) [Eventbrite Australia](https://www.eventbrite.com.au/) (<https://www.eventbrite.com.au/>) [InterNations Australia](https://www.internations.org/australia-expats) (<https://www.internations.org/australia-expats>) [Facebook local groups](https://www.facebook.com/groups/) (<https://www.facebook.com/groups/>)

Getting involved

Sport & shared interests

Joining a local club is one of the quickest ways to make friends, stay active and become part of your community.

[parkrun Australia](https://www.parkrun.com.au/) (<https://www.parkrun.com.au/>) [PlayHQ · community sport](https://www.playhq.com/) (<https://www.playhq.com/>) [Sport Australia](https://www.sportaus.gov.au/) (<https://www.sportaus.gov.au/>) [Scouts Australia](https://scouts.com.au/) (<https://scouts.com.au/>) [Girl Guides Australia](https://www.girlguides.org.au/) (<https://www.girlguides.org.au/>)

Everyone belongs

LGBTQIA+ communities

Australia is one of the world's most LGBTQIA+-inclusive countries, with welcoming communities, professional networks and events in every major city.

[Sydney Gay & Lesbian Mardi Gras](https://www.mardigras.org.au/) (<https://www.mardigras.org.au/>) [Pride in Health + Wellbeing](https://www.prideinhealth.com.au/) [Inclusive healthcare](https://www.prideinhealth.com.au/) (<https://www.prideinhealth.com.au/>) [QLife](https://qlife.org.au/) [National peer support & referral](https://qlife.org.au/) (<https://qlife.org.au/>) [Rainbow Families Australia](https://www.rainbowfamilies.com.au/) [Support for LGBTQIA+ families](https://www.rainbowfamilies.com.au/) (<https://www.rainbowfamilies.com.au/>) [InterPride](https://interpride.org/) (<https://interpride.org/>)

When you need support

Faith, accessibility & wellbeing

Moving abroad doesn't mean leaving your faith or your support behind. Places of worship, accessibility services and mental-health support, the networks that help you look after yourself and the people you love.

Faith & worship

[National Council of Churches](https://www.ncca.org.au/) (<https://www.ncca.org.au/>) [Find a Church](https://www.churchesaustralia.com.au/) (<https://www.churchesaustralia.com.au/>) [Australian National Imams Council](https://www.anic.org.au/) (<https://www.anic.org.au/>) [Hindu Council of Australia](https://hinducouncil.com.au/) (<https://hinducouncil.com.au/>) [Sikh Council of Australia](https://www.sikhcouncil.org.au/) (<https://www.sikhcouncil.org.au/>) [Executive Council of Australian Jewry](https://www.ecaj.org.au/) (<https://www.ecaj.org.au/>) [Buddhist Council of NSW](https://buddhistcouncil.org/) (<https://buddhistcouncil.org/>)

Accessibility & disability

[Disability Gateway](https://www.disabilitygateway.gov.au/) [Government information & services](https://www.disabilitygateway.gov.au/) (<https://www.disabilitygateway.gov.au/>) [People with Disability Australia](https://pwd.org.au/) (<https://pwd.org.au/>) [Carers Australia](https://www.carersaustralia.com.au/) (<https://www.carersaustralia.com.au/>) [Disability Sports Australia](https://www.disabilitysportsaustralia.org.au/) (<https://www.disabilitysportsaustralia.org.au/>)

Wellbeing & mental health

[Lifeline Australia](https://www.lifeline.org.au/) [24/7 crisis support · 13 11 14](https://www.lifeline.org.au/) (<https://www.lifeline.org.au/>) [Beyond Blue](https://www.beyondblue.org.au/) [Anxiety, depression & support](https://www.beyondblue.org.au/) (<https://www.beyondblue.org.au/>) [Head to Health](https://www.headtohealth.gov.au/) (<https://www.headtohealth.gov.au/>) [Black Dog Institute](https://www.blackdoginstitute.org.au/) (<https://www.blackdoginstitute.org.au/>)

These are starting points, not endorsements: each link opens an external site we don't control, and communities come and go. If you can't find yours, or you'd like a warm introduction to people who've walked the same path, tell us where you're moving and what matters to you. See also our [Useful contacts](#) guide.

If you need help now

Relocating is hard, and the months after arriving are when it tends to land. Both of these are free, and neither is a last resort.

[13 11 14](#)

Lifeline

Crisis support and suicide prevention, 24 hours a day. Call, or text 0477 13 11 14.

[000](#)

Emergency services

Police, fire or ambulance, anywhere in Australia. Ask for the service you need.

Sophie's insight

People worry, quietly, about whether they'll fit in, whether they'll find somewhere to pray, food that tastes like home, friends who understand them, and whether they'll be made to feel welcome. I take those worries seriously, because the answer depends on where you go. A family might feel completely at home in a diverse city suburb and quite isolated in a remote town with the same job title. My job is to tell you that honestly, before you decide, not after. There is almost always a way to find both the right role and the right community. It just starts with a frank conversation, and I'd much rather have it early.

Sophie CEO & Founder, Ethicare Resourcing

COMMON QUESTIONS

The questions people ask us about belonging

What's it like as a person of colour or visible minority in a small town?—

It depends a lot on the town, and we'll always give you an honest read on a specific one. In the big cities, being from anywhere is completely ordinary and most people feel very much at home. In small country towns and remote areas, which are predominantly Anglo-Australian, you'll be more visible, and while most country Australians are warm and welcoming, a minority of people do experience staring, clumsy assumptions or occasional prejudice. It's not the norm, but it's real. For many single clinicians on a fixed contract it's a non-issue; for a family putting down roots it can matter more. If it's a concern, a diverse regional city or a well-chosen city suburb is often a better fit than a remote posting, and we'll help you weigh it up.

Will I be able to practise my religion freely?+

Is there a community of people from my country?+

How welcoming is Australia to LGBTQ+ people?+

Can you help me choose somewhere I'll actually belong?+

KEEP EXPLORING

Related guides

REFERENCE GUIDE

Useful contacts, websites & community

The official Australian links you'll actually need, and the people we trust to help you settle.

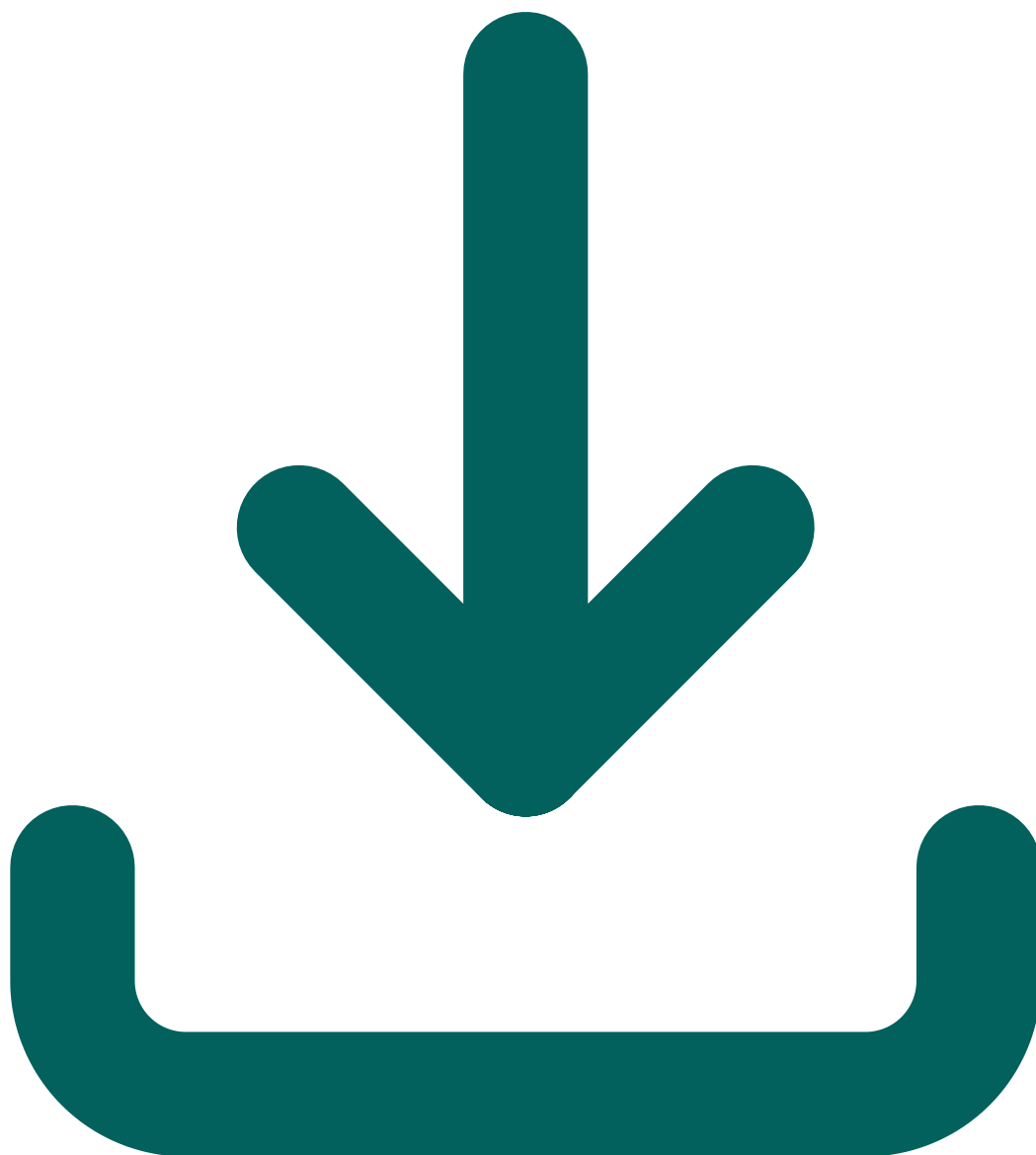


Kettle on. A longer read – about 6 min

FREE DOWNLOADABLE GUIDES

Practical guides you can keep

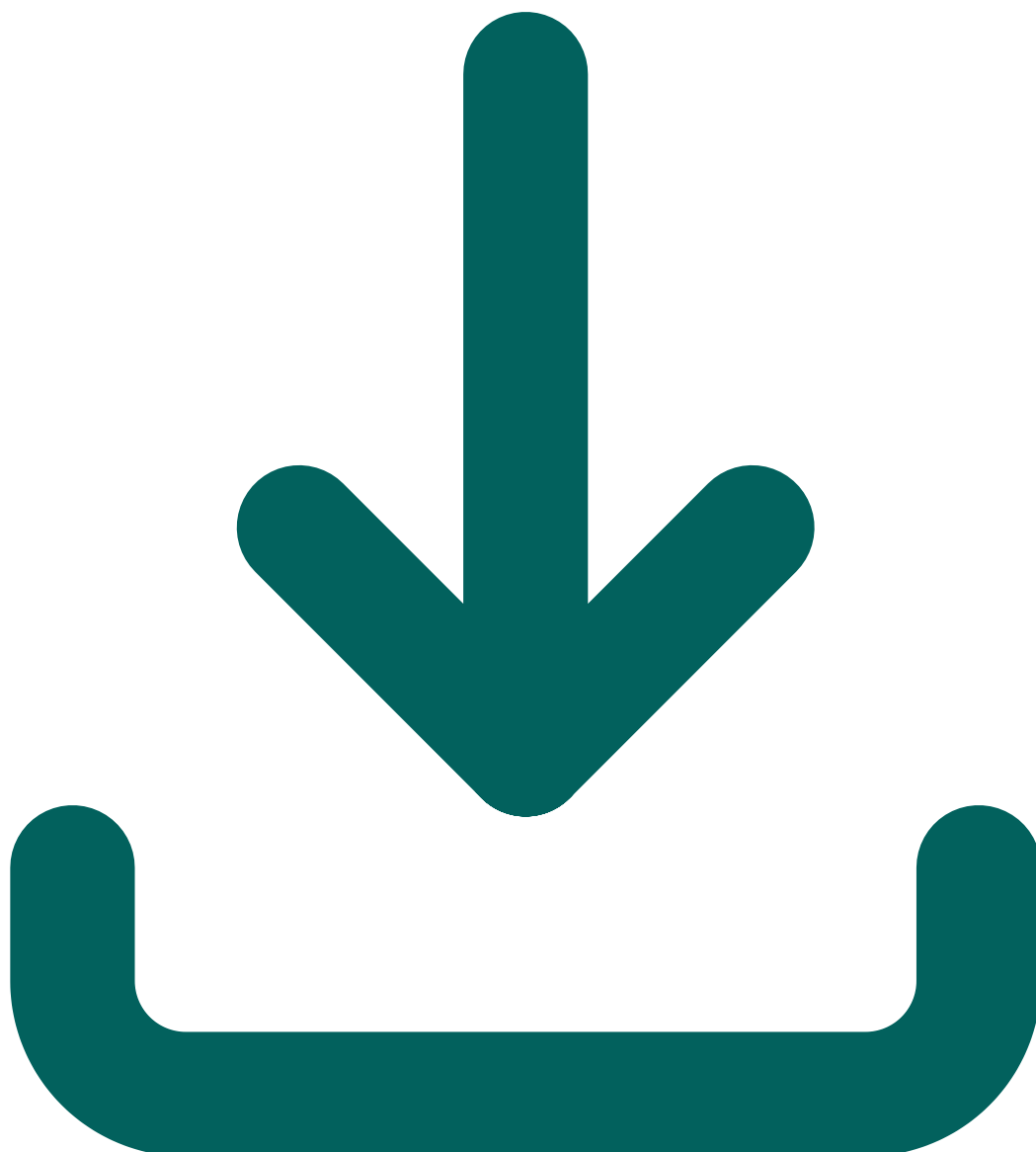
No-nonsense, honest guides to download and read at your own pace, written from years of helping healthcare professionals make this move.



Interview Preparation Guide

How to prepare for Australian healthcare interviews: STAR answers, common questions and calm, practical advice.

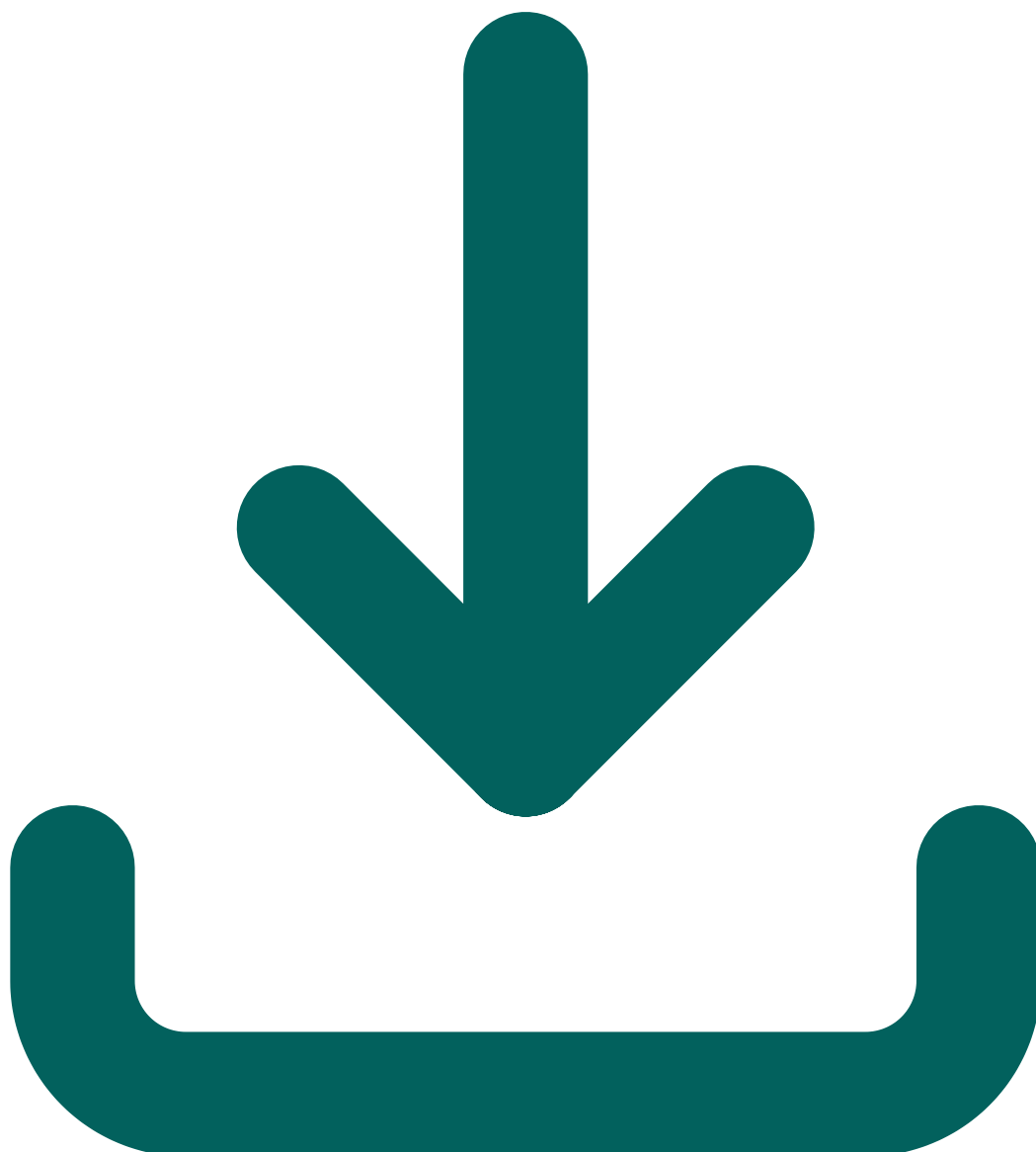
[Download PDF](#) ↓



Build your CV

Presenting your experience clearly for Australian employers: structure, what to include and what to leave out. Guided, on your device, and it gives you a file to send.

[Open the CV builder →](#)



Moving to Australia

Our national guide, printed as a book: registration, visas, shipping, housing, schools and those first few weeks.

[Request a copy →](#)

— OFFICIAL LINKS & EVERYDAY CONTACTS

The official websites, in one place

Trustworthy official sources for registration, visas, healthcare, tax, schools and licences. Much of Australia runs nationally through Ahpra and the federal government; schools, licences and tenancy run state by state.

Registration & working

Registration

One national scheme, a board per profession

Ahpra · national registration (<https://www.ahpra.gov.au>) Medical Radiation Practice Board (<https://www.medicalradiationpracticeboard.gov.au>) Medical Board of Australia (<https://www.medicalboard.gov.au>)

Skills & accreditation

Profession bodies for skills assessment

ASAR · sonographer accreditation (<https://www.asar.com.au>) ASMIRT · medical imaging & RT (<https://www.asmirt.org>) OET · English for healthcare (<https://www.englishlanguage.com>)

Fair work

Your rights and pay at work

Fair Work Ombudsman (<https://www.fairwork.gov.au>) Awards & pay rates (<https://www.fairwork.gov.au/employment-conditions/awards>) Ethicare · current roles

Visas, money & healthcare

Immigration & tax

The federal essentials

Department of Home Affairs · visas (<https://immi.homeaffairs.gov.au>) Australian Taxation Office (ATO) (<https://www.ato.gov.au>) Moneysmart · budgeting (<https://moneysmart.gov.au>)

Healthcare & family

Medicare and government services

Services Australia · Medicare (<https://www.servicesaustralia.gov.au/medicare>) Child Care Subsidy (<https://www.servicesaustralia.gov.au/child-care-subsidy>) Department of Health (<https://www.health.gov.au>)

Everyday life

Settling in, the practical bits

Australian Bureau of Statistics (<https://www.abs.gov.au>) Healthdirect · find a GP (<https://www.healthdirect.gov.au>) Settling in Australia (<https://immi.homeaffairs.gov.au/settling-in-australia>)

Official bodies and current rules are always best confirmed at the source: details change. Ethicare are recruitment specialists, not licensed migration agents; for formal immigration advice we'll point you to a registered professional.

RUN BY THE STATES

Schools, licences & tenancy, by state

Schools and their zones, swapping an overseas driver licence, and your rights as a renter are run by each state and territory. Yours will be the one for wherever you're heading.

New South Wales+

Victoria+

Queensland+

Western Australia+

South Australia+

Tasmania+

Australian Capital Territory+

Northern Territory+

These are the departments to search for in each state. Names occasionally change, and several have an online school-finder that maps the catchment for any address. Tell us where you're heading and we'll point you to the current pages and, for schools, the right starting point for your visa type.

FAITH, CULTURE & COMMUNITY

Finding your community

The national bodies for the major faiths, the organisations that help newcomers settle, and a state-by-state starting point for multicultural groups.

Christian churches

National churches, parishes nationwide.

[Australian Catholic Bishops Conference](https://www.catholic.org.au) (<https://www.catholic.org.au>) [Anglican Church of Australia](https://www.anglican.org.au) (<https://www.anglican.org.au>) [Uniting Church in Australia](https://uniting.church) (<https://uniting.church>)

Other major faiths

National peak bodies, with centres in the main cities.

[Australian National Imams Council](https://www.anic.org.au) (<https://www.anic.org.au>) [Hindu Council of Australia](https://www.hinducouncil.com.au) (<https://www.hinducouncil.com.au>) [Executive Council of Australian Jewry](https://www.ecaj.org.au) (<https://www.ecaj.org.au>)

Newcomer & multicultural support

Settling in and finding people.

[Federation of Ethnic Communities' Councils](https://fecca.org.au) (<https://fecca.org.au>) [Home Affairs, settling in Australia](https://immi.homeaffairs.gov.au/settling-in-australia) (<https://immi.homeaffairs.gov.au/settling-in-australia>) [Ask Ethicare for an introduction](#)

Multicultural bodies, by state

Each state and territory has a multicultural commission and a network of migrant resource centres, a good first call for local groups, events and settlement help. A starting point, not an exhaustive list.

New South Wales+

Victoria+

Queensland+

Western Australia+

South Australia+

Tasmania+

ACT+

Northern Territory+

Links open external sites we don't control. The state bodies are examples to help you start; availability changes over time, so if you can't find yours, just ask, we'll be honest about the makeup of any town we place people in.

— YOU WON'T ARRIVE TO STRANGERS

Trusted partners & finding your community

Settling somewhere new is about more than a job. We've built relationships with people and services we rate, and few things make us happier than helping a family find their community.

Partner we trust English & exams

Swoosh English

Friendly, focused OET and IELTS preparation for healthcare professionals, so the language test is the least of your worries.

Visit [Swoosh English](https://swooshenglish.com) (<https://swooshenglish.com>)

Relocation & shipping

Moving your life over

Trusted relocation and shipping partners who handle the logistics, from container to doorstep, so you can focus on your family.

Ask us for an introduction

Faith & worship

Your place of worship

Churches, mosques, temples, gurdwaras and faith communities near where you'll live. See our dedicated guide to faith and belonging in Australia.

Religion in Australia

Your people

National & cultural communities

South African, Filipino, Indian, British, Middle Eastern and many other communities are well established here. We're glad to connect you with families who've walked the same path.

Ask us for an introduction

A taste of home

Familiar groceries

From biltong and boerewors to spices and Asian supermarkets, we can point you to where to find the ingredients you'll miss most.

Ask us for an introduction

Online & local

Groups & networks

Facebook groups, parents' networks and profession circles where newcomers ask the small questions and find quick, kind answers.

Ask us for an introduction

These are relationships, not adverts. Tell us where you're moving from and what matters to your family, and we'll point you to the people we trust.

KEEP EXPLORING

Related guides
